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The Sunday EXPRESS



EYE

A poet for the ages

Veteran poet Gulzar on the home he lost, the city he found and all the words in between

DOWN IN JUNGLELAND
BY RANJIT LAL

What makes insect wings marvels of natural engineering



DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

FLYDUBAI MID-AIR SCARE



Crown Prince and Minister of Defence of the UAE, Sheikh Hamdan bin Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum, visits Captain Smit Machchhar at a hospital, Saturday. @HAMDANMOHAMMED/X

Oman Air had barred co-pilot from flying over extremist concerns

Samy Magdy, Sam Mednick & Cara Anna
Cairo, Tel Aviv, Jerusalem,
October 3

THE CO-PILOT accused of attacking the captain, Indian pilot Smit Machchhar, on an Israel-bound flydubai flight with an axe and trying to seize the controls was an Omani national who had been barred from flying on his country's airline because of concerns about extremist views, officials said Saturday. The co-pilot has been identified as Hamam al-Hammami,

INSIDE **PAGE 9**
NETANYAHU SPEAKS TO INDIAN PILOT: 'YOU ARE A HERO'

according to three people with knowledge of the situation, including a Gulf and Western diplomat, who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to the media.

The United Arab Emirates (UAE), which is leading the »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

● **HARYANA CM** Nayab Singh Saini begins his three-day visit to Singapore.

INSIDE
PUNJAB LGBTQ INFLUENCER SHOT DEAD, PROBE ON
PAGE 9

BID TO ADDRESS CONCERNS ON OVERREACH BY TAX AUTHORITIES

Arrest powers under GST regime likely to be removed

GST Council to discuss issue on Oct 7, Govt may bring amendment in Winter Session

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, October 3

MORE THAN nine years after its rollout in July 2017, the Goods and Services Tax (GST) regime is set to see a major overhaul — removal of arrest powers.

In a bid to boost investor sentiment and allay concerns about overreach by tax authorities, the upcoming GST Council meeting, on October 7, will take up the proposal to decriminalise offences under the indirect tax regime, two persons

aware of the development told *The Indian Express*.

The Centre and the states are learnt to have held several meetings over the last eight-nine months, including involvement at the top levels of the Union government, to reach a broad consensus on removal of the arrest provisions under GST, which were being seen as a major impediment »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Throwback to VAT

If the power to arrest is removed, the GST regime, in a way, will be similar to the Value Added Tax regime that existed before the rollout of the indirect tax regime in July 2017 and did not have any provisions for arrest.

Private sector must lead investment cycle, including R&D, says FM

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, October 3

FINANCE MINISTER Nirmala Sitharaman has called on the private sector to be the driver of investments, including in Research & Development (R&D), saying that with global uncertainty now a "standing condition", the coming years demand preparation. She added that the resilience being displayed by the Indian economy now has been built "layer by layer" since 2014, with fiscal prudence giving continuity to the government's development commitments.



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman at Kautilya Economic Conclave in New Delhi. PTI

"Raising both the scale of investment and private sector participation is essential to strengthening our innovation »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

MORE REPORTS, **P 6, 13**

In tit-for-tat move, India, Pak summon top envoys

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, October 3

A DAY after the Border Security Force (BSF) killed two suspected Pakistani intruders along the International Border in Punjab's Tarn Taran district, India and Pakistan summoned each other's Charge d'Affaires and lodged "strong protests" on Saturday.

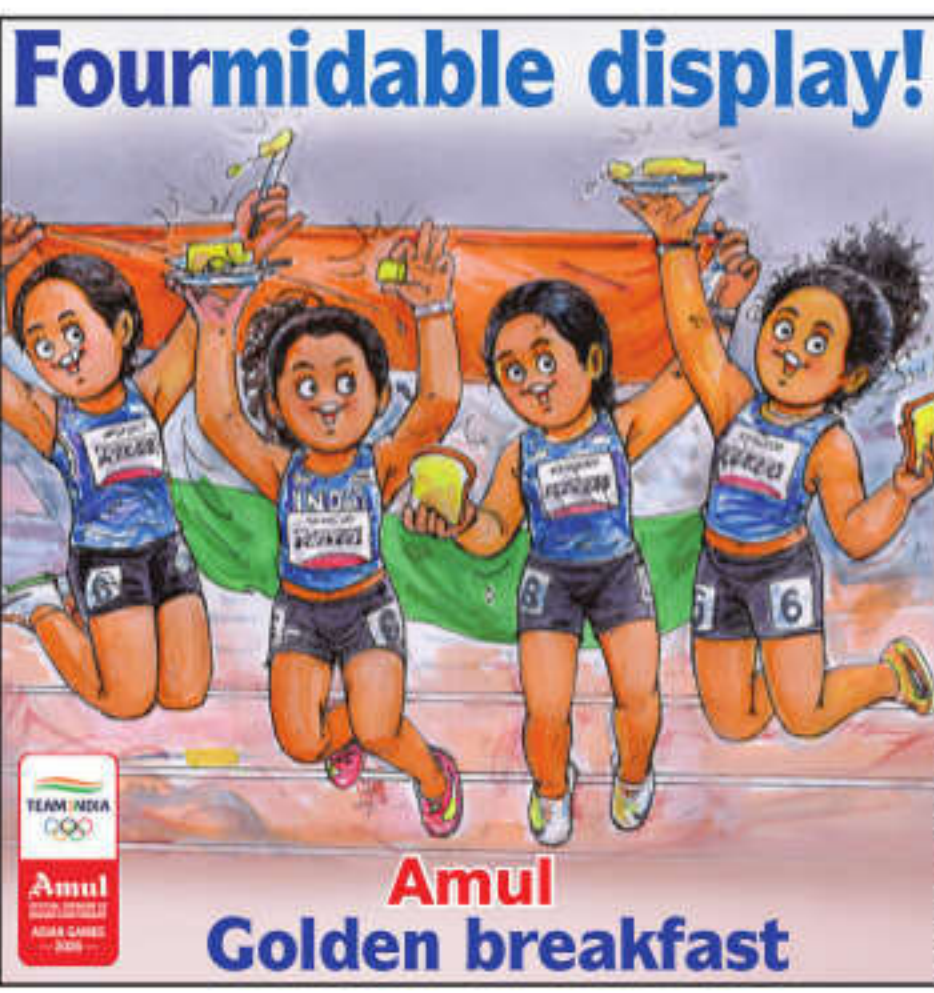
While India protested over the "continued facilitation of illegal cross-border infiltration", Pakistan claimed the two who were killed were "unarmed civilians". »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Teen archer scripts history with recurve gold, beats world champ



Mihir Vasavda
Okazaki, October 3

WHEN KUMKUM Mohod was born in 2009, South Korea had already spent two decades ruling women's recurve archery. When she picked up a wooden bow in 2018, Korea had six straight Asian Games team titles and Olympic champions in its ranks. On Saturday, at her first Asian Games, the 17-year-



17-year-old Kumkum Mohod at the Asian Games, Saturday. OLYMPICS.COM/AINAGOG: WITH LAST-MINUTE GOLD RUSH, INDIA SET TO FINISH FOURTH IN MEDAL TALLY, **PAGE 16**

old tore through that reign of dominance, one Korean at a time, and then shot the final arrow into the 10-ring to become an Asiad champion. She »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Shri Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



Shri Mohan Charan Majhi
Chief Minister, Odisha



Golden Glory for India

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SPORTS & YOUTH SERVICES DEPARTMENT, GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA



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Naval exercise

Indian and Philippine navy personnel aboard an Indian Navy ship during the ASEAN-India Maritime Exercise 2026 under the theme 'Anchored in Trust, United at Sea', in Philippines on Saturday. PTI

Abducted, killed after sharing property plan: Five held for Lucknow double murder

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, October 3

MONTHS AFTER he expressed interest in buying a property worth around Rs 60 lakh, a 45-year-old assistant nursing superintendent at King George's Medical University (KGMU) in Uttar Pradesh's Lucknow was allegedly abducted for ransom and killed after the demand was not met. A friend who was with him was also killed, and their bodies were later dumped in the Ghaghra River in neighbouring Sitapur, the police said.

The Lucknow police on Friday arrested five people for alleged involvement in the incident. A search operation is underway to trace the bodies.

The police identified the victims as Lucknow-based Pawan Kumar Garg, who was from Karauli in Rajasthan, and his friend, Sachin Vishwakarma, 26. The accused—Lucknow residents Nitin Mishra, 38, Avnish Kumar Maurya, 38, Prakash Singh, 24, Suraj Singh, 24, and Mohit Singh, 26—did odd jobs for a living. Nitin and Suraj have one criminal case against them, while Prakash Singh has two, the police said.

Amit Kumar Anand, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Lucknow, said the accused had confessed to the crime.

According to the police, on September 29, Pawan's nephew, Sanjay Garg, filed a missing person's complaint, saying Pawan had left his house in his car around 8 pm on September 27 without informing anyone and had not returned.

The next day, the police recovered Pawan's car in Sitapur district. While examining CCTV footage, toll plaza records, etc., the police spotted Pawan's car alongside another vehicle. The vehicle registration details helped them identify its occupants, Shivanand Mishra, Station House Officer, Madiyaon police station, said. All five accused were allegedly in the car.

The police later registered a kidnapping case. On October 2,

all five accused were arrested from Bhiithauli crossing, the police said.

During the investigation, the police learnt that Pawan knew Nitin, who is involved in the property business. Pawan allegedly told Nitin he had around Rs 60 lakh and was looking to purchase land, and asked him to show a suitable property. On learning of the money, the accused allegedly hatched a plan to abduct Pawan and demand a ransom. According to the police, on September 27, Nitin allegedly called Pawan and asked him to come to a place in the Madiyaon area. When Pawan arrived along with Vishwakarma, they were allegedly asked to go to New Fauji Dhaba in Lucknow's Itaunja area. Nitin and his associates joined them. The group drank alcohol and ate dinner, after which an argument allegedly broke out between Pawan and Nitin.

The accused allegedly forced Pawan and Vishwakarma into a vehicle and took them to an under-construction house belonging to Nitin in Itaunja, where they were held captive in separate rooms, the police said. The accused allegedly demanded Rs 50 lakh from Pawan as ransom. Meanwhile, Nitin reportedly took Pawan's car and parked it at a dhaba in Sitapur, before returning.

The police said the accused allegedly assaulted the two men again, repeating their demand for Rs 50 lakh. Pawan refused, saying he had no money.

According to the police, on September 28, realising Pawan would not pay the ransom and fearing that releasing him and his friend would lead to the police being informed, the accused allegedly strangled the men using ropes. Later that evening, they allegedly transported the bodies to Chalhari Ghat and threw them off a bridge into the water. The police said they have recovered Pawan's chain, ring, driving licence, photocopy of his Aadhaar card and a bank statement. Two cars allegedly used in the crime have also been seized.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Arrest powers under GST likely to be removed

for traders and businesses. The move is viewed as urgent as several arrests of high-ranking functionaries were made in recent times under the GST provisions that were termed by industry leaders as an overreach.

For intentional frauds and deceit under GST, the authorities will proceed with prosecution and arrests will be through the country's criminal code, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, a source said.

"The consultations had been going on since the last eight-nine months. The feedback from businesses about the arrests has been taken into account to move ahead with this discussion. The GST Council will take up the matter and the final decision will be taken after that, following which there will be legislative changes to allow removal of arrest provisions under GST laws," said a source.

After the rollout of GST in July 2017, authorities have grappled with multiple instances of frauds, involving broadly similar modus operandi. Typically, such cases involve fake identities or mule accounts to undertake fraudulent GST transactions in a bid to avail input tax credit, or fake bills without actual supply of goods. Many suppliers also undervalue their final goods and show purchase of raw materials at lower rates. Or, they supply taxable goods and services without due payment of GST to the central and state governments.

In 72,393 cases of GST offences from 2021-22 to 2024-25, 887 arrests were made by central GST formations. The arrests by state authorities will be in addition to this number.

Under the Central GST Act, non-compliance can result in penalty under Section 122, in-

terest under Section 50, and recovery of tax. However, violations involving deliberate intent to evade tax attract arrest and prosecution under the criminal provisions of the CGST Act.

Section 69 of the CGST Act provides for the power to arrest after approval by the Commissioner. Sub-section (1) provides that where the Commissioner has "reasons to believe" that a person has committed any offence related to fake invoices, fraudulent availment of input tax credit, he may, by order, authorise any officer of central tax to arrest such person. The "reasons to believe" have to be backed by credible material and evidence, and mere suspicion is not sufficient, with all the reasons required to be recorded in writing.

According to sources, after the GST Council discusses the issue at its upcoming 57th meeting slated on Wednesday, the Centre is expected to bring in an amendment in the Winter Session of Parliament to enable the removal of arrest powers.

Industry experts said arrests had become a harassment tool, especially in the services sector, including banking and insurance, and would often be deployed as a bargaining tool for

businesses to pay penalty in order to avoid prolonged legal battles. An official said the removal of arrest powers would be a taxpayer-friendly measure and remove any perceptions of fear and harassment.

The concern about arrest powers under GST laws is not new. It was flagged by several states in the early meetings of the GST Council, even before the 2017 rollout of the indirect tax regime.

In the fifth GST Council meeting held in December 2016, the Maharashtra Additional Chief Secretary had observed that the power of arrest and confiscation was not in tune with the concept of ease of doing business, according to the minutes of the meeting. A minister from West Bengal had said that under VAT law, there was no power of arrest and that First Information Report (FIR) could be lodged only with the police, and it may not be prudent to give such powers to the tax authority.

The Commissioner, GST Council, had said that under GST, the provision of arrest was highly restricted and the power could be exercised only where combined evasion of duty was Rs 2 crore or more and where offence was very severe -- where supplies were made

without any invoice; invoice was made without any supply; tax collected but not paid to the government; tax collected in contravention of provisions of the GST Act but not paid to the government; and taking input tax credit without receiving goods and services.

An official document from the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) stated that in the administration of taxation, the provisions for arrests are created to tackle the situations created by some unscrupulous tax evaders.

"To some, these may appear very harsh, but these are necessary for efficient tax administration and also act as a deterrent and instill a sense of discipline. The provisions for arrests under GST law have sufficient inbuilt safeguards to ensure that these are used only under authorisation from the Commissioner. Besides this, the GST law also stipulates that arrests can be made only in those cases where the person is involved in offences specified for the purposes of arrest and the tax amount involved in such offence is more than the specified limit," it said.

The government has been moving towards decriminalisation of offences on the direct tax side as well. The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) had, in September, removed arrest and detention provisions from the tax recovery rules with retrospective effect from April 1, 2026, barring tax officials from undertaking arrest in case of tax default. In a notification dated September 17, the CBDT had brought in Income-Tax (Fourth Amendment) Rules, 2026, which also removes "arrest and detention" from the tax recovery rules in case of death of the defaulter.

Sitharaman

capacity," Sitharaman said, noting that India's expenditure on R&D is only 0.83% of GDP, less than a third of the average of 2.7% for member countries of Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD). Of the R&D expenditure of 0.83% of GDP, the Indian private sector's share is only a third or so. Sitharaman was speaking on the first day of Kautilya Economic Conclave, organised by the Institute of Economic Growth and the Ministry of Finance. Her comments assume importance as recent economic data has led economists to point out that private investment has begun to take hold.

India's GDP grew at an unexpectedly fast rate of 7.8% in the April-June quarter, aided by a sharp 11.9% growth in Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF), a proxy for investments, compared with 5.8% growth in the first quarter of 2025-26. Without adjusting for inflation, or in nominal terms, GFCF growth in April-June was a sharp 20.4%, helping increase its share in GDP to 34.3%. It stood at 31.4% in April-June 2025.

While much of the focus over the last few years has been on getting the private sector to invest more, a pick-up in credit growth since the middle of 2025 is being widely seen as a sign of the non-government capex cycle taking off. As at the end of August, banks' non-food loans were up almost 19% year-on-year.

Referring to Kautilya's Arthashastra, the Finance Minister said the book places the treasury at the base of statecraft, with the lesson being that a state that "guards its fi-

nances in calm years retains the freedom to act when conditions turn".

"We need to keep building resilience as we go along; it is not a one-time exercise," she added.

The government has pursued reforms in taxation, finance, insolvency, business regulation, infrastructure planning, and public administration, she said. And while the process has been gradual, the ambition has been "transformational", with the foundations reinforcing one another.

"The next stage is to convert these capacities into higher productivity, better employment and wider opportunity -- so that more citizens, enterprises and regions can contribute to, and benefit from, India's development towards 2047," Sitharaman said.

Apart from private sector leading investments, Sitharaman also said there were several other priorities to prepare for the coming years. These include structural autonomy in strategic inputs, as strategic resource security "sits at the centre of macroeconomic policy".

Further, global openness remains important, Sitharaman said, adding that a more resilient global economy will need countries to diversify partnerships, keep markets open, honour commitments, and work together to keep trade stable and predictable to the extent possible.

"Equally important, the global financial architecture must reflect the economies where growth now lies," she said, arguing that the work on strengthening multilateral development banks should translate into "larger, faster and more predictable long-term finance for developing economies".

Oman Air had barred co-pilot from flying over extremist concerns

investigation, said the co-pilot attacked with the cockpit's crash axe and tried to take control of the sharply plummeting plane in a "terrorist attack" Wednesday. His actions nearly crashed the flight with 182 people on board before passengers and others rushed in and subdued him.

"Investigations into the incident involving flydubai flight FZ1073 found that the co-pilot had attempted to carry out a terrorist attack," Prosecutor General Hamad Saif Al Shamsi said in a statement carried by the UAE's state news agency.

Separately, a regional official and a person familiar with the matter said the co-pilot had been barred from flying by Oman over concerns he had adopted extremist views. The official said he was moved to an administrative job at Oman Air. Both spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the on-

going investigation. They gave no details about the alleged extremist views.

The co-pilot was later hired by UAE-based airline flydubai, the person said. It was not immediately clear to what extent the co-pilot was vetted. The Gulf diplomat said he had undergone standard security checks before being hired, but it appears that the checks focused on whether he had been convicted on criminal charges and didn't go deeper into examining his background for potential signs of radicalization.

The regional official also said security agencies from four regional countries were working to establish the co-pilot's motives, aided by the United States and other Western governments. The Gulf diplomat said investigations were trying to establish whether the co-pilot acted alone or "has any connection with any extremist

groups."

The regional official said the co-pilot was born in the UAE and his mother is Syrian. He obtained Omani nationality from his father, also an Omani national. The regional official also said the co-pilot had traveled to Syria, with no further details.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Friday said the co-pilot had undergone "Islamist radicalization," but provided no evidence. There was no immediate comment Saturday from Israel's government.

A flydubai spokesperson said in an email that the airline could not comment beyond its official statements and acknowledged "there are many questions at this stage." There was no immediate comment from Oman Air, and Oman's government has said nothing publicly in response to re-

peated questions since the incident.

In a statement to the AP, Royal Air Maroc, Morocco's national carrier, said the co-pilot "completed a three-month theoretical training period with the airline in 2025, as part of the pre-employment process. At the end of this training period, his application was not selected for employment." There were no further details.

Keith Coles, a spokesperson for Buckinghamshire New University in England, told the AP that al-Hammami previously completed a distance-learning course in aviation management there but "did not undertake any pilot training." There were no details on the timing.

Little else was immediately known about the co-pilot's background. His Instagram account was active until the day of the flight and then deleted. The new details raised ques-

tions about how thoroughly flydubai vets potential employees, and how the co-pilot's presence on a flight filled with Israeli passengers got past Israel's strict security protocols.

Israel's government has said it has agreements with foreign carriers to keep pilots of nations without diplomatic ties from flying there. Israel and Oman don't have formal diplomatic relations. The UAE government has earned a reputation for effective measures against extremist activities but has bristled in the past over criticism of security lapses.

Airlines are generally required to carry crash axes in the cockpit that could be used in an emergency to break open a window to escape or break open a panel to access a fire.

The captain, who was badly wounded in the axe attack, has said he used his remaining energy while being attacked to

unlock the cockpit door, allowing people who had noticed alarmingly unusual sounds to come in, tackle the co-pilot and stabilize the flight while passengers screamed.

(PTI Adds: Indian pilot Smit Machchhar is "recovering well" and remains under "excellent medical care", the Indian Embassy in the UAE said on Saturday. Machchhar managed to open the cockpit door despite his injuries, allowing passengers and crew to overpower the co-pilot.)

The plane made an emergency landing in Saudi Arabia after a descent so extreme that part of the rudder was torn away, and aviation experts have marveled that it didn't crash. Flydubai has said crew travelling on the plane helped to stabilize the plane and land. They have not yet been publicly identified.

AP

Rajasthan HC cites Gandhi, denies bail to five in Kanhaiya Lal case

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, October 3

THE RAJASTHAN High Court on Saturday denied bail to five accused in Udaipur's Kanhaiya Lal Teli murder case, invoking Mahatma Gandhi's words that "terrorism and deception are weapons not of the strong, but of the weak".

A Bench of Chief Justice Sanjay Agrawal and Justice Sameer Jain denied bail applications of Wasim Ali, 34, Muslim Khan, 43, Mohsin Khan, 27, Mohammad Mohsin, 34, and Asif Hussain, 25, saying that "we find that the gravity of the offence, the specific roles attributed to the appellants in the larger criminal conspiracy, and the heinous nature of the terrorist act disentitle the accused-appellants to the benefits of bail".

On June 28, 2022, two people — Mohammed Riyaz Attari and Ghous Mohammad — had allegedly posed as customers and hacked to death Kanhaiya Lal Teli at his shop in Udaipur over a post shared by him on social media in support of Nupur Sharma, a BJP spokesperson who was suspended for her objectionable remarks about the Prophet during a live television debate.

The Bench also quoted a poem by Ramdhari Singh Dinkar on tolerance and, in prefatory remarks, said: "The seat of a judge is surrounded by an invis-

ible, yet crushing weight, the weight to protect the rights of the citizens and people of this country which are enshrined under the Constitution of India".

"The paradigm of bail shifts entirely when the crime in question is not aimed at an individual, but at the very soul of the nation," the Bench said, adding: "Terrorism is not merely an assault on a physical body; it is a calculated, theatrical assault on the psychological sovereignty of the country. Its ultimate objective is not just to commit an offence, but the assassination of peace. It seeks to replace the 'Rule of Law' with the 'Rule of Fear'".

The NIA had filed a charge sheet, and the trial court framed charges against the five accused in 2024. They have been in judicial custody since their arrest in the days and weeks following the murder. They had filed bail applications before a Special Court, which had rejected their pleas in October and November 2024.

Representing the accused, Syed Saadat Ali and others primarily contended that "there is no cogent evidence on record to demonstrate that the accused were present in or around the vicinity of the deceased's shop" during the relevant period leading up to the incident, specifically between June 10 and June 28, 2022.

Next, they said that there is no evidence on record to suggest

that the accused "had sent any message, voice note, or text on any WhatsApp group that could be construed as hurting the religious faith of any community or promoting enmity".

They also relied on bail granted to two other accused, Farhad Mohammed and Mohammed Javed, by the trial court and by the High Court "on the exact same set of charges as framed against the present accused-appellants".

They also said that the accused have been in custody for over four and a half years and that "the trial will take its own considerable time... although the charge-sheet was filed on 22.08.2022 and charges were framed in early 2024, the trial is far from conclusion".

Senior counsel Raja Thakare, appearing on behalf of the National Investigation Agency, said that the five accused "played an active, indispensable, and integral role in the commission of the alleged crime".

Citing a Supreme Court judgment, Thakare and others said that the court is "not required to conduct a mini-trial or weigh the evidence meticulously at the bail stage. The Court must look at the material provided by the investigating agency at its face value, and if it discloses reasonable grounds for believing the accusation to be prima facie true, bail must be rejected".

Archer

made history by becoming the first Indian recurve archer to win an individual gold medal at the Asian Games.

Mohod was only nine when she first held a bow. "I didn't think much back then," she said. "I just aimed at the target, tried to score, and chased points." The ambitions came later, as the scores improved. "As I kept doing it and improving, I started dreaming bigger."

And somewhere along the way, the teenager who once simply chased points became good enough to chase down the names she had grown up admiring. Kang Chae-young was one of them. Mohod was in awe of how the South Korean, a former Olympic and world champion, released the bow with precise movements.

On Saturday, she couldn't care less for reputations. Mohod first shocked Kang Chae-young 6-4 in the quarterfinals, and overcame China's 2025 World Championships silver medalist Zhu Jingyi 6-2 in the semifinals.

Then came Oh Ye-jin, a Korean who had already helped her country to team silver the previous day. Oh Ye-jin took the opening set 29-27 after Mohod finished with an eight, and the Korean moved 3-1 ahead after they shared the second. Mohod responded with a perfect 30 in the third, only to fall 3-5 behind after the fourth when another eight left her chasing the match.

"When I hit an 8," Mohod explained, "I told myself to reset. My focus was drifting toward the arrow, so I reminded myself to

cream, something she has not touched since arriving at Asian Games camp on September 11 because she had decided to stay disciplined towards her goal.

Mohod was one of her biggest weapons — speed. "She can shoot fast," Tshering said. "If she holds more, the arms will vibrate. Her rhythm and process is very quick."

On average, Mohod takes just two or three seconds to aim and release. That rhythm was tested in the final when she dropped an eight at a crucial moment. But her response showed she had something that many Indian archers before her didn't. "She has a lot of guts. Outside the archery field, she is very shy. But on it, she transforms completely," Tshering said. "Her results are proof." And those results have come against the very archers India had spent decades chasing. South Korea had won the women's recurve team gold at every Asian Games from 1998 to 2022. On Friday, India ended that run. A day later, Mohod beat another Korean in the individual final. At 17, she's done what generations of Indian archers could not.

focus on my shooting form instead of the result."

She returned to the shooting line and fired a perfect score of 30 to force a single arrow shoot-off. The Korean shot an eight. Mohod shot a 10. In the stands, recurve archer Yashdeep Bhogae, who won a team silver on Friday, sighed: "Ghatk."

India's recurve coach, Sonam Tshering, was, however, barely surprised. Behind the glare of cameras, he had seen Mohod do the less glamorous things right: she was always at training, punctual, obedient and disciplined. Then there was the thing that has become one of her biggest weapons — speed. "She can shoot fast," Tshering said. "If she holds more, the arms will vibrate. Her rhythm and process is very quick."

On average, Mohod takes just two or three seconds to aim and release. That rhythm was tested in the final when she dropped an eight at a crucial moment. But her response showed she had something that many Indian archers before her didn't. "She has a lot of guts. Outside the archery field, she is very shy. But on it, she transforms completely," Tshering said. "Her results are proof." And those results have come against the very archers India had spent decades chasing. South Korea had won the women's recurve team gold at every Asian Games from 1998 to 2022. On Friday, India ended that run. A day later, Mohod beat another Korean in the individual final. At 17, she's done what generations of Indian archers could not.

India, Pak summon envoys

The Pakistani diplomat in Delhi was summoned hours after Islamabad summoned the Indian official there.

"The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) today summoned the Chargé d'Affaires of the Pakistan High Commission to lodge India's strong protest over the continued facilitation of illegal cross-border infiltration from Pakistan. India also categorically rejected the baseless and motivated allegations regarding an incident in the Ferozepur sector, Punjab, along the International Border on October 2, 2026," the MEA said in a statement.

It said the "Pakistani side was informed that three individuals infiltrated into Indian territory and despite multiple warnings by BSF to return to Pakistan, continued to move towards the border fence. The BSF was compelled to engage them for posing an imminent security threat."

The MEA said the incident highlights a "clear pattern of repeated cross-border movement by armed narcotics syndicates operating from Pakistan. Government of Pakistan was urged to investigate these cross-border infiltration, drug smuggling activities and the complicity of Pakistan border guarding forces therein, and to take appropriate remedial measures."

It said Pakistan was further urged to "ensure respect for the

sanctity of the International Border, strictly observe relevant bilateral arrangements, mandate its forces to exercise effective control to prevent unauthorised movement from its side, and take definitive measures to prevent the recurrence of such incidents".

Meanwhile, the Pakistan Foreign Office said the Indian Charge d'Affaires was summoned to its Ministry of Foreign Affairs to "lodge Pakistan's strong protest over the killing".

"The BSF personnel resorted to unprovoked lethal force against unarmed civilians. Such use of force was wholly unjustified and grossly disproportionate, resulting in the tragic loss of two precious lives," it said.

It further said the incident amounted to a serious violation of fundamental human rights, including the right to life, and raised serious concerns regarding the protection of civilian life under international law.

It called upon the Indian side "to conduct an immediate, transparent and credible investigation" into the incident, take appropriate disciplinary and legal action against those found responsible, and formally communicate the findings and action taken to the Pakistani government.

WITH PTI INPUTS FROM ISLAMABAD

CM lays foundation of waste processing, biogas plants; inspects Okhla landfill

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 3

IN A move aimed at increasing Delhi's capacity to process fresh waste, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) is setting up three new waste-processing plants at Okhla, Singhola and Ghazipur, along with a 300-TPD (tonnes per day) biogas plant at Ghazipur. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday laid the foundation stones for the three plants and the biogas facility, virtually from the Okhla landfill site and carried out a site inspection as well.

Delhi generates around 13,500 tonnes of municipal waste every day, while MCD currently processes around 60 per cent of the waste generated in the city. The three new plants will add 2,900 TPD of fresh-waste processing capacity,



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Minister Ashish Sood during the inspection of the Okhla landfill site on Saturday. PTI

helping bridge the gap between the waste generated and the quantity being scientifically processed.

The Okhla plant will have a capacity of 1,400 TPD, while the Singhola and Ghazipur plants will process 800 TPD and 700 TPD, respectively.

MCD's recent survey ident-

ified approximately 125,000 cattle across Delhi, which generate roughly 1,500 tons of dung daily. MCD was directed by central and state authorities to intercept this waste and prevent it from entering city drains and polluting the Yamuna.

A 300-TPD biogas plant for biodegradable waste is being

set up at Ghazipur to prevent waste from entering and polluting Yamuna.

The projects are aimed at strengthening Delhi's fresh-waste processing infrastructure and preventing waste generated each day from adding to the burden of the existing landfills.

The civic body is also constructing two more decentralised fresh-waste processing plants with a combined capacity of nearly 3,000 TPD, which will be operational in the coming year, officials said. Biogas plants at Goyla and Ghoga are set to be operational in the next two months, they added.

Meanwhile, Gupta, during her inspection of Okhla landfill site on Saturday, reviewed the status of waste disposal, land reclaimed and the capacity of the new processing facilities. She di-

rected officials to make the new units operational at the earliest and at their full capacity.

The expansion of fresh-waste processing capacity comes alongside efforts to clear legacy waste from Delhi's three landfill sites. As per government figures, 217.17 lakh metric tonnes of waste have been disposed of from Okhla, Bhalswa and Ghazipur over the past 18 months. MCD officials said the Okhla and Bhalswa landfill sites are expected to be cleared within three months, while the target for clearing Ghazipur is December 2027.

Gupta said clearing the existing landfills would not be sufficient and the system for processing fresh waste generated every day needed to be strengthened to prevent new garbage mountains from forming.

Man falls to death from Noida skyscraper

Drishhti Jain
Noida, October 3

A 29-YEAR-OLD man died allegedly by suicide after he fell from a balcony on the 43rd floor of the Supernova Spira in Noida's Sector 94 on Saturday, police said.

The deceased person has been identified as a resident of Gurgaon who had checked into the building for a short rental

stay on Friday. Additional Commissioner of Police, Noida, Manisha Singh said.

The Spira tower is Noida's tallest building, part of Super-tech's Supernova project which is under construction on a plot adjacent to the Noida-Greater Noida Expressway.

Singh said police received a call regarding the incident around 11.30 am. A purported video of the incident shows

people standing on the balcony, appearing to try to save the victim before he falls off. An officer said preliminary inquiry found that the victim was under stress because of financial problems.

"He had been messaging his father for the past few days saying that he did not want to live anymore. He hadn't gone home for many days and had been staying at different places." the officer said.

'Model zero waste colony': From 300 homes in Chanakyapuri, garbage takes a different route

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, October 3

EVERY MORNING, as most of Delhi's garbage begins its journey out of homes and towards dumpsites, the waste from over 300 homes in Chanakyapuri takes a different route.

The process begins around 6.30 am.

Arjun, one of three garbage collectors hired by the D1 Block Residents' Welfare Association (RWA), collects waste from the D1 and D2 residential blocks and the Satya Sadan officers' flats. "We then put it in separate compartments in our bicycle cart," says the 30-year-old.

After finishing his round around 11 am, he says he takes the waste to the New Delhi Municipal Council's Material Recovery Facility (MRF) at Madhu Limaye Marg, 1.5 km away from the neighbourhood.

There, he hands over the wet waste for processing. He further segregates the dry waste into several variously labelled bins: PET bottles, cardboard, metal, aluminium can, paper and mixed plastic.

These homes are part of a model 'zero waste colony'.

For a little over a year, garbage from these homes — 800 kg to 1,200 kg wet waste and 250 kg of dry waste a day — has been collected, processed and recycled in and around the



The collected dry waste is separated in several bins at the Material Recovery Facility Centre. EXPRESS

neighbourhood, a process that's mandated under the Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026.

According to RWA member Shefali Chaturvedi, households segregate their waste into wet and dry before handing it over to Arjun.

From waste to compost and recyclables

At the facility, the waste is processed further.

Amit Kumar, Sanitary Inspector and in-charge of the MRF centre, says their primary focus is on processing wet waste. "The wet waste, a combination of waste from residences and the horticulture

waste, is first broken down into finer granules through a crusher," he says.

The horticulture waste — dry leaves and branches from the colony's parks and lawns — is collected by the NDMC's auto-tippers during the day.

The wet waste is then transferred to a rounder — a cylindrical, permeable wire container used for in-situ aerobic composting. There are 10 such rounders present in the facility.

It reduces to half its volume, and the compost is taken out to dry in the sun. A worker then sifts the dried compost through a mesh to filter out unwanted debris and coarse material.

The final compost pro-

duced is then given back to the residents to use in their gardens.

Kumar says it can take between two and four months for the waste to be composted, depending on moisture and temperature. "Sometimes, we also add enzymes, such as jaggery water or curd, which speeds up the process," he says.

As for the separated dry waste, Kumar says it is given to scrap dealers who take it to authorised recyclers.

Roadblocks to expansion

In June 2025, these three Chanakyapuri blocks were the first to be declared 'Anupam Colony', a zero waste certification tag by the NDMC as part of its decentralised, zero-waste neighbourhood initiative. A total of nine blocks have received this tag till date.

But can it be scaled up?

According to Rajiv Jain, Advisor of Sanitation and Solid Waste Management for the NDMC, the aim is to implement the initiative in all neighbourhoods under the civic body's jurisdiction but replicating the model is proving to be a challenge -- mainly due to space crunch.

"Space is an essential requirement to set up more compost plants, but this is not readily available," says Jain.

He adds that getting residents to segregate waste at source remains a challenge across the NDMC area. "They need to be sensitised, told multiple times to segregate the waste." The cost, however, is not an obstacle. He says this model is cheaper than the considerable expenses of processing mass waste.

"The facilities were set up with a cost of around 3.5 lakh. Earlier methods involved expensive dustbins and composting kits with high costs, whereas our model has low operational cost, no chemicals, and simple steel or wire rounders," Jain says.

Room for improvement

Back at the colony, Chaturvedi says more collection vehicles and separate garbage bins for segregation outside each house could make the process even smoother.

She adds that while most households are now segregating wet and dry waste, the NDMC has introduced a third category of 'hazardous waste' which is yet to be implemented completely.

"We are trying to sensitise the residents about it. Most residents are aware that they should keep hazardous waste with themselves until it is collected," she says.

Borewell ban before HC as groundwater extraction hits 212% of limit in Gurugram

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurugram, October 3

GURUGRAM IS extracting 43,263 hectare metres of groundwater a year against an extractable limit of 20,333 ha m — 212.77% of the limit. In view of this, environmental activist and lead petitioner Sunil Singh has proposed before the Punjab and Haryana High Court a complete ban on groundwater extraction, a freeze on new construction without an assured surface water supply and judicial oversight for restoring water bodies.

The proposals are part of a case that has been before the HC for nearly two decades. Singh had approached the court in 2008 against alleged rampant and unauthorised tubewell extraction by builders in developing sectors. The case has since involved the wider issue of groundwater depletion and restoration of water bodies in Gurugram.

The proposals come ahead of a review on October 5 — to be attended by members of the GMDA, HSPV and MCG as well as the petitioners, among others — after a division bench of Chief Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra and Justice Rohit Kapoor described the groundwater situation in Gurugram as "grim" on October 1. After the court was told that groundwater had plunged to 40 to 50 m across Gurugram, it had noted that annual groundwater extraction in the district was twice the replenishable resource.

"We expect the authorities to examine the issues threadbare

and to suggest appropriate measures as would ameliorate the worsening situation of groundwater in Gurugram. It is to be kept in mind that the present generation is only a trustee for the futures to come and if we loose natural resources like groundwater in the manner like it is happening, the future generation would have to face disastrous consequences," the High Court had said.

In his submission, Singh said, "It is suggested that all groundwater extraction through borewells in Gurugram, whether registered, permitted or unregistered, should be prohibited. All existing borewells should be identified, geo-tagged and sealed..., and all existing permissions/NOCs for groundwater abstraction should remain suspended during this period. No fresh borewell, renewal of permission or enhancement of the permitted quantity should be allowed."

Singh proposed that no fresh construction be permitted unless authorities demonstrate a sustainable source of water other than groundwater. The submission called for restoration of identified water bodies, and their feeder channels.

Citing a GMDA survey that has found 826 of 1,216 water bodies to be retrievable, the affidavit highlighted that "305 existing public water bodies covering about 393 acres and more than 140 natural low-lying water-collection areas covering about 412 acres, which have substantial potential for restoration & groundwater recharge".

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PROTEST AGAINST ELECTION COMMISSION

As activists try to return to Jantar Mantar, around 150 detained amid heavy security

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 3

FOR THE second consecutive day, protesters demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and raising concerns over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls were stopped from reaching Jantar Mantar, the designated protest site, on Saturday.

Around 150 people, including AISA national president Neha Bora, activist Yogendra Yadav, and senior advocate Prashant Bhushan were detained.

The police action drew a response from Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, who alleged that there were allegations of misconduct with women protesters during Saturday's demonstration.

In a post on X, Gandhi referred to a female journalist's allegation against a police officer. "And this isn't the first time — we've seen video evidence before of police officers engaging in disgusting misconduct with women," said Gandhi.

He said that Delhi Police comes under the Ministry of Home Affairs, and added that Union Home Minister Amit Shah should "answer for this".

After the journalist alleged that Delhi Police was not registering an FIR, several people allegedly squatted outside the Parliament Street police station. Later, a policeman told the gathering that the journalist's complaint has been received and a probe was underway.

The protesters had gathered near Patel Chowk and began marching towards Jantar Mantar, a day after around 550 people were detained while attempting to reach the designated protest site. Police had



denied permission for Friday's demonstration and imposed prohibitory orders in the New Delhi district.

Saturday's mobilisation followed a call by Bora after she was among those detained on Friday. Among those joining her were Congress leader Kapil Sibal, advocates Nitya Ramakrishnan and Pallav Sisodia, Bhushan and Yadav, besides members of student and civil society groups.

Police began detaining protesters as they gathered and attempted to move towards Jantar Mantar. Multiple layers of barricades were put up on roads leading to the area, while



At the site of the protest near Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

police and paramilitary personnel were deployed at several points.

Those detained were taken to different police stations across Delhi and later released, police said.

AISA members alleged that a male police officer manhandled Bora and that another officer abused her. The police, however, rejected the allegations.

Meanwhile, Delhi Police has registered three FIRs against unidentified persons in connection with the attempts to hold the demonstration on Friday. Two FIRs were registered at Parliament Street police station and one at Connaught

CPI MP writes to Shah over cops 'concealing' IDs during protest

New Delhi: CPI's Rajya Sabha member P Sandosh Kumar on Saturday wrote to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, flagging the issue of Delhi Police personnel "removing or concealing their identity tags and name badges before detaining or using force against protesters".

The letter comes a day after more than 500 protesters were detained while making their way towards Jantar Mantar.

In his letter, Kumar sought Shah's intervention into repeated use of violence, arbitrary detentions, manhandling and other unlawful practices by the Delhi Police while dealing with democratic protests. Kumar said he himself was detained on Friday.

ENS

FURTHER CUSTODY NECESSARY: COURT

ED gets Vatika promoters' remand for three more days

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurugram, October 3

A SPECIAL Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court in Gurugram on Friday extended the Enforcement Directorate's (ED) custody of Vatika Limited chairman-cum-managing director Anil Bhalla and promoter Gautam Bhalla by three days in an alleged Rs 154-crore money laundering case linked to plot transactions in Gurugram.

The Bhallas, arrested on September 28, were produced before Sessions Judge-cum-Special Judge (PMLA) Narender Sura after their initial four-day remand expired.

Seeking seven more days of custody on behalf of the ED, special public prosecutors Simon Benjamin and Atul Agarwal, along with Assistant Director Dilip Singh Shaktawat (IO), submitted that although statements of several individuals, including the accused, were recorded during the four-day custody, interrogation could not be concluded due to "paucity of time and bulky record".

The ED argued that custody was essential to confront the promoters with documentary evidence and with 10 other individuals acquainted with the case who have been summoned for recording statements. It said further custody was required to "unearth and trace the proceeds of crime" and verify the involvement of other persons in the alleged transactions.

Opposing the plea, the defence argued that ED had sufficient time to complete its interrogation and alleged that notices issued on October 1 summoning witnesses were intended "just to get the ED custody extended".

The defence also submitted

the accused had not been confronted with any of the individuals whose statements had been recorded during the four-day remand. Instead, they were questioned about extracts of statements and contractual agreements already in the ED's possession, it was alleged.

Maintaining that the probe is grounded in documentary evidence, including public documents, the defence urged the court to decline any extension.

Partly allowing the ED's application, Judge Sura said further custody of the accused was needed for the probe. "After perusing the record produced before this court, the nature of investigation conducted till date, and the fact that for the purpose of thorough investigation, some other persons have been summoned for making statements under Section 50 of the Act, which may be required to be put to the accused for clarification of the facts, further custody is necessary," the court said. The court directed that both accused be produced before it on October 5 at 4 pm.

The ED's probe, initiated in March on the basis of Delhi Police Economic Offences Wing FIRs, concerns allegations arising from plot transactions involving residential plots of Vatika India Next in Sectors 82 to 85 and Vatika India Next-2 in Sector 88A. The agency has alleged that land contracted for plots collected for between 2010 and 2012 was not substantially delivered. It has valued the allegedly undelivered plots at Rs 140.73 crore.

The second allegation concerns a 2024 agreement with Scaler Ventures for 165 plots in Vatika India Next-2, where 14 plots were allegedly sold to third parties without consent.

Six lanes to two: What Barapullah can learn from traffic solutions abroad



Traffic snarl at the Barapullah III stretch. TASHI TOBGYAL

Pragynesh
New Delhi, October 3

DID DELHI need another flyover?

Four days after the Barapullah Phase 3 flyover opened, the question is no longer just about the bottleneck at its merging point, where traffic from six lanes is forced into two.

It is about the larger idea of putting more traffic on flyovers in a city where congestion keeps shifting from one road to another.

While the project was originally scheduled for completion in 2017, construction delays pushed its opening to 2026. In these nine years, while numbers of vehicle rose significantly, East Delhi and the wider NCR also grew, changing vehicular movement between East Delhi, Noida, Ghaziabad and South Delhi.

The result: The new stretch is meeting an older, narrower road and the traffic has nowhere to go. Barapullah Phase 3 has six lanes, one in the Mayur Vihar direction and the others towards South Delhi. The six lanes merge into a three-lane carriageway. Ideally, the combined carriageway should have been five lanes wide. It is not and the traffic has to further merge into the two-lane Phase 2 flyover, with vehicles from all lanes competing for space.

This is the problem with flyovers, says urban practitioner Hitesh Vaidya, who used to be

associated with the National Institute of Urban Affairs. "A flyover is like shifting the traffic from the ground floor to the first floor," he said.

Other countries have tried different approaches.

In 2006, near Birmingham in United Kingdom, bottlenecks in a stretch was solved using a dual system: Hard Shoulder Running (HSR) and Variable Mandatory Speed Limit (VMS). The systems ensured that no more lanes were made and no additional flyovers came up.

Under HSR, an emergency breakdown lane is opened to traffic when sensors detect congestion. VMS uses sensors to change speed limits according to traffic conditions, helping maintain gaps between vehicles and keep traffic moving.

A Transportation Research Board assessment found that the system reduced average travel time by more than 32%, while accident rates also fell.

In 2003, a six-lane highway over Cheonggyecheon river — used by around 160,000 vehicles every day — was demolished to revive the water body. The expectation was that the traffic would be in a deadlock.

But as per an article published in Behavioural Design Academy, the move saw a reduction in congestion with vehicular traffic reducing by over 45%.

According to experts, in

India, better planning was needed to solve the Barapullah fiasco. "A detailed survey needs to be done to assess the volume of traffic on the flyover and where it's moving. I don't know if they have been done properly. Because the plan was made over 20 years ago, it's not feasible now," said Prof P S N Rao, former director of the School of Planning and Architecture, Delhi.

Rao said that in India, the best possible solution is to bolster public transport rather than continuing to build flyovers. "People take the Barapullah because other routes, like through Nizamuddin or

ITO, are already choked. You create more alternative routes, more vehicles come. Now that we know that even Barapullah is not going to cut it, just take the Metro," he said.

"With flyovers, you are shifting traffic from one road to another. Instead of putting more resources to sort the flyover, we need to invest in more Metro lines. Most Western countries are doing it. Even the well-off take public transportation. Why not us?" he asked.

As of now, the solution with the Delhi Police is putting up barricades and an extra traffic light. Based on their drone survey, they are set to manually manage the merging of lanes using the traffic lights and personal, so that all lanes don't empty together, say officials.

Campus gate shut, food for protesters stopped: AUD students claim 'manhandled by guards'

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, October 3

AT THE gates of Dr BR Ambedkar University's Kashmere Gate campus, students gathered on Saturday with packed food in their hands. It was meant for students and PhD scholars who had been sitting in an indefinite protest for six days inside the campus with demands ranging from drinking water and classrooms to faculty shortages, student representation, and access to campus areas.

But those outside the gate alleged that security guards stopped them from entering the campus and they could not hand over food to the protesters.

Blessy, an MA student of Gender Studies, said students were stopped from entering the campus despite many having classes and exams. While alleging that the campus was closed to students on Saturday, she claimed that guards stopped students outside from passing food to the protesters and "manhandled" those trying to receive it.

The Public Relations Office of the university, however, said in a statement on Saturday that items being delivered at the gate beyond normal hours were checked by security personnel



Protest underway at Dr BR Ambedkar University on Saturday. EXPRESS

on safety grounds. It also said that its medical team was monitoring the protesting students and providing assistance.

It further said that the library, computer laboratories and some blocks had been closed for maintenance and that students had been informed in advance. "Students have manhandled security guards and the issue is already in cognisance of the Delhi Police. University security guards have not initiated any action on their own. Their role is limited to maintaining campus security as per standard protocol," the PRO office said.

Further, the AUD said that while it had designated a place

for peaceful protests, "students are sitting in the area close to library and classrooms, which is also adversely affecting other students". It said its Proctor's office had appealed to the protesters to move to the designated area.

Maintaining that it was in continuous dialogue with the protesters, the university said it had positively responded to their "permissible and legitimate demands".

The confrontation is the latest flashpoint in a protest that began with a five-point demand charter but has since widened into students voicing concerns about how the university is run.



At Supernova in Noida's Sector 94. GAJENDRA YADAV

Noida's Supernova society asks owners to give bachelor, student tenants one month's notice

Drishti Jain
Noida, October 3

HOMEOWNERS AT Supertech's Supernova in Noida Sector 94, who have rented their flats to students or bachelors, have been asked to give the tenants one month's notice and replace them, preferably with families, under new tenancy rules introduced by the apartment owners' association.

The association has also asked homeowners to refrain from renting flats to students and bachelors in the first place, and to prefer families, working professionals or members of any other "lawful category".

However, if the owners wished to continue with such a tenant, they may need to get their decision reviewed by the tenancy committee. "If the committee doesn't give the clearance to the student/bachelor, then the owner can't let out the property to the said student/bachelor and they have to get their premises vacated within a month from the date of notice from the said committee," said the policy issued recently.

On October 1, a video went viral on social media showing Tushar Sharma, a Sector 15 resident who allegedly operated a rented facility in Spira, a Supernova tower, arguing with a security guard after reaching the wrong gate. Sharma allegedly forced his way into the Supernova premises in his car.

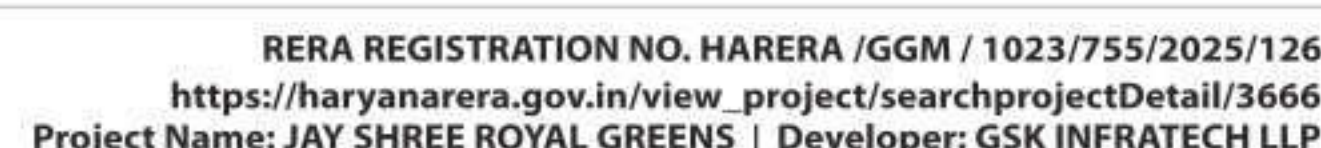
Noida Police later arrested him on preventive grounds, while his vehicle was seized and challans issued.

In the policy, the association noted complaints of increasing nuisance at Supernova East and West — a residential complex of around 500 flats — including playing of loud music, smoking and drinking. It also listed alleged illicit activities like drug consumption as well as running illegal call centres involved in online fraud and prostitution rackets.

Naresh Nandwani, adviser to the Supernova Apartment Owners' Association (SNAOA), said there had been several instances of flats being rented out for short-term stays.

Further, the 'Policy for Regulation of Tenancies, Occupancy and Resident Conduct, 2026' stated that an apartment cannot be occupied by a number of people inconsistent with its size or sanctioned residential use. The association said the provisions would help prevent the society from being "converted into a hostel".

The policy also seeks to regulate short-term and commercial use of residential premises.



(रजिस्ट्री के साथ फ्री-होल्ड आवासीय प्लॉट)



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Rahul launches ‘Satyagraha’ digital platform

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 3

CONGRESS MP and Leader of Opposition (LoP) Rahul Gandhi launched the ‘Satyagraha’ digital platform on Saturday, describing it as an initiative to consolidate issue-based protests unfolding across the country.

“Across the country, people are fighting for their rights and too often, fighting alone. Gen Z, students, farmers, Adivasis, Dalits, women — every struggle has its own story. But a lone voice is often easier to silence,” Gandhi wrote in a post on X.

The LoP invoked the ethos of ‘Bapu’ and made an appeal to the people to register their protests against the government on Satyagraha. “Bapu taught us that truth is our greatest weapon. But an even greater weapon is standing together with the truth. If you too are fighting against any injustice, share your story. It will take just two minutes,” he said.

He added, “We want to help organise these protests, put them together and work with you to see if we can help you resolve what you’re fighting for. Take a look at the Satyagraha website. Fill out the form. Enroll your movement, and we will try to see how we can support you. We’ll be in touch.”

Why Form 7 applicants in Karnataka are facing FIRs? BJP seeks review

Express News Service
Bengaluru, October 3

A Karnataka BJP delegation met Director General and Inspector General of Police (DG&IGP) M A Saleem on Saturday, urging a review of FIRs registered in connection with Form 7 applications during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The delegation was led by state BJP president B Y Vijayendra, former chief minister BS Yediyurappa and Leader of Opposition in the Assembly R Ashoka.

The BJP’s intervention comes amid the state chief electoral officer agreeing to initiate legal action against those responsible for allegedly filing bulk Form 7 applications to remove eligible voters. The controversy intensified after fresh instances of mass Form 7 submissions targeting alleged voter deletions surfaced a day after Chief Minister D K Shivakumar cited three FIRs registered over similar complaints.

In a memorandum submitted to DG&IGP Saleem, the delegation alleged that criminal cases were being registered against BJP workers and political activists for submitting Form 7 objections and claimed that the police machinery was being subjected to political pressure. It urged the police to ensure that criminal proceedings arising from the electoral roll exercise were based on evidence and due process.

The BJP said Form 7 is a

‘PAKISTAN’S PLAN TO ACQUIRE 5TH-GEN FIGHTER JETS CAUSE FOR WORRY’

Air Force needs to induct 36-40 aircraft annually, says Air Chief

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, October 3

THE INDIAN Air Force (IAF) needs to induct 36 to 40 aircraft annually to prevent its depleting fighter squadrons from falling below 30 and move towards the sanctioned strength of 42, Chief of Air Staff Air Chief Marshal A P Singh said on Saturday.

He also highlighted the ongoing efforts of the IAF to develop a robust beyond-visual-range (BVR) combat capability through the planned induction of the indigenous ASTRA and its variants of BVR air-to-air missiles, along with additional batches of foreign missiles offering longer ranges.

The IAF Chief made the remarks while addressing the media ahead of the 94th Air Force Day, which will be observed on October 8.

Responding to a question about the IAF’s fighter squadron strength, Air Chief Marshal Singh said the force could begin inducting 30 to 35 fighter jets annually “if things go as planned”.

Referring to HAL’s target of delivering up to 24 LCA Mk1A

aircraft to the IAF annually, he said even if HAL produces 20 aircraft a year and the Multi-Role Fighter Aircraft (MRFA) contract is finalised by the end of this year, the total annual induction would add up to approximately 32 aircraft.

The MRFA programme, under which the IAF would receive 12 aircraft annually, involves the proposed acquisition of 114 Rafale jets.

He said if the proposed contract to acquire 12 additional Su-30 aircraft is included, with six jets delivered each year, the annual induction could rise to between 30 and 35-40 aircraft, provided all the plans move forward as expected. “So, we are hoping that these things will happen and that we will be able to achieve the pace of growth we have set,” he said.

The IAF Chief said it is prudent to have a mix of three to four types of fighter jets in the force’s inventory, so that they can perform different roles effectively. He said in the near future, the IAF will have a healthy mix of LCA Tejas Mk 1A, LCA Mk 2, the French Rafales and the indigenous fifth-



Air Chief Marshal A P Singh

generation fighter jet — Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA).

Talking about reports of Pakistan moving to acquire China’s fifth-generation J-35 stealth fighter jet, Air Chief Marshal Singh said it is a cause for worry. “Is it a no-go situation? I wouldn’t agree with that. We possess the necessary capabilities... it is not just about a single platform, but about how it is integrated into the entire system.”

“Pakistan has possessed other platforms in the past, yet they haven’t been able to achieve anything significant with them during Operation Sindoor. Similarly, if we effec-

tively integrate the platforms we are purchasing and inducting, we should be able to counter this threat — at least for the time being.”

He also said there is a need to push the AMCA programme and take alternative decisions in case there is a delay in that. He also clarified that Russia has offered the Su-57, but no decision has been taken yet, even as he emphasised the need to consider the need for a fifth-generation aircraft “if our adversaries are getting a fifth-generation aircraft”.

Responding to a question from *The Indian Express* on how the IAF is working towards augmenting its BVR capability, the Air Chief said three variants — Astra and its Mk2 and Mk3 variants — are currently under production or in stages of research.

The Astra BVRAAM is already in production, while the Mk2 variant is midway through its R&D and the Mk3 is in the initial stages of R&D, progressing through research and development.

He said the IAF is also making efforts to procure additional batches of missiles with

longer ranges from foreign sources. India has been reportedly looking at procuring Russian R-37M ultra-long-range air-to-air missiles and additional batches of French Meteor Missiles.

Augmenting the BVR capability of the IAF has been in focus since Operation Sindoor. ACM Singh said the Astra, its variants and the additional foreign missiles will fulfil the immediate requirements of the IAF, adding that the development of the Astra Mk2 and Mk3 variants is progressing in the right direction, particularly in terms of ranges.

The first in the family, ASTRA Mk 1, has a range of 80 to 110 km. A more advanced version of the ASTRA Mk 1 — the ASTRA Mk 2 — has an enhanced range of 200 km.

Earlier this year, the DRDO had conducted a flight test of its Solid Fuel Ducted Ramjet (SFDR) technology for the ASTRA Mk 3, which could have a range of over 350 km.

He also said that while the IAF is growing the number of drones and loitering munitions, there is no need for a separate drone force.

EXPRESS special

10% left out of Uttarakhand’s final voter list, hope of inclusion intact

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
Dehradun, October 3

UTTARAKHAND MAY have published its final electoral roll after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR). However, the Election Commission of India’s order for a fresh exercise to identify voters who were on the pre — SIR roll but are missing from the current list means the process isn’t over yet.

This comes as just over 10% of the state’s 79.60 lakh voters have been deleted.

According to officials, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) have been directed to compare the two rolls, visit identified voters at home and facilitate their enrolment if they are found eligible. This comes after the ECI, under fire over the scale of deletions, directed 20 states and Union Territories where the exercise has been completed to run a “special drive” to enrol left-out voters.

The CEO office has also clarified that the declaration form used with Form 6 — the form to enrol voters on the list — during the SIR phase was specific to that exercise. During the non-SIR period, the forms prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, will be used.

The details of the post-SIR exercise are contained in a presentation prepared by the Chief Electoral Officer, Uttarakhand, for Saturday’s meeting with recognised political parties.



The final roll contains names of 37,37,701 men, 34,21,036 women and 212 third-gender electors. EXPRESS

Based on the Election Commission’s latest directions of September 29 and October 1, it says BLOs will prepare a list of electors who were present in the pre-SIR roll but do not figure in the current roll. They will then conduct house-to-house visits to ascertain the voters’ present status and, where eligible, facilitate their enrolment through Form 6.

The exercise will not be restricted to those whose names disappeared during SIR. During their house visits, BLOs will also facilitate Form 6 for left-out voters as well as first-time and young eligible voters. They have been asked to try to cover at least 20-25 identified electors every week so that the exercise can be completed in about a month.

The move comes as Uttarakhand on Saturday published its final electoral roll with 71,58,949 electors, after a claims-and-objections process that saw

1,29,872 new voters added and 1,04,708 names deleted according to the rules, the Chief Electoral Officer’s office said.

The state had 79,60,762 electors when the SIR began on June 8. The draft electoral roll published on July 14 contained 71,33,785 electors. The final roll, therefore, represents an increase of 25,164 over the draft, but remains about 8.02 lakh below the electorate at the beginning of the SIR.

The final roll contains 37,37,701 men, 34,21,036 women and 212 third-gender electors. It includes 72,656 voters in the 18-19 age group and 1,22,892 voters above the age of 80. The state has 12,543 polling stations.

The post-SIR exercise will also involve recognised political parties. The CEO’s presentation says BLOs will share the list of identified electors with recognised political parties, while the

lists, Form 6 applications and field-verification reports will be submitted to the Electoral Registration Officer. At the end of the exercise, EROs will share booth-wise lists with political-party representatives, providing another opportunity for eligible left-out voters to be enrolled.

The Election Commission has also directed the state to conduct targeted outreach among vulnerable groups. The CEO’s presentation says adequate help desks and special camps will be organised, as required, for people living in night shelters, workers, poor and homeless people. It also calls for a special campaign to enrol left-out and young or first-time eligible voters in states and Union Territories where SIR has been completed.

The October 3 action plan says district-level special camps and help desks are being planned by Electoral Registration Officers in accordance with the ECI’s September 29 and October 1 directions.

The fresh exercise follows the large reduction in the electorate recorded during the SIR. The CEO’s presentation shows that 8,26,977 electors were classified as “uncollectable (ASDD)”, accounting for 10.39 per cent of the electorate before the draft roll. Dehradun recorded the highest number of such electors at 1,86,008, followed by Udham Singh Nagar at 1,77,673 and Haridwar at 1,30,203.

India can be called a developed economy if development is inclusive, says V-P

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 3

VICE-PRESIDENT CP Radhakrishnan on Saturday underlined the importance of consensus and inclusivity, saying India could call itself a developed economy only if its development was inclusive.

Speaking at the inauguration of Kautilya Economic Conclave, 2026, Radhakrishnan said India was moving towards becoming a developed economy and that development should reach every section of society.

“We can call ourselves a developed economy if it is an inclusive development of everyone,” he said.

He emphasised the importance of policymakers understanding the ground realities of both micro and macroeconomic situations, saying China had understood the same.

“If we understand the ground realities of the village, we can know what we should do for the development of that village... When you want to make macroeconomic policies, then you have to understand the ground realities of the globe. That is where the success story of the Chinese is well-established. They understand the ground realities of both, and they have brought their nation to be the second largest economy of the world... Policy-



Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan

makers should always understand the ground realities...”

Speaking of the challenges being faced by economies today, he said consensus was important.

“In these times of flux, we need decisiveness embedded in consensus. We have to debate, we have to discuss and we have to come to a conclusion that is acceptable to everyone.”

Referring to the reforms undertaken by the Narendra Modi government over the past decade, including Jan Dhan accounts, direct benefit transfer and Goods and Services Tax, he highlighted financial inclusion.

“History proves the process of consensus-building helps reforms go forward... The process may sometimes be gradual and sometimes we may lose our patience also, but we should never show it outside... India’s experience of the last decade shows how inclusiveness is important... Inclusion can itself become an instrument of resilience,” he said.

Tariffs becoming policy instruments, sometimes weaponised: P K Mishra

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, October 3

THE PRINCIPAL Secretary to the Prime Minister, P K Mishra, on Saturday said tariffs, export controls and other restrictions are increasingly being used not only for conventional commercial objectives but also for strategic purposes, and these “instruments of economic policy are sometimes even weaponised”.

He said the future will belong to those who can be “steady without being closed, careful without being fearful, and ambitious without being naïve”, and India intends to be such a country.

Speaking at a session on ‘A World Priced for Risk’ during the 5th Kautilya Economic Conclave, Mishra said, “We are increasingly confronted, not merely with risk, but also with uncertainty... The events of this decade have brought this distinction into sharp focus. We have seen a pandemic disrupting production and mobility across the world, wars disrupting energy and food markets. Shipping routes and geographical chokepoints become sources of economic vulnerability. Export restrictions, sanctions and tariffs become

instruments of economic policy, even sometimes they are weaponised. Critical minerals, technologies and even financial infrastructure require a new strategic significance...”

Discussing risks associated with energy availability, Mishra said, “For decades the principal question for an energy importing country or energy importing economy was often price of energy. Today, there is another question — will the energy be available or can it reach us?”

“A disruption in a major shipping route can affect the price of crude oil thousands of kilometres away. Geography has, therefore, become an economic variable... The economic logic of globalisation was built around specialisation — produce where costs are lowest and move the goods efficiently across borders. The logic remains relevant and even powerful, but the experience of the pandemic, geopolitical conflict and more recent disruptions have highlighted another consideration: the cost of interruption. A supply chain that is efficient in normal times may be fragile if the single-node supplier or geography becomes unavailable,” he said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

● NCERT HISTORY TEXTBOOKS PRODUCED DURING THE UPA RULE HAVE UNDERGONE DELETIONS AND REPLACEMENTS UNDER MODI DISPENSATION, WHICH SEES ‘SECULAR’ AND MARXIST HISTORIANS AS IDEOLOGICAL ADVERSARIES

Marxist to Hindutva: How NCERT history book rows mirror a battle for India’s past

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, October 3

IN ITS newly released Class 9 social science textbook, Understanding Society — India and Beyond, the NCERT has in a chapter on medieval history focused on resistance local kings offered to “foreign invaders” — the Delhi Sultans and the Mughals — with only a cursory mention of the alliance between the Mughals and Rajputs.

This marks a break: for decades, medieval history textbooks did discuss battles but also discussed in detail instances of cooperation between the Mughals and Hindu princes, apart from pointing out that the medieval times saw the development of a composite culture in India with the mixing of Indo-Islamic influences.

The period being talked about is the same, but the interpretation of the past has under-

gone a discernible change.

Indian history as a modern discipline was first written by the British after conquering the land. Much research has gone into how this history framed India’s past.

Pointing out that colonial histories of India periodised the past as Hindu India, Muslim India and British India, historian Gyanendra Pandey argues that in so doing, colonial writers saw religion as the moving force in Indian history — something that they saw as the opposite of the “modern”, “secular” west. Significantly, modern India was not characterised as Christian India despite the British rulers being Christian — thus projecting them as people who could transcend religion as rulers and were thus “modern” in their outlook.

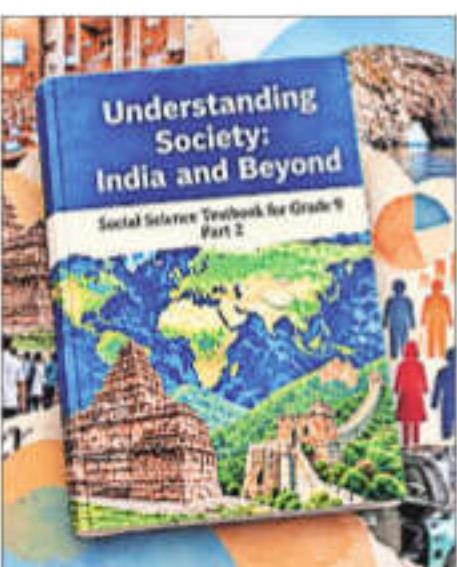
Indians, in contrast, were seen as intrinsically religion-driven. This also legitimised the presence of the British to

“civilise the natives”.

There are examples of this. In his History of British India written in 1817, James Mill saw a progression from a backward Hindu India to a more civilised Muslim India and then the most civilised British India — thus legitimising British rule and also seeking to drive a wedge between Hindus and Muslims. He also saw Muslims as “masculine” and Hindus as “effeminate”, and denied the existence of any composite culture in India.

After the Revolt of 1857, when Hindus and Muslims both rose in revolt against the British, V A Smith wrote a history of India where he portrayed “Muslim rule” as barbaric. Such history writing became one of the instruments of the Divide and Rule policy.

With the freedom struggle came a new writing of history, which argued that the mixing of Hindu and Islamic in-



New NCERT Class 9 social science textbook

fluences had created a composite culture in India. The idea was to frame Hindus and Muslims as co-travellers in the national journey rather than as adversaries. Historian Tara Chand, who wrote Influence of Islam on Indian Culture in 1936, was closely associated with this shift.

Not just historians but freedom fighters contributed to this reading. The core argument of Jawaharlal Nehru’s The Discovery of India is that while there were conflicts as outsiders came to this land, these were invariably followed by a grand resolution that set off creative developments.

Nehru was appreciative of Akbar but critical of Aurangzeb for “setting the clock back” through his policies that angered many local kings. Later works of “secular” historiography have also sought to defend Aurangzeb by showing him to be a complex personality.

From the 1950s began Marxist historiography in India, with D D Kosambi among the first well-known Marxist historians. Here, “secular historiography” underwent a change. While medieval times were culturally seen in much the same way as nationalists earlier had, Kosambi turned his critical gaze

on ancient India, demolishing what many Hindus considered their beliefs through a sharply “rational” lens.

In his 1962 book *Myth and Reality*, he took up several such beliefs, arguing that they were myths and not history.

The trend set off by Kosambi would emerge repeatedly among Marxist historians and those aligned with them, with historian D N Jha famously writing a book *The Myth of the Holy Cow* on beef eating in ancient India, thus suggesting that Hindu beliefs of the present were based on a myth.

After the Congress split in 1969, Indira Gandhi fell short of the majority mark in the Lok Sabha by about 45 seats. Given her shift towards the Left at this point — illustrated by the slogan “*Garibi Hatao* (eradicate poverty)” and policies such as bank nationalisation and abolition of

privy purses — she got the support of the CPI and some Independents to form the government.

“The CPI was delighted to join in, seeing Mrs Gandhi’s Left turn as an opportunity for expanding its own influence,” historian Ramachandra Guha writes in *India After Gandhi*.

At the time, the Left was the pre-eminent intellectual force, and not just in the country. Aligarh-based historian Saiyid Nurul Hasan, who was a Communist, was the Union Minister for Education, Social Welfare and Culture from 1971 to 1977. Many NCERT textbooks were authored by scholars with a background in the Left. JNU, set up in 1969, also had a Left slant primarily through its faculty appointments.

The BJP’s rise to power

under Atal Bihari Vajpayee saw the replacement of old NCERT history textbooks — authored by scholars like R S Sharma, Satish Chandra, Bipan Chandra and Arjun Dev — with books authored by those like Makkhan Lal, Meenakshi Jain and Hari Om.

The books, which drew criticism from many “secular” historians, were again replaced when the Congress-led UPA government was in power from 2004 to 2014. JNU historian Neeladri Bhattacharya was chief advisor to NCERT in the production of the new textbooks.

It is these textbooks that have undergone deletions and replacements under the Narendra Modi dispensation, which has seen “secular” historians in general and Marxist historians in particular as ideological adversaries.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Parliamentary panel reshuffle: TMC loses both chairperson posts

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, October 3

IN A reshuffle of heads of the Parliamentary Committees, the Trinamool Congress has lost both its chairperson berths owing to a group of its MPs switching camps after the recently concluded West Bengal Assembly elections. The chairpersons of six of the 24 Parliamentary Standing Committees were rejigged on Saturday.

The Parliamentary Committee on Commerce, which was headed by TMC Rajya Sabha MP Dola Sen, will now be headed by BJP Rajya Sabha MP Sudhanshu Trivedi. The Committee on Chemicals, which was headed by TMC MP Kirti Azad, will now be headed by Lok Sabha MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, who led the TMC rebel faction and claimed to have merged with lesser-known Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI).

Reacting strongly to the reshuffle, TMC Parliamentary Leader Derek O'Brien wrote a letter to Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan, saying that the "Parliament is being turned into a deep, dark chamber". The leader of the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC faction maintained that theirs is the third largest party in the Upper House, but is being "deprived" of a chairperson berth.

"In Rajya Sabha, the BJP is the largest party, followed by the INC (second largest) and AITC (third largest). And yet, the Chairpersons, which we held in 2024-25 and 2025-26, has been taken away. This is not the first time we have been treated in this manner! In 2019, when we were also the third largest party in Rajya Sabha, we were deprived. That was rectified a few years later and now it is back to square one," said the

TMC leader in his letter.

Other changes announced on Saturday include Congress Rajya Sabha member Digvijaya Singh being replaced by party colleague Mukul Wasnik to head the panel on education.

Meanwhile, the BJP has reshuffled three of its committee chairpersons, with party MP Brij Lal being replaced by party colleague Sujeet Kumar to head the committee on Personnel, Public Grievances, Law and Justice. Rajya Sabha member Brij Lal's term in the RS is set to end in November.

The BJP has replaced Lok Sabha MP Basavaraj Bommai with Shashank Mani to head the Labour, Textiles and Skill Development Committee. The third change that the BJP has made is in the Committee on Railways, with the party appointing its MP Sudhir Gupta instead of C M Ramesh.

Among those who have retained their chairpersonships include DMK MPs Tiruchi Siva and K Kanimozhi who will continue to head the Parliamentary Committee on Industry, and the Committee on Food, Consumer Affairs and Public Distribution, respectively.

Congress MPs Shashi Tharoor and Charanjit Singh Channi have also been retained as chairpersons of Committees on External Affairs, and Agriculture, respectively. Meanwhile, party MP Mukul Wasnik will continue to head the Committee on Education, Women, Children and Youth.

Samajwadi Party's Ram Gopal Yadav has also been retained as the chairperson of the Committee on Health and Family Welfare.

The leaders of some key BJP allies such as the JD(U), Shiv Sena and TDP have also been retained as heads of different Parliamentary Committees.

‘Not the time for mandir-masjid’: BJP shifts tack to development in West Bengal bypoll

70% of Rejinagar population is Muslim; Humayun Kabir, who won earlier this year with nearly double the votes of his BJP rival, says facing ‘intimidation’

Ravik Bhattacharya
Rejinagar, October 3

ON A small makeshift stage in Begunbari area of Rejinagar, BJP Bengal president Samik Bhattacharya stands beside party candidate Shankharavh Sarkar, as others jostle for space. The public meeting has come at the end of an impressive road show involving over a hundred motorcycles.

The crowd gathered around the stage is predominantly Muslim, with others looking on from balconies and rooftops. "In the last elections, our candidate lost by a huge margin. Minority voters were not with us. But this election is different," says Bhattacharya.

Days after Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said that the October 6 bypolls were a "test" for the minority community, and that they should come with the BJP. Bhattacharya says: "Eighty percent of Muslims stay in villages, and their monthly income is Rs 5,000 or lower. Participation of Muslims in government jobs is also low. The situation needs to change."

While the BJP government is accused by opponents of stoking anti-minority sentiments in West Bengal to win this year's Assembly elections and to consolidate its hold in the state since then, for the bypoll in Rejinagar where nearly 70% of the population is Mus-

lim, the party has changed its narrative to development. It is also directly reaching out to Muslims, in a manner rarely seen before in the state.

Bhattacharya, seen as the "moderate" face within the state BJP, says: "In these last six months under our government, has there been a single riot?... This is not the time to do Babri Masjid-Ram Mandir. For the next 20 years, it will be our government both at the Centre and in the state. You will have to stay with us. You will have to choose."

A day later, during his tour of the constituency, Adhikari underlines the same at a public meeting in Shaktipur.

Bhattacharya's reference to Babri Masjid is deliberate. In the April 2026 Assembly elections, the Rejinagar seat was won by Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP) leader Humayun Kabir, who laid the foundation for a replica of the mosque in the constituency.

Kabir got nearly double the votes of his BJP rival, getting 51.62% of the votes, to the BJP's 27.02%, and the TMC's 17.43%.

The Rejinagar bypoll was necessitated as Kabir resigned from the seat and retained the other constituency he won from, Nouda.

Kabir's son Gulam Nabi Azad is the AJUP candidate for the Rejinagar bypoll now. There is little sign of him though in the constituency, with Kabir claim-



West Bengal BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya campaigns ahead of Rejinagar bypoll on October 6. EXPRESS

ing "intimidation" by the BJP administration, including slapping of cases, and saying the AJUP would campaign only online and on social media.

With the BJP wooing Muslims and Kabir away, the contest could go either way - particularly as the anti-BJP corner is crowded. Apart from Kabir, who used to be in the Trinamool Congress before floating the AJUP ahead of the Assembly polls, it includes the Congress, CPI(M) and the two TMC factions. All have put up candidates from the Muslim community.

At the site of Kabir's Babri Masjid replica, along National Highway 10, construction is on, with earthmovers at work and bricks lying in a pile. "Around Rs 10 crore have come in as donations," says Kabir, sitting in a small office at the site.

He is "being forced to take a backseat", says the AUJP leader, who seems subdued and far removed from his once firebrand image. "Apart from fresh cases against me, old cases are being revived against my party leaders. Twenty-four

of them have been arrested. Twelve of us got bail, but police kept calling me for interrogation, and harassing my followers. That is why I decided that neither my son nor I will campaign."

As per Kabir, the "harassment" has been on since May, when the government asked him to drop Babri Masjid from the name of the replica. "I refused. My security has been withdrawn."

About the other candidates, Kabir says he is not worried. "It is a straight fight between the BJP and me. And if free and fair polls are held, my son will surely win. Other parties... all will have their deposits forfeited... The BJP is trying to break the Muslim vote and consolidate Hindus behind it. But fair elections will show that people are with us."

Mamata TMC candidate Rabiul Alam Chowdhury, who is campaigning in Loknathpur, a short distance from where villagers are gathered under a single halogen light, also talks of police "threatening" their voters.

VHP claims 254 Hindus killed in attacks this year, calls for fast-track trials, surveillance

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 3

THE VISHWA Hindu Parishad (VHP) on Saturday called for fast-track trials in cases of alleged religiously motivated attacks on Hindus, tighter regulation of madrasas and installation of high-resolution surveillance cameras at mosques and madrasas in "sensitive areas".

Claiming that 254 Hindus had been killed by "jihadis" in the first eight months of this year, the RSS affiliate called upon Hindus living in sensitive areas to "remain vigilant and prepared for self-defence".

At a press conference in New Delhi, VHP joint general secretary Surendra Jain released a 26-page list of 254 cases that the organisation said it had compiled from media reports of killings between January and August 31, 2026. The document gives the date and place of each incident, names of the victim and accused, and links to reports published by various media outlets.

The VHP has classified those on the list as Hindus killed by "jihadis". The document itself, however, includes cases arising from a range of circumstances. For instance, some of the linked reports concern murders following personal or financial disputes, while others involve allegations of communal or religiously motivated violence. The classification is VHP's.

Jain said the list covered only cases that were reported in the media and claimed that several other such incidents had not received media coverage. "The fact that such a large number of Hindus have been killed by jihadis, despite efforts by 'Ram-bhakt' governments in several states to curb this deadly trend over the past decade, should be a matter of concern for all patriotic and nationalist Bharatiyas," Jain said.

The VHP demanded that cases of attacks on Hindus found to have been driven by religious hatred be sent to fast-track courts and that those convicted receive swift and stringent punishment. It also demanded that minors accused of murder and serious offences allegedly motivated by religious hatred be tried as adults, alleging that minors were being used to commit violence in the expectation that they would receive lighter punishment.

RSS-linked magazine: ‘Protests over EC row, IIT suicide new bids of Communist-Islamist cabal’

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, October 3

"UNDERMINING BRAND Bharat in the name of democratic rights and agitations has become a fashion," the RSS-affiliated magazine *Organiser* has said, linking current protests over various issues - ranging from an IIT Bombay student's suicide and the Election Commission (EC)'s controversial Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls to Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions - to what it called the activities of a "Communist-Islamist cabal".

In an editorial in the latest issue of the magazine, *Organiser* editor Prafulla Ketkar said: "Fuelling protests, invoking caste sentiments in every issue,

creating alienation towards the Government and discrediting institutions is the new modus operandi of a Communist-Islamist cabal."

He also alleged that "anti-Bharat forces from outside" were "encouraging and funding these agitations" and that some Opposition parties were "falling prey to this game for short-term political ends".

Titled "Protest Season - IIT Bombay, Election Commission & UPI: Saving Gandhi and Ambedkar from Marx and Mao", the *Organiser*'s September 28 editorial argues that a new cycle of protests has begun in the wake of what it calls the "Constitution under threat" narrative" used during the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. It claims that "identity-based machinations" are now

using youth by combining issues of education with caste identities, adding that the trend could continue until the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly polls or even the 2029 Lok Sabha polls.

Citing the recent suicide of an IIT Bombay student, the editorial questioned attempts to link his death to caste discrimination. It said alleged cheating in an examination and subsequent disciplinary action had been turned into "a caste-based discrimination issue".

"If IIT students, irrespective of caste, are unable to handle the mental pressure and resort to an extreme step like suicide, it requires introspection, not agitation," Ketkar wrote. He argued that the questions of family and social pressure and mental health should also be

examined and said "ideological activism" should not be allowed to "undermine the IIT brand that symbolises excellence".

The editorial similarly targeted the questioning of the EC's functioning and the SIR. It alleged that representing internal conversations between the Election Commissioners in a manner that discredited electoral democracy was "part of the same machinations". Referring to questions raised over the EVMs and the SIR, it asked: "Is it a coincidence, or a pattern we need to decode?"

Significantly, the editorial also defended the proposed MDR on UPI transactions - an issue on which another RSS affiliate, Swadeshi Jagran Manch (SJM), has taken a conflicting position.

In a statement, SJM national co-convenor Ashwani Mahajan had argued that permitting banks and other notified electronic payment providers to levy MDR could undermine UPI and shift the balance in favour of the international card companies such as Visa and Mastercard.

"UPI is the successful story of the decade," the SJM said, warning that MDR could potentially allow global payment companies to regain ground in India.

The *Organiser* editorial went on to accuse Rahul Gandhi and the Congress party of allegedly "piggybacking on Marxists and Maoists, along with Islamists" to spread "fear, hatred and anarchic conditions through misinformation and disinformation".

Careers



GUJARAT METRO RAIL CORPORATION (GMRC) LIMITED
(SPV of Govt. of India and Govt. of Gujarat)
Block No.1, First Floor, Karmayogi Bhavan, Sector 10/A, Gandhinagar: 382010, Gujarat, India

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FORM NO. CAA. 2
[Pursuant to Section 230(3) and Rules 6 and 7]
Company Application No. CA(CAA) 37/AHM/2026
In the matter of:
Evoqua Water Technologies India Private Limited
...Non-Applciant/Transferee Company
Xylem Water Solutions India Private Limited
...Applciant/ Transferee Company

NOTICE AND ADVERTISEMENT OF NOTICE OF MEETING OF UNSECURED CREDITORS OF APPLICANT/ TRANSFEREE COMPANY

Notice is hereby given that by an Order dated 25 September 2026 (hereafter referred as the "Order"), in the above Company Application No. CA(CAA) 37/AHM/2026, the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Ahmedabad Bench (hereafter referred to as the "Hon'ble Tribunal") has directed that a meeting of the Unsecured Creditors of Xylem Water Solutions India Private Limited ("Transferee Company") be convened and held through videoconferencing, on 05 November 2026 at 10:30 AM, for the purpose of considering and if thought fit, approving the Scheme of Amalgamation between Evoqua Water Technologies India Private Limited ("Transferor Company"), the Applicant/ Transferee Company and their respective shareholders and creditors ("Scheme").

In pursuance of the said Order and as directed therein, notice is hereby given that the meeting of the Unsecured Creditors of the Transferee Company (as on 27 June 2026) will be held on 05 November 2026 at 10:30 AM, at which time the Unsecured Creditors are requested to attend the meeting through videoconferencing.

The Unsecured Creditors will be entitled to attend and vote in the meeting through videoconferencing. The instructions for attending the meeting through videoconferencing are provided in the Notice of Meeting. The Notice of Meeting with accompanying documents is being sent to the Unsecured Creditors of the Transferee Company as directed by the Hon'ble Tribunal, through electronic mode, to those Unsecured Creditors whose email IDs are registered with the Transferee Company, and through Registered Post/ Speed Post/ Courier at their registered or last known addresses available with the Transferee Company to those Unsecured Creditors whose email IDs are not registered with the Transferee Company. Unsecured Creditors whose email IDs are not registered with the Transferee Company can have the same registered by sending a request to the Deputy Manager - Procurement of the Transferee Company, Ms. Pinky Shah, at Pinky.Shah@xylem.com.

Copies of the Scheme, the Order, the Notice and the Explanatory Statement can be obtained free of charge at the Registered Office of the Transferee Company, Plot No. 731, Manjusar GIDC, Savli Road, Savli - 391770, Gujarat, India between Monday to Friday between 10:00 AM to 05:00 PM, up to the date of the Meeting or by email to the Deputy Manager - Procurement of the Transferee Company, Ms. Pinky Shah, at Pinky.Shah@xylem.com, and in case of no response, can contact the Chairperson, Mr. Dinesh Chattrath, at dinesh_chattrath@yahoo.co.in.

The Hon'ble Tribunal has appointed Mr. Dinesh Chattrath, Advocate to be the Chairperson and Ms. Pruthi Bhavsar, Advocate to be the Scrutinizer of the aforesaid Meeting.

The abovementioned Scheme, if approved at the Meeting, will be subject to subsequent approval of the Hon'ble Tribunal.

Dated this 04th day of October 2026.

Sd/-
Xylem Water Solutions India Private Limited
On behalf of
Dinesh Chattrath, Advocate
Chairperson Appointed for the Meeting

Registered Office:
Xylem Water Solutions India Private Limited
Plot No. 731, Manjusar GIDC, Savli Road, Savli - 391770, Gujarat, India
CIN: U29120GJ2011FCT065732



STEEL AUTHORITY OF INDIA LIMITED (SAIL)
Central Marketing Organisation
40, J L Nehru Road, Kolkata - 700071, Website: www.sail.co.in

Adv. No.: CMO/HR/YP/2026/01
Date: 30th September 2026

Central Marketing Organisation and Environment Management Division, units of Steel Authority of India Limited (SAIL), invites online applications from dynamic, result-oriented and promising professionals for engagement as Young Professionals on Fixed Term Engagement basis.

YOUNG PROFESSIONAL ENGAGEMENT 2026

IMPORTANT DETAILS	POSTS INCLUDED	ELIGIBILITY
Engagement Type: Young Professional (Fixed Term Engagement)	• Young Professional – Level 1	• BE/B.Tech/CA/CMA/CS (Post-wise)
Application Mode: Online	• Young Professional – Level 2	• Relevant Post-Qualification Experience Required
Job Location: Kolkata	• Young Professional – Level 3	• Age Limit: As Per Official Notification
	• Marketing, Finance, Computer & Information Technology, Compliance, Environment Management	• Indian Nationals Eligible

SELECTION PROCESS	FEE (CONSOLIDATED)	IMPORTANT DATES
• Application Screening	• YP Level 1 : ₹70,000/- Per Month	Online Application Start: 30 th September 2026
• Interview	• YP Level 2 : ₹1,00,000/- Per Month	Last Date to Apply : 15 th October 2026
• Document Verification	• YP Level 3 : ₹1,40,000/- Per Month	
• Medical Examination		

HOW TO APPLY

1. Apply Through SAIL Careers Portal (<https://sailcareers.com>)
2. Complete Online Registration
3. Upload Required Documents (Educational Certificates, Experience, ID Proof, etc.)
4. Submit Application Before Deadline

IMPORTANT NOTE

- Engagement of Young Professionals is on Fixed Term Engagement basis and does not confer any right for regular absorption in SAIL.
- SAIL reserves the right to cancel / restrict / modify / alter the engagement process at any stage without assigning any reason.
- For detailed eligibility criteria, post-wise qualification, experience, age, terms & conditions and other information, candidates are advised to read the official notification carefully before applying.

For detailed notification and updates, please visit: www.sail.co.in

Place: Kolkata
Date: 30th September 2026

Sd/-
Sr. Mgr (HR)
CMO, HQ, Kolkata
Steel Authority of India Limited (SAIL)

There's a little bit of SAIL in everybody's life



रानी लक्ष्मी बाई केंद्रीय कृषि विश्वविद्यालय, झाँसी-284003
Rani Lakshmi Bai Central Agricultural University, Jhansi-284003

Advertisement No: RLBCAU/07/2026
Dated: 03.10.2026

पशु चिकित्सा एवं पशु विज्ञान महाविद्यालय, दतिया (नौनेर) में पशु चिकित्सा विज्ञान एवं पशुपालन स्नातक (B.V.Sc. & A.H.) पाठ्यक्रम में प्रवेश के लिए आवेदन

रानी लक्ष्मी बाई केंद्रीय कृषि विश्वविद्यालय, झाँसी के अंतर्गत पशु चिकित्सा एवं पशु विज्ञान महाविद्यालय, दतिया (नौनेर) में शैक्षणिक सत्र 2026-27 हेतु पशु चिकित्सा विज्ञान एवं पशु पालन स्नातक (B.V.Sc. & A.H.) पाठ्यक्रम में उपलब्ध सीटों पर प्रवेश के लिए NEET-UG 2026 में वैध रैंक प्राप्त करने वाले पात्र एवं इच्छुक अभ्यर्थियों से आवेदन आमंत्रित किए जाते हैं। पशु चिकित्सा विज्ञान एवं पशु पालन स्नातक पाठ्यक्रम में प्रवेश राष्ट्रीय पात्रता सह प्रवेश परीक्षा-यूजी 2026 (NEET-UG 2026) की रैंक के आधार पर, निर्धारित पात्रता शर्तों एवं लागू नियमों के अधीन किया जाएगा। प्रवेश हेतु पंजीकरण प्रपत्र विश्वविद्यालय की आधिकारिक वेबसाइट www.rlbcu.ac.in पर दिनांक 03.10.2026 से 12.10.2026 तक ऑनलाइन उपलब्ध रहेगा। अधिक जानकारी के लिए कृपया विश्वविद्यालय की वेबसाइट www.rlbcu.ac.in देखें। प्रवेशित छात्रों को विश्वविद्यालय से छात्रवृत्ति प्रदान नहीं की जाएगी।

Application for Admission in College of Veterinary and Animal Sciences, Datia in B.V.Sc. & A.H. programme

Applications are invited for admission in **Bachelor of Veterinary Science and Animal Husbandry (B.V.Sc. & A.H.)** from eligible candidates who have secured a valid rank in NEET-UG 2026 and desirous of seeking admission against the available seats in the College of Veterinary and Animal Sciences, Datia under Rani Lakshmi Bai Central Agricultural University, Jhansi for the Academic Session 2026-27. Admission shall be made on the basis of NEET-UG 2026 ranking, subject to fulfillment of the prescribed eligibility conditions and applicable rules. The registration form for admission in **B.V.Sc. & A.H.** will be available online on the official University website www.rlbcu.ac.in from 03.10.2026 to 12.10.2026. Kindly visit the University website www.rlbcu.ac.in for further information. No University Fellowship will be provided to the admitted students.

कुलसचिव / Registrar



STATE BANK OF INDIA
Premises & Estate Dept. Local Head Office
8th Floor, Gandhi Maidan, Patna-800001
E-mail: agmpe.lhopat@sbi.co.in

TENDER ID- LHOPAT / EMP/ARCH/2026-27/01
Dated: 04.10.2026
EMPALEMENT OF ARCHITECTS / CONSULTANTS UNDER ₹15 CR. CATEGORY AND REVIEW & ENLARGEMENT OF EXISTING PANEL OF ARCHITECTS/CONSULTANTS UNDER THE GEOGRAPHICAL AREA OF PATNA CIRCLE

Premises & Estate Department LHO Patna, on behalf State Bank of India (SBI) invites applications from reputed and experienced Architectural/ Consultancy Firms /Individuals for Empaument of Architects/ Consultants under ₹ 15 Cr. Category and review & enlargement of existing panel of Architects for State Bank of India, Patna Circle.

The complete application including eligibility criteria can be downloaded from the Bank's website <https://sbi.bank.in/web/sbi-in-the-news/procurement-news> from 04.10.2026. Last date for submission of online applications with supporting documents is 02.11.2026, up to 15:00 Hrs. Corrigendum/addendum, if any in the matter will be published only on Bank's above website.

Place : Patna, Date : 04.10.2026 Assistant General Manager (P&E)

epaper.indianexpress.com

Punjab MLA flags teacher shortage in govt school his son goes to, AAP suspends him

Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, October 3

THE AAM Aadmi Party (AAP) on Saturday suspended Maur MLA Sukhveer Singh Maiserkhana for alleged “anti-party activities”, barely an hour after he released an emotional video accusing the Punjab government of failing to address teacher shortage in state-run schools, including those attended by his two children.

Maiserkhana is the only MLA in 117-member Punjab Assembly who sends both his children to government schools, an investigation by *The Indian Express* had found in March this year. The suspension order, issued by AAP state general secretary Harchand Singh Barsat, read: “It has come to the notice...that you have been found involved in anti-party activities and indiscipline. In view of the above, your primary membership from the party is suspended with immediate effect”.

Going live on Facebook, the

first-time MLA said he regretted enrolling his children in government schools, claiming their “future was at stake” because of the shortage of teachers.

Maiserkhana alleged that repeated pleas to senior party leaders, including former Delhi education minister and Punjab affairs in-charge Manish Sisodia, had failed to resolve the shortage. The AAP MLA said he knows he will be denied a ticket for contesting the upcoming polls. “But I will continue to fight for people,” he said and added that he may be booked too.

“My children study where the children of 3 crore common Punjabis also study... and that’s why I am speaking today as a father. The future of my children is at stake. The issue of teacher shortage is not being addressed in the schools where my children study,” he said.

“Have got tired of saying that please give teachers, please give teachers... I always worked for the party’s betterment... and now they are isolating and ignoring me, removing me from



Sukhveer Singh Maiserkhana is the only Punjab MLA whose children go to govt school and (right) *The Indian Express* report of March 15, 2026



everywhere. Why? Just because I am fighting for the schools, for my own children, and for the children of all those who send their children to government schools,” he said.

Declaring that he would not remain silent, Maiserkhana dared the government to “do wrong to me, but not my children”. “If nothing has been done in schools, how will we ask for votes from people? In entire Punjab, I am the only MLA whose kids study in government schools. If I won’t raise voice, who will? Did I do anything

wrong by enrolling my kids in a government school? I think it was a big mistake. Arrest and jail me but I will speak for my and people’s children who study in government schools,” he added.

Maiserkhana’s son is enrolled in a School of Eminence in Bathinda and the daughter in another state-run primary school. The AAP, in an official statement, denied the allegations and said Maiserkhana had attempted to defame the party by making a false statement that only one teacher was doing duty at the School of

Eminence in Bathinda.

“The claim was contrary to the official record issued by the school principal on September 29, 2026. According to the record, the school has 30 sanctioned teaching posts, of which 25 are currently filled. The staff posted at the school includes one principal, seven lecturers, 15 teachers from the Master Cadre and two Computer Science teachers. The school currently has 580 students studying from Classes 6 to 12 across 19 sections,” read the statement.

Former Union Minister Ravneet Singh Bittu said, “When a ruling-party MLA has to come on social media and appeal for adequate teachers in schools in his own constituency, it raises serious questions about the situation faced by ordinary families and lakhs of students across Punjab.” SAD chief Sukhbir Singh Badal said AAP’s “fake” ‘Silkha Kranti’ has been “exposed”.

Punjab Congress president Pargat Singh said, “What we have been saying for the past

four and a half years, the AAP’s false education revolution built on publicity and its dictatorship has today been laid bare by Maiserkhana himself. Like many Punjabis, Maiserkhana too had been influenced by AAP’s Delhi model and its false claims of an education revolution”.

Congress MP Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa said that a sitting AAP MLA says he has raised basic issues like repairing schools and appointing teachers, yet nobody listened. “Now, he says that despite being a sitting MLA of the ruling party, he cannot even get an appointment with the chief minister. If an ‘Aam Aadmi’ MLA cannot even meet his own chief minister, then what does that say about the ordinary people who are trying to be heard?” Randhawa asked.

The Indian Express investigation in March had found that during the 2025-26 session, 36 MLAs had school-going children, including 31 from the AAP, but the others sent their wards to private schools in India or institutions abroad.

Narco-trafficking kingpin Navpreet Singh deported from Turkey, says Shah

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 3



Navpreet Singh was on the run for several years

HARDENED narco-trafficking kingpin Navpreet Singh, wanted in several narcotics cases and on the run for years, was deported from Türkiye and brought back to India on Saturday, Union Home Minister Amit Shah announced via a social media post.

“Obtaining Turkish citizenship under the fake identity of Navab Virk, he [Singh] had continued to smuggle heroin and methamphetamine to India from Afghanistan. Our agencies tracked him down, ripping apart veil after veil to unmask his true identity, and secured his deportation. Today he has been brought back to India and put behind bars in connection with cases involving drug trafficking and other crimes he is accused of. Congratulations to all the agencies for this success,”

Shah wrote on X.

Hailing the development as a “historic milestone”, the minister added that the “Modi govt is committed to destroying every narco-cartel before Dec 2029”.

A native of Punjab, Navpreet, also known as ‘Nav’, had been on the run for over two years. The 34-year-old is alleged to have headed a sprawling international narcotics syndicate whose India-based operations were run by his cousin, Prabhdeep Singh.

Baby orangutans face longer quarantine at Odisha zoo

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, October 3

THE FIVE baby orangutans rescued from a forest in Odisha’s Balasore district are set for a longer stay in Odisha’s Nandankanan Zoological Park. The animals, rescued from the forests of Balasore in September amid smuggling concerns, will remain in quarantine for 90 days at the zoo, where officials said their health and well-being will be closely monitored.

Nandankanan officials said the Central Zoo Authority (CZA) has advised a 90-day quarantine for the orangutans as part of biosecurity protocols — measures used to prevent, control and stop the spread of diseases among animal populations.

The CZA has also advised that only caregivers and doctors be allowed to enter the quarantine facility where the infant orangutans are being kept.

“The orangutans will be quarantined in the hand-rearing centre (HRC) area only, where they are currently kept. We have open enclosures at the side of HRC, having a larger area and open skies, where the apes will be moved during the day to acclimatise with the environment after the advice of the technical committee,” Deputy Zoo Director Pradeep Mirase told *The Indian Express*.

While a mandatory quarantine period of 30 days is standard for animals imported into Indian zoos, it is generally extended to 90 days in multiple phases for highly protected or high-risk species. Orangutans are listed under Appendix I of the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species (CITES), which imposes the



Zoo officials say their priority is to ensure that the infants receive the best healthcare during their stay at Nandankanan.

highest level of protection on species threatened with extinction and restricts their international trade.

Orangutans are native to the rainforests of Indonesia and Malaysia, across Borneo and Sumatra, and are “critically endangered” according to the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List.

The decision to quarantine the orangutans comes as authorities continue to investigate where the apes, first spotted in the forests of Odisha on September 8, came from.

“The rescued orangutans are infants; their place of origin remains unknown, and their health history is also unclear. We don’t know if they have any underlying diseases. In view of the CZA advisory, it was decided to quarantine the apes for 90 days,” said the zoo deputy director. Even after completion of the quarantine period, there will be no public viewing of the rescued orangutans at Nandankanan until a final decision is taken by the state government and other statutory bodies.

According to zoo officials, the priority is to ensure the infants

receive the best possible healthcare and management during their stay at Nandankanan. While the state government has formed a five-member technical committee comprising experts to oversee the health, welfare and management of the baby orangutans, zoo authorities monitor their health conditions daily.

“There is a gradual increase in the weight of each baby. The orangutan babies are apparently healthy and have a normal appetite, while their behaviour and activity levels are gradually improving. Their faecal consistency is also normal,” said a statement issued by the zoo on September 26.

While three of the five baby orangutans were found to be anaemic — one severely — officials said the haemoglobin levels in two of the three apes are gradually improving. No decision has been taken yet on conducting their DNA tests to determine their species and geographical origin.

The five baby orangutans were rescued from a forest in the state’s Balasore district on September 8, raising concerns of smuggling.

Forest department claims that the villagers have encroached on the area and cut over 30,000 trees in a decade

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, October 3

LAST MONTH, during an inspection deep inside the Udanti Sitanadi Tiger Reserve (USTR) that spans Chhattisgarh’s Dhamtari and Gariaband districts, senior forest officials spotted something alarming. A number of trees, a majority of them Sal, Bija and Tendu, were found girdled in the Karka area. The process, in which portions of the bark is removed to cut off nutrient supply, eventually results in the death of the tree. In all, over 2,000 fully grown trees were found girdled. The location of the place made it all the more intriguing: This was the same area from where villagers were relocated nearly four decades ago in the 1980s for the construction of a dam.

On closer inspection, which included looking into satellite images, it has come to light that villagers have been returning to the area over the last two decades. In the last one decade, they have allegedly cleared 30,000 trees in the protected forest for cultivation.

With Karka forming part of an important forested landscape and wildlife movement corridor, including an elephant corridor, degradation of habitat can increase the potential for human-wildlife conflict, officials said.

Karka was historically a for-

est village situated in the catchment of the Sondhur dam, within the erstwhile Sitanadi Sanctuary.

Following construction of the dam, the village was relocated in the 1980s.

While forest authorities said people have been returning despite getting compensation, many villagers claimed they never got any relief and hence, never moved out.

“As per available departmental records, 55 people of the village received compensation from the Water Resources Department. Despite the lawful compensation, forest land in the upstream area has subsequently been subjected to encroachment and clearing,” said deputy director of USTR, Varun Jain.

A preliminary investigation by forest officials, including the use of ISRO images, showed crop fields near the submerged area in 2006. By 2016, 22 hectares upstream was encroached.

Back then, a Preliminary Offence Report (POR) was registered but 20 persons booked in the case were acquitted. The encroachment continued, and increased. And as of 2026, more than 30 hectares were found encroached. During the latest field assessment on September 22, the Forest Department has found evidence of extensive forest degradation.

“We have calculated that



The forest department has found evidence of extensive forest degradation. EXPRESS

over 2,500 trees have been girdled (over the last few years) due to which they slowly die. The calculation is ocular, by comparing the tree density in adjacent forest areas using sample plots (adjacent area shows more than 1,500 trees/hectare while the encroached area shows only 50-100 trees per hectare), said Jain. “This is why 2016 imagery shows a dense forest, but 2017 shows a stark reduction in forest cover as the trees had dried and died in one year (due to girdling),” he added.

The forest team faced strong resistance from 40 to 50 villagers during their investigation. A fresh POR has been registered against two villagers in the matter.

On the other hand, around 32 families from Karka said they continued to stay inside the reserve because they never got compensation even as others who received it moved out. Bhagwan Singh, 32, from

the village told *The Indian Express*, “The 32 to 33 families never got compensation. At first, the forest department offered us 5 acres and Rs 15 lakh to move out of the reserve but when we refused (as we did not want to move out), they started alleging encroachment.”

They have found support in the Gram Sabha Federation, an umbrella body of all Gram Sabhas in tiger reserves, with its president Ishwari Lal Netam saying, “It is true that the trees have been girdled. Though we cannot estimate how many have been girdled, the figure is not as high as the forest department claims.”

A forest official, however, said, “They got Community Forest Resource Rights (CFRR) in 2020 in 2,208 hectares and they were supposed to protect the forest but instead, they are cutting thousands of trees. We shall take appropriate action.”

The community forest resource area is the common for-

est land that has been traditionally protected and conserved for sustainable use by a particular community.

CFRR provides for recognition of the right to “protect, regenerate or conserve or manage” the community forest resource. At present, GPS-based mapping of the encroached area is underway along with DGPS-enabled drone mapping where minute details are clearly available. This drone generated imagery will be compared with ISRO imageries to get an accurate assessment of the extent of forest cover loss.

“A DGPS drone survey was conducted two days ago in the presence of police personnel. Based on the exact area identified through the survey, the names of the accused will be added to the registered POR, following which 80A notices will be issued, directing them to vacate the encroached land,” Jain told *The Indian Express*.

The forest department has also initiated a departmental enquiry against a beat guard and range assistant. They allegedly resisted registering the POR for 20-25 days after the matter came to light, giving rise to suspicion that they were aware of the matter but had been turning a blind eye to it all this while.

“In last four years, USTR administration has freed 1,050 hectares of encroached forest land and the field staff, operating with a 65% vacancy in sanctioned strength, have faced five attacks by villagers. About 200 to 300 hectares inside USTR is still encroached upon, including in Karka,” added Jain.

City with Open Hand turns 75: Can Chandigarh grow without losing itself?



NORTHERN LIGHTS
BY MANRAJ GREWAL SHARMA

A WEEKLY DISPATCH ON POLITICS AND POWER SHIFTS IN PUNJAB, HARYANA AND HIMACHAL PRADESH

ONE OF the biggest fears of any Chandigarhian is a city that looks like Gurugram on a very rainy day, or like one of its satellite cities such as Zirakpur: cramped, chaotic and stripped of greenery.

But Chandigarh has two kinds of Chandigarhians: those who were raised here or have worked here for years, and those who arrived here more recently. The former want to re-

tain the standards the city has long offered; the latter are grateful that it remains far better than the urban sprawls of most Indian cities.

As Chandigarh marks 75 years of its making this October, that difference matters. Its population is at an all-time high, while there is little land left to build upon. The amended Chandigarh Master Plan 2031 has opened the door to vertical growth. But can the city grow upwards without damaging the character of a place built around three cardinal principles: sun, space and greenery?

And who gets to decide? Residents who have repeatedly gone to court to preserve the city’s character? Elected councillors, who can sometimes appear more interested in real-estate development than heritage? Or itinerant bureaucrats who spend two or three years here before moving on? Less said the better about politicians in Punjab and Haryana, whose interest in Chandigarh is

often confined to periodically laying their respective claims on it.

A city meant to be different

The Chandigarh story began in March 1948, when the Punjab government, in consultation with the Centre, earmarked a 114-sq-km site near the Shivalik foothills, as the site for its capital after an aerial survey. It was chosen for its natural drainage, elevated terrain, and accessibility.

The city began to take shape in 1951 when the government turned to Swiss-French architect Le Corbusier, who conceived Chandigarh as a living organism. The Capitol Complex was its head, Sector 17 its commercial heart, the Leisure Valley its lungs and the residential sectors its organs. Roads numbered V1 to V7 separated different kinds of traffic.

Its spirit was embodied in the Open Hand: a symbol of giving and receiving, welcoming everyone.

Pierre Jeanneret, Corbusier’s cousin, spent 15 years as the city’s Chief Architect, utilising local materials and workmen to build its soul. Architect S D Sharma, who worked closely with him and contributed to landmark structures like PGIMER, remains a living link to that era. At a seminar for critiquing the city’s planning, the 94-year-old patiently listened before quietly declaring: “Chandigarh is perfect. It has no flaws.”

This sentiment has found powerful defenders among the city’s denizens. Senior advocate Mac Sarin and other residents fought all the way to the Supreme Court, which delivered a landmark judgment in January 2023 banning the apartmentalisation and floor-wise sale of residential houses in Phase 1, Sectors 1 to 30, to safeguard its heritage character. Citizens also legally challenged a proposed flyover on Dakshin Marg, arguing it violated the city’s pedestrian-friendly grid ethos.

Lawyers vetoed a proposal

to relocate parts of the Punjab and Haryana High Court away from the Capitol Complex. A metro also met the same fate for threatening the city’s character.

While the Capitol Complex became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2016, Chandigarh’s true heritage lies in its green belts, strict sector grids, tree-lined avenues, low-rise skyline, light-filled openness and the Shivaliks.

That is what is now under pressure.

New faultlines

Chandigarh has never been frozen in time. It has grown and changed. The city’s industrial belt has new malls, it has built a new underground, and parts of the high court complex have been modified.

Bylaws too are being relaxed. As Bimal Patel, who designed the new Parliament, argued, why should residents not be allowed to make need-based changes in their houses if they do not affect neighbours?

Last month, the Administra-

tion approved amendments to the Master Plan 2031, allowing high-rises (10 storeys) in selected areas, subject to studies on traffic, water, sewerage and ecology. The rationale: Chandigarh has only about 114 sq km of developable land. If the city cannot expand outwards, it must grow upwards.

Former Chief Architect Sumit Kaur, who helped shape the original Master Plan 2031, disagrees, arguing that drastic changes in one phase risk undermining the idea of Chandigarh as one organism, besides straining its already creaky water, sewage, roads and social amenities. She also underlines the fact that the city falls in Seismic Zone IV. “It is strange but we seem to be copying our neighbours instead of the other way round,” she says.

Architects such as Pallav Mukherjee underline the idea of a pan-regional urban plan and suggest a rethink of transport, with mini-buses running across its vertical and horizontal grids every 10 minutes, to allow for

better commute for both locals and those living on the city’s outskirts.

‘City Beautiful’

Chandigarh is not merely an architectural experiment. It is a much loved home, each sector unique.

For locals, it’s truly “City Beautiful”. Speaking on the legacy of Partap Singh Kairon, the Punjab chief minister who championed Chandigarh, the current Leader of Opposition in the Punjab Assembly, Partap Bajwa, insisted that “it is peerless”. “There is no city like this in the country,” he said.

BJP national president Nitin Nabin, when asked about the proposed changes to Chandigarh during his visit to Jalandhar a few months ago, also said: “It’s a concept city, it should remain the way it is.”

Its history is also political. Chandigarh has been the joint capital of Punjab and Haryana as well as a Union Territory (UT) since 1966.

That complicated history is

captured by rappers Navdeep Singh and Harsimranjit Singh, who sang “Shehar mera Chandigarh”. Their ancestral village, Fatehgarh Madran, is now Sector 34. “Before Chandigarh was built, this area was the heart of Pwadh,” they say. “We’ve always been Chandigarhians.”

Chandigarh cannot become a museum. It must provide homes, jobs, transport and opportunities for those who have streamed in after its first settlers. But can the city grow without erasing or diluting the very idea that made it different?

Perhaps the bolder question is this: Why turn Chandigarh into just another city when India could build more Chandigarhs? Seventy-five years from now, the goal should be an India dotted with cities that breathe, walk and shine like Chandigarh, not a Chandigarh that gasps amidst an urban sprawl.

Manraj Grewal Sharma is National Editor, North, The Indian Express

Capt Machchhar recovering well: Embassy

Press Trust of India
Dubai, October 3

INDIAN PILOT Smit Machchhar is "recovering well" and remains under "excellent medical care" after being seriously injured in an attack by his co-pilot during a flight to Israel, the Indian Embassy in the UAE said on Saturday. Machchhar was stabbed and seriously injured in the cockpit of flydubai flight FZ1073 on Wednesday while it was travelling from Dubai to Tel Aviv.



Captain Smit Machchhar

Hammami, the Wall Street Journal reported, quoting people familiar with the matter.

The flight, carrying 174 passengers, transmitted emergency signals and made a rapid descent of more than 17,000 feet from an altitude of 34,000 feet before making an emergency landing at Prince Sultan Bin Abdulaziz Airport in Saudi Arabia's Tabuk.

After receiving initial treatment in Tabuk, Machchhar was shifted to Abu Dhabi for continued medical care.

Meanwhile, Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in a conversation with Captain Machchhar, the video of which was shared on X, said, "You are a hero for Israel, India, and the entire world. I invite you and India's Prime Minister Modi to light a torch on Israeli Independence Day." During the conversation that took place on Saturday, the Israel PM asked Captain Machchhar how it all began, and he revealed new details from the moments in the cockpit.

The UAE, which is leading the investigation, said the co-pilot attempted to carry out a "terrorist act". UAE Attorney General Hamad Saif Al Shamsi said the co-pilot used a crash axe to attack Machchhar and attempted to take control of the aircraft, state-run WAM news agency reported.

Machchhar managed to open the cockpit door despite his injuries, allowing passengers and crew to overpower the co-pilot, according to earlier reports.

The co-pilot who attacked Machchhar has been identified as Omani national Hamam al-

'India has a new hero': Consulate General of Israel in Mumbai puts billboard hailing Capt

Press Trust of India
Mumbai, October 3

THE CONSULATE General of Israel in Mumbai on Friday put up a billboard in the city hailing flydubai pilot Smit Machchhar, who foiled his co-pilot's attempt to allegedly crash an Israel-bound flight.

"India has a new hero, and Israel will never forget his name: Captain Smit Machchhar! Thank you, Captain Smit! Recover quickly. Israel is waiting to welcome you," Yaniv Revach, Israel Consul General in Mumbai, said in a post on X.

He also posted an image of the billboard with a message: "Thank you Captain Smit for saving lives. We wish you a speedy recovery." The flydubai flight FZ1073, travelling from Dubai to Tel Aviv, transmitted emergency signals on Wednesday and made a sharp descent of more than 17,000 feet from 34,000 feet before diverting to Prince Sultan Bin Abdel Aziz Airport in Saudi Arabia's Tabuk city. The flight was carrying 174 passengers, including 27 children.

According to Yaniv Revach, Consul General of Israel in Mumbai, this initiative is part of a public awareness campaign to honour the pilot's act of bravery as well as a symbol of friendship between the people of Israel and India.



A billboard put up by the Consulate of Israel in Mumbai on Saturday. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

Bollywood artistes Shah Rukh Khan, Salman Khan, Karan Johar, Ranveer Singh and several other Bollywood personalities have praised flydubai pilot Captain Smit Machchhar for his courage.

Actor Shah Rukh Khan said Machchhar "stood strong when it mattered the most" and put his own safety on the line to protect those on board.

"It's not easy to stare adversity in the face and put one's safety on the line. But you did just that to protect those on board and showed us what being a Captain entails. A true

display of courage and duty. Wishing you a speedy recovery, the country is proud of you," the actor wrote on X.

Salman Khan hailed the pilot's actions, saying, "*Kamaal kar diya pilot ji, hum sab aap ko salute karte hain* (You've done an incredible job, pilotji. We all salute you for your courage)... will be a pleasure to fly with u.. Well done bro.. Capt #Smit-Machchhar." Ranveer Singh shared a photograph of Machchhar on his Instagram and called him "Captain Courageous". Director Karan Johar said on a post on Instagram, "It takes

another grain of courage to be fighting for your own life but in that split second, put the lives of all others before yours. And that's what captain Smit Machchhar did in the face of the toughest times. And for that, the entire country & humankind is behind you!"

Actor Rashmika Mandanna said she was at a loss for words at the courage Machchhar showed while fighting for his own life and thinking about others. "Wishing you strength and a very speedy recovery, Captain Smit. We are so proud of you," she added.

LGBTQ influencer and makeup artist shot dead in Amritsar

Kamaldeep Singh Brar
Amritsar, October 3

PUNJABI LGBTQ social media influencer and makeup artist Madhu Sudan, popularly known as Mad Sandhu, was shot dead by unidentified persons in Amritsar on Saturday with police saying they have "some leads" and the accused will be nabbed soon.



Madhu Sudan popularly known as Mad Sandhu

have recorded the family's statement".

Sandhu had over 2 lakh followers on Instagram and was the founder of Mane Lane Unisex Salon in Amritsar and operated beauty academies offering courses ranging from self-makeup to professional bridal artistry. He faced homophobic trolling on his gay identity, and would hit back saying "God has made me the way I am".

A few months ago, an audio-video clip went viral featuring a confrontation between Sandhu and a Nihang Singh with the latter objecting to the Sandhu's social media activities and older video reels, warning him to refrain from content deemed harmful to Punjabi culture and youth. Although Sandhu issued a public clarification stating he had changed his content style and stopped repeating past mistakes, he maintained that old clips were being recirculated intentionally to manufacture unnecessary controversy.

Based on a statement from the family, police registered an FIR and initiated the preliminary investigation. The motive of the attack was yet to be ascertained, a senior police officer said, adding they were working on multiple angles.

DCP Investigation, Amritsar Commissionerate, Prabhjot Singh Virk said, "...We have leads and will solve the case soon. We



A walk through river to school

Students cross the river to reach their school at Kuklah village in Himachal Pradesh's Mandi district on Saturday. A series of cloudbursts and flash floods on June 30, 2025 had devastated Kuklah and adjoining villages. The Kuklah bridge and adjoining road were swept away, cutting off around 20 gram panchayats. The bridge is yet to be rebuilt. ANI

Govt approves 5 Centres of Excellence to support five Classical languages

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 3

THE MINISTRY of Education Saturday approved the establishment of five Centres of Excellence (CoEs) for studies in five Classical languages, namely Assamese, Bengali, Marathi, Pali and Prakrit.

"The establishment of these five Centres marks a significant step towards strengthening the institutional ecosystem for the study, research and preservation

of India's Classical Languages," the Ministry said in a statement

The Centres will focus on four broad areas - providing dedicated institutional platforms for advanced research, scholarly work and academic engagement; preservation and digitisation; wider dissemination of Classical Language heritage; and strengthening regional academic ecosystems.

The Centre of Excellence for classical Assamese will be established at Tezpur University,

Assam; for classical Bengali at Visva-Bharati University, West Bengal; for classical Marathi at Deccan College Post-Graduate and Research Institute, Pune, Maharashtra; for classical Pali at Central University of Odisha, Odisha; and for classical Prakrit at Central University of Gujarat, Gujarat.

The initiative reinforces government's efforts to preserve and promote India's rich linguistic and literary heritage, the Ministry's statement read.

Keralam's former DGP resigns as Thiruvananthapuram councillor months after BJP's mayor 'snub'

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, October 3

BJP STATE vice-president and former DGP R Sreelekha has resigned as councillor of the Thiruvananthapuram Municipal Corporation, months after she publicly expressed disappointment over not being made mayor after the party won control of the civic body.

In the 101-strong cooperation council, BJP has only 50 members and the party has been ruling with the support of an independent. With Sreelekha's resignation, BJP-led NDA's strength has come down to 49, leaving the party's governance at the corporation in a precarious position. BJP has begun conciliation process with Sreelekha to save the party-led corporation.

Sreelekha, who joined the BJP in October 2024, submitted her resignation to Mayor V V Rajesh, who told the media that she had cited personal reasons for the decision. Sreelekha has not so far publicly given any other reason for her resignation. Reports of her dissatisfaction over the mayoral post had emerged after the corporation elections.

In the December 2025 local body elections, the BJP-led NDA won control of the Thiruvananthapuram municipal corporation, ending the CPI(M)-led LDF's 45-year run. The 101-member council has 50 NDA councillors. With Sreelekha's

• BRIEFLY



People gather at the explosion site in Tirupati district. PTI

ANDHRA PRADESH

Four killed, ten injured as boiler explodes in Tirupati pharma factory

AT LEAST FOUR workers were killed and 10 others were injured when a boiler exploded at a pharmaceutical factory in Sri City in Andhra Pradesh's Tirupati district on Saturday morning. The blast caused a part of the building's roof to collapse, trapping workers who were later rescued, officials said. The explosion occurred as several night-shift workers were preparing to leave the facility. The blaze broke out following the explosion was later brought under control, while the injured were shifted to nearby hospitals. ENS

MP man kills 4 family members

A 32-YEAR-OLD man allegedly killed his mother, grandparents and a five-year-old cousin while injuring four others in Anuppur district of Madhya Pradesh in the early hours of Saturday, police said. Accused Prem Singh, a resident of Umaria district who had a history of violence, was taken into custody, Superintendent of Police Vikrant Murab told PTI. PTI

Labourer dies as wall collapses

A 35-YEAR-OLD labourer was killed after a wall under construction collapsed near a hotel in Mathura's Govind Nagar on Saturday, initially raising fears that two other workers were trapped under the debris, police said. The wall suddenly collapsed while construction work was underway in the afternoon, burying three labourers working at the site, according to officials. PTI



Former DGP R Sreelekha

resignation from the Sasthamangalam ward, a vacancy has arisen in the council. The national leadership of the BJP hailed its breakthrough in the Kerala capital as a watershed moment that would pave the way for the party to rule the southern state."

After the elections, Sreelekha told media she had contested the election with the expectation of becoming mayor. She said the BJP had presented her as its mayoral face during campaign.

Speaking to the media in January this year, Sreelekha said: "I was reluctant to contest the elections, but I agreed following the assurance that I would be made mayor. I thought I was the face of the party in the corporation. I am also BJP state vice-president and have to work for all candidates. I was given the task of ensuring the victory of 10 candidates. At least, I agreed to contest the election. The party leadership said I was the face of the party in the elections to the corporation, and I was presented before TV channels in that

manner. However, at the last minute, things changed for some reason."

Sreelekha said, "I think the party central leadership might have taken such a decision thinking they (Rajesh as mayor and Asha Nath as deputy mayor) can perform better. I accept the decision of the leadership and am not going to debate over it with the leadership. I cannot walk out in protest against the decision. There are people who have voted for me. Hence, I decided to continue as a councillor for five years. I am not going to contest the Assembly elections". She suddenly contested Assembly election from Vattiyorkkavu as the BJP candidate, where Congress candidate K Muraliedharan won. Sreelekha finished third, behind CPI(M) candidate. In the 2021 Assembly elections, then BJP candidate V V Rajesh had finished second.

R Sreelekha is Keralam's first woman IPS officer. She retired in 2020 as director general of Kerala Fire and Rescue Service and was the first woman IPS officer in Kerala to attain DGP rank. After joining the BJP in 2024, Sreelekha told the media that Prime Minister Modi's charisma had prompted her to join the party. "I have faith in BJP's ideologies. I am joining BJP after three-week-long thinking," she then said. On her retirement day, she abstained from a formal farewell party and guard of honour given to DGP-rank officers.

• NIMA MALEKAR HAS NOW LOST BOTH HER CHILDREN AND HER HUSBAND TO SUICIDES, REPORTEDLY CAUSED BY FARM DISTRESS AND THE WAIT FOR A BOREWELL ELECTRICITY CONNECTION

It rained the day after he died. For a farmer family in Yavatmal, it was too late, again

Ankita Deshkar
Pimpplapur (Yavatmal), October 3

THE TULSI plant outside her house in the brown and dry Pimpplapur village in Yavatmal's Ralegaon is unusually green. Nima Dnyaneshwar Malekar has barely noticed.

In five years, the 58-year-old can't remember a time when she was not in mourning. First it was for her elder son Nikhil, 28, who died of suspected suicide in March 2021. Younger by three years, Tapaveen, her only other child, followed his brother in October 2024. On July 22 this year, Nima's husband Dnyaneshwar, 65, took his own life.

Her voice breaking, Nima says she had no idea "what was going on in their minds". "We worked so hard. My children worked, their father toiled. But what was the use? There is nothing left."

Nima's nephew Harish Choudhary says reasons for all three deaths, by hanging, were the same - recurring crop losses, inadequate rainfall and diffi-

culties in securing an electricity connection to operate a borewell. The Malekars are not alone in this, as large parts of Maharashtra, including Yavatmal, again stare at drought. Last week, the state declared drought in 265 of its 358 tehsils - or about three-fourths of Maharashtra.

As per official figures, between January and June this year, even before this year's drought cycle actually hit, Yavatmal had witnessed 128 farmer suicides. Nima and Dnyaneshwar had built their house only this year after getting funds under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana. "Left all alone in it" now, Nima spends half her time at her brother's home in Kosala village, as neighbours and family help look after her land.

She is just carrying on, she says. "I will live for as long as God chooses to keep me. The day He takes me, I will go."

'I am going mad'

Sarpanch Ravindra Choudhary, who is related to the family, says Nikhil, who worked on the family's five-acre land, where

they grow cotton, had been trying for long to get his application approved for an electricity connection to draw water from their borewell.

"He would say, 'I am going mad. I don't understand how the crop will grow,'" Nima recalls. Then, in 2021, excess rain washed away their crops. When Nikhil was found hanging from a tree, it was just a month to go for his marriage. Villagers cut down the tree later.

Tapaveen was meant to take a different course, having finished BA and enrolled for post-graduation. But, after Nikhil's death, he started helping on the land too, studying on the side and preparing for competitive examinations.

But then came 2024. It was a particularly bad year, the family recalls, and their crop failed in the absence of rains. "He too started saying, 'What should I do? My mind is not working,'" Nima says. One day while she and her husband were away in the field, Tapaveen hanged himself from a rope at their home.

This year, they sowed three



Nima Malekar says she is just carrying on. "I will live for as long as God chooses to keep me."; (right) stunted growth of cotton crop in agricultural land of Malekars. ANKITA DESHKAR

times, Nima says, putting in the seed, spending money on fertilizers. "But there was no rain for nearly two months after that. The crop dried up."

Her husband did not share his despair, Nima says, recalling how she slept before him that night. Sometime in the early hours, Dnyaneshwar went to the adjacent room and hanged himself. Nima discovered the body at about 5 am. Grampanchayat Adhikari of the village RR Dhage

says farmers here are at the mercy of the weather. "During the elder son's time, there was excess rain. During the younger son's, there was a drought... It's still the same."

A family's pride

Dnyaneshwar worked as a farm labourer on other people's land for years before saving enough to buy the five acres he owned in 2018. It was all fallow land, Harish says. "Dnyanesh-



war made it cultivable almost single-handedly."

For a few years, the family thought their troubles were behind them. But the battles with the rain - and to get electricity - just dragged on.

The family says it first applied for an electricity connection in 2021, when the government came out with a scheme. The sarpanch says around 40 farmers in the village benefited, but not Dnyaneshwar.

The Malekars tried again when the government came up with a solar-powered system in 2023. While Nima has written to the Tehsildar again now, Harish says solar is hardly the answer. Pointing out that the Malekar borewell is deep and requires a high-capacity pump to draw water, he says: "How can we run the pump on it? Solar starts dipping by around 4 pm (when the sun starts going down). It does not work at night."

The family also says that, without any subsidy from the government, the cost of installing a solar system is beyond their means. Sarpanch Ravindra admits only three people in the village have gone for solar.

Promises and grants

After all three deaths, Nima was visited by representatives from political parties. "The BJP, the Congress, the Shiv Sena all came," says the sarpanch. "But nothing was done."

Recently, Nima was issued a certificate under the Niradhar Scheme and told she would receive Rs 1,500 a month. The pay-

ment is yet to start, family members say.

A cheque of Rs 20,000 was also given by the tehsildar under the Rashtriya Kutumb Labh Yojana. Ralegaon Tehsildar Amit Bhoite says: "The scheme offers immediate financial support to bereaved BPL families who have lost their main bread winners. We have also sanctioned over Rs 1 lakh for her husband, under the aid for families in case of farmer suicides. The amount of Rs 1,500 has been sanctioned under the Sanjay Gandhi Niradhar Yojana." Bhoite adds that he is trying to rope in some NGOs to provide additional financial assistance to Nima.

The only significant aid they ever received, the family says, was Rs 1 lakh after Nikhil's death. It all went into paying their debts, Harish says.

Nima still goes to the farm when she can, he adds. "She just goes and sits." Her eyes looking into the distance, her face blank, Nima says: "The day after he (Dnyaneshwar) died, it rained... But, since then again, there has been no water."

Gujarat varsity student found ‘stripped & injured’, dies later

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, October 3

A 21-YEAR-OLD university student was found “critically injured and without clothes” on the premises of a society in the Isanpur area of Ahmedabad on Friday night, police said on Saturday.

The youth was dressed by locals and taken to a nearby hospital, but died during treatment. The police identified the deceased as Jigar Sailesh Solanki, originally from Bhavnagar. Police have filed a murder case and launched a probe to trace the unidentified assailants.

A statement issued by Zone-6 DCP Bhagirath T Gadwhi said, “An FIR has been registered regarding the death of 21-year-old Jigar Sailesh Solanki, who was beaten and sustained fatal injuries to various parts of his body inflicted by an unknown person. The incident occurred on the night of October 2, 2026, between 9:15 and 10:30 pm, within the compound of Tirthbhumi Apartments...”

According to the FIR, Solanki was a third semester student of the B.Voc. (Finance) course at Silver Oak University, Gota. He had been living in a PG accommodation earlier but

The deceased has been identified as 21-yr-old Jigar Sailesh Solanki from Bhavnagar; police have filed a murder case and launched a probe to trace the assailants

around two-and-a-half months ago, he and his paternal cousin had moved into his maternal uncle's home in Isanpur.

“On the night of the incident, he had left home on his motorcycle to meet a friend. Later, he was found in a critically injured condition at Tirthbhumi Apartments, the police statement said.

“Signs of physical assault were observed on his body, including several injuries. He was transported to LG Hospital for treatment via the ‘108’ emergency service, where the attending doctor declared him dead during treatment,” the statement further read.

In a video statement, DCP Gadwhi said Solanki had been conscious at the time he was found by some residents of the society. He managed to give them his name and contact in-

formation of his family members, with which the residents managed to inform his family. However, they could not glean any information as to who attacked him.

DCP Gadwhi told mediapersons, “We sent his body for panel postmortem and according to the inquest panchnama, most of the injuries are on his (Solanki) back and thighs, where he appears to have been repeatedly struck with a stick.”

“But we are waiting for the autopsy report as there may be internal injuries that may not have come to the attention of police personnel on the scene,” he added.

The police managed to find the clothes of the deceased near the scene of crime and a forensics team as well as the dog squad were called in to help investigate the same. The Crime Branch is also aiding in the investigation, said the senior officer.

On the basis of Solanki's statement, an FIR was registered at the Isanpur police station against unidentified persons under Section 103(1) of the BNS.

DCP Gadwhi said, “We are investigating it could be responsible... We have not yet found any particular reason or motive.”

At J&K hospital, burqa ‘restriction’ sparks protest, inquiry ordered

Express News Service
Jammu, October 3

A PROTEST this week by nursing interns over alleged restrictions on wearing burqas inside the Gynae Department's labour room at Government Medical College and Hospital in Doda, Jammu and Kashmir, has prompted the hospital administration to set up a seven-member inquiry panel.

Trouble erupted on Wednesday when scores of nursing interns held a demonstration inside the hospital premises against Dr Madhu Chib, head of the gynaecology department at Doda Medical College, alleging that she had objected to their wearing of the burqa.

Protesters boycotted work and gathered outside the hospital building. One protester said that a day earlier, Dr Chib had moved a student out of the labour room because she was wearing a veil. Dr Chib has not commented on the allegation.

“We saw two more students made to stand outside the labour room on the same grounds,” she said, calling it an interference in their religious matters.

The protest was called off after the hospital administration intervened and Dr Chib clarified that her objection to the burqa was confined to ensuring hygiene compliance in sensitive areas such as labour rooms and operation theatres.

The hospital management also set up a panel to look into the circumstances leading to the protest.

Dr Irfan Tassaduq, the in-charge medical superintendent of Doda GMC Hospital,

confirmed the development and attributed the protest to a “miscommunication”.

“She [the doctor] had asked them to tighten their loose gears and wear a gown (apparel) over them according to the protocol in the labour room and operation theatre,” he said.

“In such sensitive areas, where the risk of infection to patients runs high, even doctors have to observe these protocols.”

The protest has drawn reactions from political leaders.

While Doda MLA Mehraj Malik took up the matter with Health Minister Sakina Itoo, ruling National Conference chief spokesperson Tanvir Sadiq expressed concern, saying that the Constitution of India guarantees citizens the right to freely practise their religion.

“Whether a woman chooses to wear a hijab or not is a matter of her personal choice and autonomy, and no one should impose restrictions on it,” Sadiq said.

This is not the first time Dr Chib has been involved in a public controversy. She had previously lodged a police complaint against Aam Aadmi Party MLA Malik in May last year, alleging that he had made abusive and gendered remarks against her on social media.

Malik, who has criticised the functioning of hospitals in Doda and raised the issue in the J&K Assembly, had denied the allegations and accused the doctor of engaging in private practice at a local nursing home during official duty hours.

‘2027 poll winnability is critical for both Cong, Samajwadi Party’

UTTAR PRADESH Congress chief **Aradhana Misra** speaks to **Maulshree Seth** about her experience of working with Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, her immediate priorities, and the expected alliance between the Congress and the Samajwadi Party (SP) for the upcoming Assembly polls. Excerpts:

You have taken charge of the UP Congress very close to the 2027 elections. How do you see your challenges?

It is a very big challenge. I am grateful to the senior leadership for giving me this responsibility. I come from a legacy of four generations in the Congress. My great-grandfather and grandfather were freedom fighters. My father, Pramod Tiwari, had a political career spanning 47 years. But I was not brought directly into electoral politics.

My journey began at the grassroots. I became a panch in 1998, when I was around 19. In 2001, I became a block pramukh. Alongside this, I worked in the Congress organisation at the state level. So, I have seen politics from the grassroots upwards.

You travelled with Priyanka Gandhi Vadra across UP during 2019-2022. How did that experience shape you?

When Priyanka ji came to UP in 2019, I accompanied her extensively. She already had an association with me because she used to be in-charge of Amethi and Rae Bareilly, which are close to my constituency. We had a strong bond.

Between 2019 and 2022, I travelled across the state with her. It gave me the opportunity to see the Congress organisation closely: its strengths, weaknesses. I became the Congress



Legislature Party leader after that. So this responsibility is also a continuation of the organisational work I have been doing.

As a woman leader heading the UP Congress, what would be your roadmap?

Challenges always come with responsibility. There is nothing new about that. Being a woman in politics does not bother me anymore. But yes, women have to work a little more because there are so many responsibilities.

Have been fortunate that my party leadership understood these challenges. They promoted me and protected me. Congress has always believed in women's participation and empowerment. The party gave the country its first woman PM, its first woman President and UP's first woman CM. I am another example of that tradition.

Saharanpur MP Imran Masood has been appointed the working president of the state Congress. How do you see the two of you working together?

I see his appointment as strengthening the team. We have to work together to reach

workers and strengthen the organisation at the grassroots. The responsibility is not of one person. We need to work collectively — with the working president, new vice-presidents, senior leaders, district and state leaders and the entire cadre.

What are your immediate organisational priorities?

I would like to connect with every Congress worker and go as deep as possible, right down to the booth level. The booth has to be strong to win an election.

With so little time left for the polls, it may not be possible to do everything I want. But my agenda is to strengthen the existing organisational structure.

Do you think the alliance between the Congress and the SP could be another major challenge for you?

Winnability is the most important factor because we are contesting an election to win and form the government. Our objective and mission for 2027 is to form the government and oust the BJP. So, winnability is a major marker — not only for the SP but for the Congress as well.

But I want to clarify one thing. The INDIA alliance was formed at the central level. Therefore, seat-sharing and when the alliance will be announced — all of that will be decided by the central leadership.

Is alliance a more daunting issue in the Assembly polls?

The Assembly election has different stakes because there are many local claimants. But the 2024 Lok Sabha success has given our workers clarity about the importance of our alliance, and we will work together.

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, RAYAGADA Email ID-ccerwcrayagada@gmail.com						
25001/1239/2627 Letter No.3031 Date: 28.09.2026 NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING THROUGH GePNIC e-Procurement Notice						
1.	Name of the work	:	Construction of Building works for the year 2024-25, 2025-26 & 2026-27 (13 Nos)			
2.	Class of contractor	:	“B” & “A” of (Odisha PWD) or relevant class of other licensing authority.			
3.	Estimated Cost	:	Varies from Rs.284.42 Lakhs to Rs.120.99 Lakhs (Approximately)			
4.	Details projects	:	As per Annexure attached			
	Procurement Officer		Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender online for bidding	Last Date & Time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of tender
	1	2	3	4	5	6
	Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Rayagada	NCB-16/RWCRGDA/2026-27	From 11.00 A.M.	To 5.00 P.M.	Up to 5.00 P.M.	Will be intimated later
5. The details of works can be seen from the web site https://www.tendersorissa.gov.in						
6. Any Corrigendum/Addendum will be displayed in the above e-tender web site.						
						Sd/- Chief Construction Engineer, R W Circle, Rayagada
OIPR- 25001/25196/1/26-27/0033						

दानपुर छावनी परिवर्द्ध कार्तिकी छठ पूजा 2026 व्यवस्था महेनजर निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना	
दानपुर छावनी परिवर्द्ध कार्यालय कार्तिकी छठ पूजा 2026 के आलोक में घाटी एवं निदेशित स्थानों पर विभिन्न व्यवस्था हेतु ईन्ड्रक निविदाकार से e-procurement portal site https://defproc.gov.in/nicgep/app माध्यम से अलग-अलग निविदा आमंत्रित करती है। विवरण निम्न प्रकार है:-	
क्रम सं०	निविदा/ठेके का नाम
1.	छावनी क्षेत्र के गंगा घाटी पर बालू बिछाने, गिराने एवं आवश्यक घाट अथवा स्थान तक पहुंचाने हेतु।
2.	छावनी क्षेत्र के गंगा घाटी पर कन्ट्रेलर रुम की व्यवस्था जिसमें लाईट (10 मेटल एवं 15 ट्यूब) जेनरेटर, माईक, एवं कुर्सी इत्यादि की व्यवस्था
3.	छावनी क्षेत्र के गंगा घाटी पर नाच, सोंबिंग रुम, बैनर, पुआल, चाली बिडिबेगाणी, गेट व्यवस्था एवं आवश्यकतानुसार पार्किंग की व्यवस्था करने हेतु।
4.	छावनी क्षेत्र के गंगा घाटी, मार्ग एवं अन्य बताने जहाँ पर बैरिफेन्डिंग व्यवस्था हेतु।
महत्त्वपूर्ण विधिवी निम्न प्रकार है:-	
1.	प्रकाशन की तिथि
2.	ऑनलाईन दस्तावेज डाउनलोड के शुरुआत की तिथि
3.	निविदा भरने की प्रारंभिक तिथि
4.	ऑनलाईन दस्तावेज डाउनलोड के शुरुआत की तिथि
5.	पंजीकरण हेतु शुल्क जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि
6.	तकनीकी दस्तावेज के खलते की तिथि

नोट- (i) निविदा दस्तावेज ऑनलाईन उपलब्ध है और भारत सरकार के e-procurement portal site <https://defproc.gov.in/nicgep/app> पर ही ऑनलाईन आवेदन दे सकते हैं। निविदा के आवेदन के लिए निविदाकार के पास अंकित अधिकारी द्वारा प्रमाणित Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) होना आवश्यक है। (ii) निविदाकार को सक्षम पंजीकारों द्वारा प्रमाणित आवरण एवं चिह्न प्रमाण पत्र, आवसीय प्रमाण पत्र, अनुपत्र प्रमाण पत्र इत्यादि निविदा पत्र के साथ अपलोड करना अनिवार्य है। क्रम सं० 1 से 4 तक का निम्न एवं सही अलग-अलग अपलोड करना होगा जो अलग-अलग दिया गया है। (iii) पंजीकरण शुल्क m-collect(<https://echhawani.gov.in/citizen/language-selection>) द्वारा जमा हो मान्य होगा। जमा करने के उपरान्त छावनी परिवर्द्ध के सेल (ceodana-stats@nic.in) पर सूचना दिया जा सकता है या फिर कार्यालय में सचित स्वीड जमा कर सकते हैं। (iv) किसी तरह का संशोधन या सूचना e-procurement portal site पर दी जायेगी। केन्द्र अथवा राज्य सरकार द्वारा लिये गये निर्णयानुसार, समय-समय पर दिनांक वाले छठ संशोधित दिशा-निर्देश भी अनुक्रमीय होगा।

पंजीकार: श्री.डी.ए.सी.छठ/2026-27

दिनांक 04/10/2026

SD/XXX
मुख्य कार्तिकी अधिकारी,
दानपुर छावनी

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PMGSY CIRCLE BATOTE.

SHORT NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS

E-NIT NO:-PMGSY/SE/B/35 OF 2026-27 DATED:- 30/09/2026

List of Important Dates of Bids for Maintenance of roads including Initial Rectification, periodic Renewal, Emergency Maintenance and 5 year Routine maintenance after completion of Last Renewal

Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Batote, on behalf of Lt. Governor J.K. (UT) invites on line percentage rate tenders one-procurement portal <https://pmgsytenders.jk.gov.in> from the Contractors registered inappropriate class/category with J.K. P.W.D. or Contractors of equivalent categories registered with other States/Central Government. Departments, Institutions, Undertakings and Authorities on standard schedule of rate given below for the packages shown in the column 2 of table, for Initial Rehabilitation (IR)/ Periodic Renewal (PR)/ Routine Maintenance(RM) for five years after completion of Renewal Work on roads, constructed under Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana.

Name of Work: Renewal Coat of Road Dumber to Hawal, Package No. JK04-323, Length: 6.60 km, Block Interwal, District Kishtwar, under C&T

Estimated Cost (in Rs.) LACS

Completion Period of Initial rectification (IR), Periodic Renewal (PR), Routine Maintenance (RM) and Emergency Repairs (in Days)

Total Estimated Cost (in Rs.) LACS

IR PR RM Emerey Repairs

Cost of Documents (Rs. in Lacs)

Bid Security (EMD) (Rs. in Lacs) to be submitted in the contract

Whether First Call

S. NO. S. No. of District Name of PUJ No. of Roads Total Length of Road (in Km.)

Initial Rehabilitation works (IR) Estimate Routine Maintenance (RM) Renewal of Blunt non Blunt non Surface Emergency Works

Part-I (Rs. in Lacs) Part-II (Rs. in Lacs) Part-III (Rs. in Lacs) Part-IV

01 JK04-323 Kishtwar Chawno 6.60 Km - 82.24 165.03 - 247.27 90 days (3Months) 2 Years* As and when required 0.10 4.94 4th

1. Maintenance Period is 5 years from the date of completion of last Renewal

** All renewal shall be completed within two years of start of this contract i.e. from the start of work order.

** Routine maintenance on Performance based Maintenance concept shall be carried out on any stretch of road for period not less than 5 years. The time period of this contract is 7 years i.e. within two years. All the Periodic Renewal are to be completed as specified & the remaining all roads shall be maintained as Routine maintenance for 5 years

Position of AAA & TS = Accorded

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen / downloaded from the departmental website www.pmgsytenders.jk.gov.in as per below schedule.

1 Date of Issue of Tender Notice 30/09/2026 (1500 Hrs)

2 Period of Downloading of bidding documents From 30/09/2026 (1600 Hrs) to 10/10/2026, (1700 Hrs.)

3 Date and time of pre-bid meeting 01/10/2026 (1200 Hrs) Office of Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Batote

4 Bid Submission Start Date 01/10/2026, (1600 Hrs.)

5 Bid Submission End Date 10/10/2026, (1700 Hrs.)

6 Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bids (Online) 12/10/2026 on or after 1200 Hrs. in the Office of Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Batote

7 Date & Time of Opening of Financial Bids (Online) To be notified after Technical bid evaluation is completed

Sd/-

Superintending Engineer PMGSY Circle Batote

For and on behalf of The Government of Jammu and Kashmir

No: PMGSY/SE/B/5529-5603

Dated: 30-09-2026

DPII-11655/26 - DATE 03.10.2026

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT, CIRCLE NO-1 RAIPUR (C.G.) Tender Notice

Contractors, Registered appropriate class in Unified Registration System [e-Registration] invited Online tenders for the following works:-

NIT No./ System Tender No.	Name of Work	Probable amount of contract
1	2	3
217/200444	CONSTRUCTION OF RCC ROOF WITH COLUMNS AND FOOTING IN PLACE OF TIN SHED AT OLD BUILDING OF BAR ASSOCIATION IN CIVIL COURT CAMPUS, RAIPUR (C.G.) (1st Call)	Rs. 63.97 Lakh
216/200442	SPECIAL REPAIR WORK AT ATAL EXPRESS WAY, RAIPUR C.G. FOR R.O.W PROTECTION WORK OF UNAUTHORISED ENTRY/EXIT ON CARRIAGE WAY (1st Call)	Rs. 16.85 Lakh
218/200445	RENOVATION I/C ELECTRIFICATION WORK AT BOYS HOSTEL NO. 01,02,03, IN SCIENCE COLLEGE CAMPUS, RAIPUR (DEPOSIT WORK) (1st Call)	Rs. 149.91 Lak
173/200538	S/R, MOW, DEPOSIT AND OTHER WORK OF VARIOUS ROADS ARANG & MANDIR HASOUD SECTION UNDER SUB-DIVISION SURVEY RAIPUR (C.G.) (2nd Call)	Rs. 20.50 Lakh
219/200579	AMC OF FIRE FIGHTING & FIRE ALARM SYSTEM OF CG SADAN,CG NIWAS DWARKA,CG BHAWAN, TRIBAL YOUTH HOSTEL DWARKA, AT C.G. BHAWAN DIVISION NEW DELHI (1st Call)	Rs. 60.26 Lakh
220/200580	ANNUAL OPERATION AND MAINTENANCE OF STP SBR PLANT (50 KLD), WTP PLANT AND RO PLANT (2000 LPH) OF CG NIWAS, DWARKA, NEW DELHI (1st Call)	Rs. 14.60 Lakh

NIT No. 217 System Tender No.200444, NIT No. 216 System Tender No.200442 NIT No. 218 System Tender No.200445, NIT No. 219 System Tender No.200579 & NIT No. 220 System Tender No.200580 Last date of tender Download Date up to 19.10.2026 Time 17:30 PM & NIT No. 173 System Tender No.200538 Last date of tender Download Date up to 14.10.2026 Time 17:30 PM

● Note :- All eligible/interested contractors are mandated to get enrolled on the e Procurement portal (<https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>) in order to download the tender documents and participate in the subsequent bidding process.

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer
RO NO 262703684/2 P.W.D. Raipur Circle No-1, Raipur (C.G.)

WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY

No JBPC/NFR/E-Tender-26, Date 01/10/2026

DRM (Commercial) Jabalpur, on behalf of president of India invited e-Tender for the earning and leasing contracts from Jabalpur Division. Details are as under:-

Sr. No.-1 Category : OOH, Tender /E-Auction Notice No. : ADVT-JBP-JBP-OH-167-26-2, Assets Details : Build, operate, and transfer of Gantry Gate at Jabalpur and Madan Mahal Station (50% time sharing for display of commercial advertisements and 50% for display of RAILWAY information), Media-LED/other upgraded digital moving display. Total: 2 No. Gentry Gate, **Lot Start Date Time : 05-10-26 (10:00:00), Lot End Date Time : 05-10-26 (10:30:00)**

Sr. No.-2 Category : (Advertising -On Station Premise (Non-Digital)), Tender /E-Auction Notice No. : ADVT-JBP-JBP-OSN-94-23-1, Assets Details : Advertisement through Flex Board and Glow Sign board at Jabalpur Railway Station, **Lot Start Date Time : 09-10-26 (11:00:00), Lot End Date Time : 09-10-26 (11:30:00)**

Sr. No.-3 Category : (Advertising -On Station Premise (Non-Digital)), Tender /E-Auction Notice No. : ADVT-JBP-DMO-OSN-161-26-1, Assets Details : Advertising through Flex Board 1100 sq.ft. at Platform,concourse, FOB, Ramp, **Lot Start Date Time : 9-10-26 (11:10:00), Lot End Date time : 9-10-26 (11:40:00)**

Sr. No.-4 Category : Misc-Static-Services -Two wheeler and other parcel packing services), Tender /E-Auction Notice No. : MSS-JBP-REWA-TWnOPS-167-26-1, Assets Details : Contract is for two-wheeler vehicle packing at parcel offices of Rewa, Satna, Katni, Katni Muwara, Sagaur and Damoh of Jabalpur division West Central Railway for a period of five years, **Lot Start Date Time : 09-10-26 (15:00:00), Lot End Date time : 09-10-26 (15:30:00)**

Sr. No.-5 Category : (Food tray advertisement on Back of seats of trains), Tender/E-Auction Notice No. : MMS-FTA-127872-1-26-4, Assets Details : Advertisement through Vinyl Stickers on Snack/Food Trays (Seat-Back Meal Trays) in the Sitting Coaches of Train No. 11705/11706. Prospective bidders are requested to kindly visit the site / divisional office before the E-Auction regarding assets., **Lot Start Date Time : 12-10-26 (10:00:00), Lot End Date Time : 12-10-26 (10:30:00)**

Sr. No.-6 Category : (Food tray advertisement on Back of seats of trains), Tender/E-Auction Notice No. : MMS-FTA-155494-1-26-2, Assets Details : Advertisement through Vinyl Stickers on Snack/Food Trays (Seat-Back Meal Trays) in the Sitting Coaches of Train No. 22189/22190, 11651/11652, 11265/11266., **Lot Start Date Time : 12-10-26 (10:10:00), Lot End Date time : 12-10-26 (10:40:00)**

Prospective bidders are requested to visit e-Tender Leasing module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned catalogue No. E-Tender information is also available on the notice board of Divisional Railway Manager (Commercial), West Central Railway, Jabalpur.

(Sd.)
Divisional Railway Manager (Commercial)
West Central Railway, Jabalpur

स्वच्छ भारत अभियान एक कदम स्वच्छता की ओर

Government of Odisha e-Procurement Notice

INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)
34001/936/2627

Bid Identification No. C.C.E.DKI. (R&B) 13/2026-27 Email ID-sedklpjd@gmail.com

Letter No. 2120 Dt. 01-10-2026

The Chief Construction Engineer, Dhenkanal (R&B) Circle, Dhenkanal on behalf of Governor of Odisha invites Percentage Rate bids in double cover system to be received in ONLINE MODE from eligible contractors for Road & Building works as detailed below:

1. Name of the work	: Road & Building works
2. No of works	: 09 (Nine) Nos
3. Estimated Cost	: Rs.1.26 Crore to Rs. 7.59 Crore (as given in column No. 03 of table)
4. Cost of tender paper	: Rs 10,000.00
5. Class of contractor	: 'B' Class, 'A' Class & 'Special' Class (as given in column No. 07 of table)
6. Period of Completion of work	: 06 (six) to 09 (Nine) calendar months (as given in column No. 08 of table)
7. Date and time of availability of bid	: From Dt.09.10.2026 to 5.00 P.M. of Dt.23.10.2026
Document in the website	: Dt.26.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M.

India must protect its archives



ARUN KUMAR

AS I began to write this article, two distant but related pieces of news caught my attention. The first was in a magazine of the University of Nottingham's Manuscript and Special Collections, which mentioned that in the 17th century East Midlands (a region in the UK), there were about 45 Parish libraries, out of which 25 have still survived today. Parish libraries were run from churches and were often collections of books of individual clergymen. The Manuscript and Special Collections division, which houses the rare collection of these books, is organising an exhibition, titled Secret and Sacred Libraries, effectively opening the local ecclesiastical book heritage to a wider public. It was heartening how historic libraries and collections that continued to be preserved are being celebrated.

The other news, again broadly relating



RENUKA PURI

to the religious world, was slightly depressing. In an investigation, *The Indian Express* reported that over 2 lakh books of the Tulsi Sadan Library, a library under the Indian Union Ministry of Culture, have been homeless for 15 years. These books have been trapped in boxes and are awaiting shelves and readers since they were dislocated from the National School of Drama in New Delhi in 2011, when it was shut due to the construction of a Delhi metro station. Tulsi Sadan Library was opened in 1972 to commemorate 400 years of Ramcharitmanas and encompasses rare and special

These books are a window to the world that may have gone, but they talk about a world that defines us

books in 14 Indian languages.

Libraries and archives are not immune to dislocation or temporary shutdowns. They are. But when they are not rehabilitated and given a better place promptly, they lose their value and significance. Libraries and archives have a rhythm with readers who have their own rhythms of reading, writing, and appreciating a historical collection. When the two are disturbed, a rare collection library loses not only its prime customers but also those who can place its collections in a proper literary and historical context.

Specific and local rare book collections — whether it is the Tulsi Sadan Library or the collection of Lucknow's famous press, now archived, the Munshi Nawal Kishore Press (founded in 1858) or the rare books of the Rampur Raza Library in Uttar Pradesh — are as powerful a heritage as the Ashokan pillars and the Taj Mahal. These books are a window to the world that may have gone, but they talk about a world that defines us as who we are, how we think, and how we behave. History lives in us. The only ways to reach that deep part of ourselves are rare books, our built heritage, and our collective memory, which is gradually fading.

We must act before it is gone. I do not

want to only lament, although that is the natural emotional response after reading such news. As a practitioner of history, author of a book, and a frequent user of rare books, archives, and special collections across the world, I would like to recommend practical steps for our governments, heritage bodies, and libraries and archives.

Protect our rare book heritage by preserving books as they are, by training and employing archivists, by digitising historical works, and most importantly, by facilitating and welcoming readers. Digitisation and preservation do not automatically mean easy access; rather, sometimes they can mean restrictions if appropriate software platforms are not being used to classify and search records, if trained and passionate archivists are not there to welcome readers, and if access to collections is made through a myriad of bureaucratic paperwork. To make India a knowledge capital, we must preserve, protect, and open our libraries, archives, and collections for everyone. We must strive for "knowledge without barriers".

The writer is an Assistant Professor at the University of Nottingham

P Vaidyanathan Iyer's *Off the Record* will be back in a fortnight

Political change needed now



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

WE LIVE in interesting times. These words are borrowed from what is believed to be a Chinese curse, which is used against enemies to wish turbulence and turmoil upon their lives. I prefer to think of 'interesting times' as a blessing compared to boring times, of which there are too many. I find the times we have been living through for the past few months interesting because they seem to herald change in a political landscape that has been drearily unchanged for very long.

Last week almost all our political parties decided to use Gandhi Jayanti as a launch pad for separate campaigns to unseat the Chief Election Commissioner. In Delhi, there was noise and chaos at Jantar Mantar, because of the government's decision to deny permission for large gatherings at this famous protest site. Of course, there were supporters of the Cockroach Janta Party, but sadly so were Aam Aadmi Party leftovers and sundry commies, who have suddenly surfaced to ride on the cockroach wave and recover ground with a generation of Indians they failed to woo in the past.

So, as a political columnist with an overdeveloped sense of responsibility, I watched and watched. What I found fascinating was the contrast between the calls to action by the INDIA bloc and by the Cockroach Janta Party. It gave me an unexpected insight into why the opposition parties have failed spectacularly to get support from ordinary people and why the cockroaches have done so much better. India's most important opposition leaders gathered in a closed room, where cameras were allowed in for a photo before deliberations began.

As I saw the lineup of political princelings and princesses all seated together, I found myself wondering if they realised how bored Indian voters are with the kind of electoral feudalism they represent. And how much better the Cockroach leaders looked as they wandered about the streets of Mumbai, stopping to talk to people and urging them to come to their rally. It was the sort of thing all politicians did when I first became a reporter, but now, it is only the 'cockroaches' who understand how important it is to mingle with ordinary voters. And this is before they have entered politics or started a political party. If they do, it is my fervent hope that they do not become like politicians that we already have.

India's voters have limited choices. On one side there is that team of political heirs who inherited their political parties, ideas and privileges from indulgent parents. This genre of politician is what Prashant Kishor famously called 'potted plants' in an adda at *The Indian Express*. Personally, I prefer to think of them as political businessmen. Their reason for embarking upon the noble task of 'serving the people' is mostly to take over the family businesses they have inherited. It surprises me not even slightly that they have failed so shamefully to win elections since the Modi era began.

On the other side is the BJP that inevitably has lost its way because of being in power too long. This party believes it will continue to remain in power because of the 'charisma' and 'visionary leadership' of Narendra Modi. So, what they offer in every election now is just those things while going through the motions of following his lead. On Gandhi Jayanti, senior ministers and other acolytes could be seen with brooms in hand, sweeping up spaces where there was no garbage. Had they been sincere about honouring Gandhiji, at least they would have tried to do their sweeping in filthy places that, sadly, are far too many in our fair and wondrous land.

This hypocrisy has become their leitmotif. When it was decided that the Prime Minister's birthday would be celebrated with a month of 'seva', they pretended to be doing real social work in villages and slums, but as soon as the cameras lost interest, so did they. I would not be exaggerating even a little when I say that the BJP has become almost as undesirable for voters as the INDIA bloc because although they bang on about how much India has changed, the ordinary voter knows that it has changed mostly in the glossy and very expensive promotions we see on television.

The gall of BJP chief ministers is remarkable. They pose against a backdrop of magnificent highways and factories, declaring that states like Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh have been transformed. If the money wasted on advertising were spent on real things like schools, hospitals, and cleaning our rivers, India would truly be transformed, but this has not happened and nor is it likely to. This is why the 'cockroaches' have found it so easy to connect with the people where the opposition leaders have failed.

The response of the Prime Minister and the chief of the RSS has been to try to communicate with this generation of restless, angry young Indians, to try and speak to them on Instagram in Gen-Z words and gestures. But so far this has not worked in their favour because the young people they are trying to reach are much smarter than voters once used to be. And, they have shown with their campaigns for better governance, better schools and better elections that they understand these things well and what to reject. Interesting times, would you not say?

The writer is an officer of the Indian Revenue Service (Income Tax)

Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly 'She Said' column



INSIDE TRACK | BY COOMI KAPOOR

LESSONS FROM PAST

The BJP has downplayed the gravity of *The Indian Express* investigations, highlighting 14 occasions in 10 months when two ECs differed with the Chief Election Commissioner over the implementation of the election process, including changes to the ECIN software, by terming it as a "normal part of institutional deliberation leading to unanimous decisions". The history of past differences between EC members suggests otherwise.

When the three-member commission concept was introduced in 1993 under PM PV Narasimha Rao, the two new ECs, MS Gill and GVG Krishnamurthy, protested that CEC TN Seshan continued to conduct the commission as a one-man show. They were not consulted, and no meetings were held before important decisions were taken. Seshan ignored their objections and approached the Supreme Court to affirm his supremacy. But the court held that each member of the constitutional body had equal rights.

Following Seshan's term, the rule of majority has always prevailed. On the rare occasion when two commissioners, the late Navin Chawla and SY Qureshi, concurred in 2009 against then-CEC N Gopalaswami's decision on serving a notice to Sonia Gandhi for receiving the Order of Leopold in 2006 from the Belgian government, the CEC was overruled.

During the 2019 Lok Sabha election, Ashok Lavasa disagreed with then CEC Sunil Arora about giving a clean chit to the PM and home minister for alleged violations of the model code of conduct. Lavasa subsequently insisted he would not attend meetings unless his minority decisions were recorded.

It is therefore important to know whether CEC Gyanesh Kumar in fact held formal three-member meetings with documented minutes on contentious issues.

TATA SEPTEMBER COUP

Those who choose to view the confrontation between the Tata Trusts and the runaway Tata Sons Board as a mere personality clash between the trusts' chairperson, Noel Tata, and Tata Sons executive chairperson, N Chandrasekaran, fail to read between the lines. It is fairly obvious that powerful interests are at work to hobble Noel Tata, who seems to be running a three-legged race against unseen opponents who have strong tailwinds propelling them forward.

September was indeed a star-crossed month for the legendary House of Tata with a pincer attack from all sides. Surely, not just a coincidence? To begin with, the RBI, on September 11, rejected the Tata Sons' application to surrender its Core Investment Company (CIC) status, even though the Tatas had faithfully completed a significant financial restructuring by clearing Rs 21,813 crore of debt in order to ensure that the holding company had no access to public funding. The Tatas followed the precedent set by Shangvi Finance, which owns Sun Pharma, and had been permitted to surrender its registration and get regulatory relief in 2023. However, the RBI immediately rejected the Tata Sons' application for exemption from its revised 2022 regulations for the public listing of Tata Sons. The RBI simply changed the goal post!

The second shock was a sudden U-turn by the Tata Sons Board from its long-stated position of opposing public listing of the group. The board mysteriously decided not to challenge the RBI's September 11 decision. A month earlier, Chandrasekharan had informed the board that he would be stepping down as chairperson when his second extended term expired in February, but on September 17, the Tata Sons board voted to reappoint Chandrasekharan, despite the objections of the Sir Dorabji Tata and Sir Ratanji Tata trusts that own 66 per cent of Tata Sons. It is unlikely that any court would eventually rule the proceedings of this meeting legal, but litigation can drag on).

In September, the Maharashtra charities commissioner, mysteriously, prohibited the Sir Ratanji Trust from holding a board meeting and taking formal decisions while the commission conducted an inquiry into frivolous charges trumped up by disgruntled persons being eased out of Tata trusts. Now trustee Venu Srinivasan, who falls in this category, has demanded the charities commissioner inquire into the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust as well. For over 150 years, founder Jamsetji Tata's simple mandate to his descendants was to do good for India. Do those at the helm of government reciprocate this trust?

WHAT'S IN A NUMBER?

Famous personalities often apply for numbers for motorcar license plates that they deem lucky. For instance, Amitabh Bachchan is believed to favour numbers that end in two/add up to two; Sanjay Dutt opts for 4545 and Shahrukh Khan 555. The late NTR chose 9999, as his descendants now do. Arun Jaitley's preference was 6666. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph Vijay has started a new trend. In his 2024 film, *The Greatest of All Time* (GOAT), the hero drove a limousine with the number plate TN CM 2026. Seeing how prophetic that number turned out to be, Vijay's ally Thol Thirumavalavan, leader of the VCK, has been in a video-shoot in a car with a TN 07 CM 2031 number plate. Now NTK leader Seeman has applied for the number TN 08 CM 2031.

A confrontation that reshaped the Election Commission



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY SHUBHAM KUMAR

IN OCTOBER 1993, TN Seshan was away in Pune when Delhi altered the institution he had come to personify. A former Cabinet Secretary, TN Seshan had taken over as Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) in December 1990. The President, on October 1, appointed two Election Commissioners alongside him: MS Gill, a senior IAS officer who would later succeed Seshan as CEC, and GVG Krishnamurthy. An ordinance issued the same day laid down that the business of the commission would, as far as possible, be transacted unanimously and, where its members disagreed, by majority.

Three years into office, Seshan had brought the Election Commission into public consciousness by taking on governments over the conduct of elections and forcing politicians accustomed to a relatively unobtrusive poll body to reckon with an increasingly assertive one.

The Constitution, however, had never confined the Election Commission to a single member. Article 324 provided for a Chief Election Commissioner and "such number of other Election Commissioners, if any", as the President might from time to time fix. For much of independent India, the commission had functioned with only the CEC. But it briefly had a multi-member body, when, in October 1989, weeks before the general election, the Rajiv Gandhi government appointed SS Dhanoa and VS Seigell as Election Commissioners alongside CEC RVS Peri Sastri. After a change in government, the President, on January 1, 1990, returned the commission to its single-member form.

Dhanoa challenged the abolition of his post before the Supreme Court. The court rejected his case in 1991, holding that while the Constitution required a CEC, the appointment of more Election Commissioners was not obligatory. The judgment, however, left unresolved the question that would soon become central to Seshan's own case: if other commissioners were appointed, what authority would they exercise in relation to the chief? The court had observed, in passing, that the chief stood in a distinctly



Election Commissioners Krishnamurthy, Gill meet with their chief, Seshan. EXPRESS ARCHIVE

higher position.

Two years later, the appointments of Gill and Krishnamurthy changed the way power was exercised within the Election Commission. The ordinance issued on October 1, 1993, gave both commissioners an equal voice in the commission's decisions and provided that where unanimity was not possible, the majority would prevail. For Seshan, the institutional consequences were immediate. A CEC who had come to embody the institution in public life could now be outvoted within it.

The dispute quickly reached the Supreme Court. Journalist and political commentator Cho Ramaswamy filed the first challenge on October 13, 1993. Seshan followed with his own petition on October 26, challenging both the ordinance and the appointments of Gill and Krishnamurthy. By December, the court had concluded that the questions raised went directly to the interpretation of Article 324 and referred the matter to a Constitution Bench. While the petitions were pending, the ordinance was replaced without material change by legislation on January 4, 1994.

Seshan's argument rested substantially on the special position Article 324 gave the CEC. The Constitution protects the CEC from removal except in the same manner and on the same grounds as a judge of the Supreme Court. Other Election Commissioners may be removed on the CEC's recommendation. To Seshan, these distinctions suggested that the Constitution had placed the chief above the other members of the commission and that this hierarchy should extend to the commission's decision-making as well.

A five-judge Constitution Bench led by Chief Justice AM Ahmadi rejected that proposition in July 1995. It upheld the 1993 arrangement and the appointments of Gill and Krishnamurthy, holding that the CEC's stronger

protection against removal did not translate into superior decision-making authority.

The court treated the CEC's stronger protection from removal as a safeguard for institutional independence, not as a source of greater voting power. Once a multi-member commission had been constituted, its members were to decide matters collectively. Any other reading, the court reasoned, would reduce the other Election Commissioners to little more than advisers.

In practical terms, the settlement placed the CEC in the position commonly associated with primus inter pares, or first among equals, in the commission's decision-making. The CEC was chairperson, but where unanimity failed, the statutory rule of majority would govern.

For Seshan, this was a striking outcome. His years at Nirvachan Sadan had been defined by an effort to establish the authority of an institution often treated as administratively peripheral. Yet his own challenge compelled the Supreme Court to explain that the strength of the Election Commission could not depend entirely upon the authority of a single office-holder.

Three decades later, recent differences within the Election Commission have given that history renewed relevance. It remains instructive precisely because collegiality was never meant to eliminate disagreement, only to contain it within a constitutional framework.

That was the irony of Seshan's legacy. He did more than perhaps any predecessor to make the CEC's office visible and formidable. Yet the case bearing his name helped establish that the commission itself was larger than his chief.

The writer is a constitutional lawyer specialising in public law

What do we tell a girl who asks 'was it me?'

IT WAS SEVEN years old. My swimming class had ended, and I was walking to the changing room when I sensed a presence behind me. I turned and found a member of the swimming complex staff charging towards me. In that split second, I shouted. My mother came rushing, and the man made an excuse about being there to protect me. As a cop's daughter, I have grown up around men. And the prepubescent me, informed about "good" and "bad" touch, could instinctively identify an improper gaze. While I immediately told my parents what had happened, in the hullabaloo that followed, the incident was resolved.

My parents were careful not to let me or themselves become paranoid, because even though nothing untoward happened, the trauma could have set in. As I confided in my parents, however, the incident made me aware of a reality that I was not just a child, but a girl. I wish this realisation had not come to me so early in my life.

After losing my father as an adult, I became acutely aware of some older men who tried to show me unwanted avuncular affec-

tion. Again, there was no incident, but my skin crawled each time, and I began despising any conversation with them.

What changed over the years? Only that my awareness of this reality grew deeper.

So, when I read a news report about a minor rape survivor who told a court that the man she called "uncle" should be kept in jail until he grows old, my skin crawled again. The matter pertained to an incident that took place in July 2023, when the girl was seven. After announcing the verdict, the judge read out a personal message to the child, and now the Delhi High Court has ordered that the message be delivered to the child along with the compensation. My skin crawls while writing this article too. The judge further wrote that the court cannot give the child her childhood back but that the court had heard her words.

The judge also lauded the child's courage in identifying the man, recounting the truth and speaking up. Even today, some of my relatives dismiss the incident at the swimming complex, arguing that a child couldn't have known. They remain firm in their belief



SHE SAID
BY KATYAYANI
SANJAY
BHATIA

that the man had indeed been there to protect me. This is infantilisation. Would we say the same to a seven-year-old boy who alleges that he has been attacked? If the answer is no, we need to ask why our lens is coloured for girls and gendered crimes.

As per the National Crime Records Bureau's Crime in India 2024 Report, in cases pertaining to Section 4 (penetrative sexual assault) and Section 6 (aggravated penetrative sexual assault) of the POCSO Act, only 1,492 cases of a total of 44,126 involved an unknown or unidentified offender. This effectively puts the focus on why these wounds go so deep. Studies have documented how childhood trauma can lead to the development of insecure attachments, emotional dysregulation, and relational challenges in adult relationships.

The judge's "message of encouragement" goes beyond that one child. It acknowledged the wound that the seven-year-old was carrying. I have forgotten much, but that evening after the swimming class remains fresh in my memory. It came as a baton of strength to the woman who, after losing her

father, had to battle the unwanted male attention that came in the garb of concern. When the judge lauded the child's courage, I felt exonerated, vicariously and personally.

How can we tell the child that there will be a time she will have to devise her own handbook on how to deal with the male gaze? That she will have a drill of what to wear when using public transport? That she will be asked whether she "asked for it"? That she will need nerves of steel, veins of iron and a numb mind to ignore the stray palms that brush against her, even inside her home. How can we tell her this, for she will ask us the question we are unprepared to answer: Was it my clothes? Was it my body? Was it me? Did I do anything to "ask for it"?

Women do not need a handbook that instructs them in avoiding violence. We need a handbook, as a society, to prevent violence.

The writer is an officer of the Indian Revenue Service (Income Tax)

Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly 'She Said' column



REGIONAL, EUROPEAN NATIONS PROVIDING DEFENSIVE MILITARY AID, SAY OFFICIALS

Saudi plans assault to break Houthi blockade in Red Sea

Operation to be led by Yemeni forces supported by Saudi air strikes: Officials

Reuters
Riyadh, October 3

SAUDI ARABIA is planning an offensive against Iran-backed Houthi militants in Yemen, with options being considered including a coastal push to secure the Red Sea route or an assault on multiple fronts, regional and Western officials told *Reuters*.

The operation, expected to be launched in the coming weeks, will be led by Yemeni forces on the ground, which are overseen by Riyadh, and supported by Saudi air strikes, according to six people with knowledge of the preparations.

While US is already providing intelligence to support Riyadh's operations in Yemen, and some regional and European nations are providing mainly defensive military aid to the kingdom, the Saudi allies aren't expected to play a direct role in combat operations, said people who requested anonymity.



Black smoke rise from an oil facility in Riyadh on Saturday. AP

ity to discuss security matters.

A key objective of the planned Saudi offensive, which hasn't been previously reported, is aimed at reversing the rapid gains made by the Houthis last month when they advanced down the coast and seized control of the Bab el-Mandeb strait, according to the people with knowledge of the plans who include Gulf and Yemeni officials and Western diplomats.

The Saudis are considering two possible options for the assault, the Gulf and Yemeni officials said: Either a narrowly focused attack on the area around Bab el-Mandeb or a broader offensive that also includes other

synchronized attacks on multiple fronts around Yemen, in the governorates of Al-Bayda, Marib, Taiz and Al-Jawf.

Spokespeople for the Saudi and Yemeni governments, the Houthi group and the US military didn't immediately respond to requests for comment about the Saudi plans. The six people with knowledge of preparations couldn't give a precise timing for the launch of the offensive, with their estimates ranging from within a week to until after US midterm elections in November.

Michael Ratney, a former US envoy to Saudi Arabia, said he expected an offensive to be narrowly focused and certainly

Fire, smoke seen near Aramco oil facility in Riyadh

Riyadh: A large plume of smoke and fire was seen rising in the vicinity of an Aramco facility in Riyadh on Saturday, a witness told *Reuters*.

There was no confirmation from Saudi authorities about the fire. Aramco did not respond to a request for comment. The fire comes amid escalating hostilities between Saudi Arabia and Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis, who have stepped up attacks on Saudi cities and energy infrastructure. There was no immediate claim of responsibility for Saturday's fire.

REUTERS

more modest in scope than the Saudi-led operation in 2015 that sought to rout militants.

"As much they want to vanquish Houthis, they also need to get back to status quo before Houthis controlled territory along Bab el-Mandeb," he added. "Ideally, it would be a limited operation to retake areas and go back to normal maritime traffic."

Man arrested in Fairford air base investigation released on bail

Reuters
London, October 3

BRITISH COUNTER-terrorism police investigating a suspected plot involving an air base used by the US said on Saturday they had released on bail a dual UK-Iranian national who had been arrested on suspicion of preparing terrorist acts.

The 25-year-old man was detained on Thursday over the incident last weekend involving the RAF Fairford base in western England from where US bombers have taken part in raids against targets in Iran.

Police confirmed he had now been released, and searches at two properties in London had concluded. "The investigation into the circumstances surrounding events in Gloucestershire is continuing," police said in a statement.

The incident near Fairford began in the early hours of last Sunday when five British men in their 20s were arrested near three vans on suspected terrorism and explosive offences.

The men were later released without charge on police bail "under stringent conditions", and although detectives said petrol was found in the vans, no improvised explosive device was present.

Russia vows more Kyiv strikes, urges diplomats to leave city

Reuters
Kyiv, October 3

RUSSIA SAID on Saturday it would continue to carry out targeted retaliatory strikes on Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities and urged foreign nationals and diplomats to leave the capital.

In a statement, the Russian Foreign Ministry said that "in response to the Ukrainian Armed Forces' terrorist acts against the civilian population and civilian infrastructure of our country, the Armed Forces of the Russian Federation are continuing to systematically carry out targeted strikes on military facilities in Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities".

"The Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs once again warns foreign nationals, including diplomatic mission staff, against staying in Ukraine or travelling to its territory," it said adding "Responsibility for any adverse consequences lies entirely with those who ignore this warning."

Russia has recently escalated strikes on infrastructure in the Ukrainian capital, hitting a bridge across the Dnipro river in an air attack on Saturday. The intensifying campaign has upended life for the capital's 3 million residents ahead of the bitter winter months.

Russian President Vladimir Putin said this week that Ukraine was paying the price for its own attacks on Russia and would continue to do so as Moscow's forces systematically strike different targets there.

Meanwhile, Moldovan President Maia Sandu said Saturday that the war is "dangerously reaching" her country, following a spate of airspace incursions.

"I condemn Russia's attack on Ukraine this morning. Its



A rescue worker extinguishes a fire at a residential house destroyed by a Russian airstrike in Kharkiv region, Ukraine on Friday. AP

Will hit Russian oil refineries in response to airstrikes: Zelenskyy

Kyiv: Ukraine will double down on attacking Russian oil refineries in response to a new policy of airstrikes by Moscow designed to force people to abandon Kyiv and other cities, but won't target civilians, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said.

Ukrainian intelligence has obtained documents showing Russian leader Vladimir Putin issued a "new doctrine" of military attacks on a much broader range of civilian targets ahead of this winter, Zelenskyy said.

"We saw documents and we know that they allow them attack infrastructure ... logistics ... roads, schools, hospitals, to pressure people to leave the capital, leave different cities," Zelenskyy said. "This is the goal of the operation."

Driving the shift in policy, Zelenskyy said, was Putin's desire to appear strong at a time when his military was losing ground in frontline region and sustaining higher levels of casualties.

Zelenskyy said an Ukrainian counteroffensive, code-named "Vivaldi", had recaptured around 140 sq km of Donbas region, which Russia has said it must control as a condition for any peace deal.

REUTERS

Tennessee prisons chief resigns after botched execution

Associated Press
Nashville, October 3

THE HEAD of Tennessee's prison system is resigning, Gov. Bill Lee announced Saturday, the first major shake-up since the stunning failed execution of Christa Pike landed her on a ventilator at a hospital.

Frank Strada, commissioner of the Department of Correction, will step down this month, Lee said. Strada said in a statement that resigning was "in the best interest of Tennesseans" while an independent review determines what happened Wednesday when the state failed to execute Pike despite administering two doses of a lethal drug.

"I believe this review is entirely appropriate and necessary, and I look forward to doing everything I can to help determine exactly what occurred," Strada said.

Pike was taken to a hospital, where she was on a ventilator and unconscious in the following hours, her attorneys said in a court filing Friday.

Hospital staff were working

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Department of Correction Commissioner Frank Strada

to save Pike's life and, as of late Thursday, were trying to clear the two doses of pentobarbital, which the state uses to execute

prisoners, lawyers said.

The shocking failure has left both sides of the death penalty debate demanding answers. Lee has ordered an independent review and halted any new executions.

Strada said he believes the state "carried out its responsibilities in accordance with the established protocol."

Pike's legal team welcomed Strada's departure but said "it does not help Christa now."

"What happened to her Wednesday reflects a systemic failure that goes far beyond any

one person," the four-lawyer team said.

"We hope the governor's call for a full, independent review will expose the profound problems within Tennessee's entire death penalty system."

Pike's attorneys said they believed problems with the IV lines caused the pentobarbital to flow into her body instead of her bloodstream.

Strada took over the Correction Department in January 2023 after serving as deputy director of the Arizona Department of Corrections.

Brazil Presidential election today pits Lula against Bolsonaro's son

Associated Press
Rio De Janeiro, October 3

MILLIONS OF Brazilians will vote Sunday in an election dominated by two rivals: incumbent President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva and Sen. Flavio Bolsonaro, the son of ex-leader Jair Bolsonaro, whom Lula defeated four years ago.

Twelve candidates are on the presidential ballot, but only Lula and Bolsonaro are thought to have a real chance of becoming Brazil's next head of state. If no candidate receives more than 50 per cent of the vote, the top 2 will advance to a runoff on October 25.

Lula, who, at 80, is one of the world's oldest heads of state, is running in his seventh presidential election. Bolsonaro, 45, is competing in his first and seeking to return his family name to power after his father governed Brazil from 2019 through 2022.

The two represent opposite sides of the political spectrum, with conflicting visions on issues ranging from how to tackle organised crime to the relationship Latin America's biggest country should have with the Trump administration.

Lula has repeatedly warned the US not to meddle in Brazil's elections. The Trump administration did not respond to a request for comment on whether it is seeking to interfere in the vote.



A Palestinian man carries an item at the site of an Israeli strike on an apartment building in Gaza City on Saturday. REUTERS

fire, has stepped up strikes on the group in recent weeks.

Hamas has denied trying to carry out attacks or rebuild its arsenal and accuses Israel of undermining the Gaza peace deal. Friends, including Muslims, and relatives gathered at the Saint Porphyrius Church in Gaza City to pay their respects during the funeral of the Christian mother and daughter.

In a statement later on Saturday, the Greek Orthodox Patriarchate of Jerusalem mourned Maisa Abu Dawoud and her daughter, Mary, extending condolences to their family.

Israeli strike kills five in Gaza, including 4 women

Reuters
Cairo, Gaza, October 3

AN ISRAELI airstrike killed at least five Palestinians, including four women, in an apartment building in Gaza City early on Saturday, health and civil defence service officials said.

Among the dead were a Christian mother, Maisa Abu Dawoud, and her daughter Mary, medics and the church said. There was no immediate comment from the Israeli military. The strike destroyed the building and started a fire.

"We were asleep and suddenly heard continuous strikes and heavy explosions. The children woke up startled and started running and screaming," said witness Ahmed Al-Dahdouh.

"We ran out and found our neighbour's house was struck and there were dismembered martyrs, women, men and children. We started to pull them out, they were scattered under the rubble," he told *Reuters*.

Israel, which says Hamas has been rearming and launching attacks in violation of the cease-

Tens of thousands protest across Spain as housing crisis deepens

Reuters
Madrid, October 3

TENS OF thousands of people took to the streets of Madrid and other Spanish cities on Saturday as they stepped up demands for action to tackle a mounting housing crisis after government measures were struck down by the opposition.

Some demonstrators waved posters calling for a general strike after the measures drawn up to address mass anger over the eviction of an 87-year-old woman in Madrid, and other housing issues, were rejected in parliament on Friday.

"It's a shame," said Nando de Angelu, 26, who joined Saturday's protest in Madrid. "It only proves that it is us the people who have to adapt to the political parties, and not the politicians to what the people want, and this can't go on like that."

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez might call a snap election for November after the legislation failed to pass, Spanish media reported on Friday, and would be watching the strength



Protesters demonstrate demanding political action to stop evictions and alleviate the housing crisis, in Madrid on Saturday. REUTERS

of Saturday's protests before making a decision.

Sanchez's office refused to comment on the reports. In the southeastern city of Valencia, demonstrators clashed with police who fired rubber bullets and tear gas to break up protests.

About 30 protesters managed to get inside the City of Arts and Sciences, a landmark cultural building in the city, before they were ousted by police. Other demonstrations in 50

Spanish cities were peaceful.

Valeria Racu, spokeswoman for the Tenants Union, told reporters in Madrid that a general strike would be called after talks with labour unions.

About 70,000 protesters took part in Saturday's demonstration in Madrid, the Spanish government said.

Protests planned in Barcelona and the nearby city of Hospitalet de Llobregat were called off because of heavy rain.

• BRIEFLY

FRANCE

France to step up Ebola funding in Congo amid resurgence fears



Civil Protection members wearing PPE in Bunia, Ituri province, Congo. REUTERS

FRANCE WILL step up its support for efforts to eradicate Ebola in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo, Foreign Minister Jean-Noel Barrot said on Saturday during a visit to a region hit by the virus, warning that it could quickly resurge if vigilance waned.

Barrot made rare trip by a Western leader to the northeastern Congolese city of Bunia, where a laboratory-confirmed case of mpox was identified in mid-September. France allocated \$15.1 million to fight Ebola between January and July. Barrot said he would propose additional humanitarian funding for Ebola during French budget discussions. "Ebola may seem far away to some people or political leaders, but it can return quickly," Barrot said.

REUTERS

KENYA

17 pilgrims killed in road accident on highway

A CRASH involving multiple vehicles on the highway to the Kenyan coastal city of Mombasa on Saturday killed 17 people, most of them pilgrims on the way to a prayer site, officials said. The crash in Salama area happened after midnight when a truck driver tried and failed to overtake another truck, police said. That caused a collision with vehicles including a van carrying pilgrims. AP

UNITED STATES

Plane with 6 on board missing off Nantucket

A PLANE with six people aboard lost contact during a flight from Bermuda to Boston, and the US Coast Guard said it was searching early Saturday for the missing aircraft off coast of Nantucket. The Coast Guard said the Federal Aviation Administration reported that the Gulfstream G100 had lost contact Saturday morning. The search for jet included crews in the air and on the water, Coast Guard said. AP

• THE GOVERNMENT, SEEKING TO DIRECT HOW PEOPLE USE THE TECHNOLOGY, HAS RESPONDED BY IMPOSING NEW REGULATIONS AND JUDICIAL GUIDELINES ON ITS USE — AND MISUSE

China wants its citizens to embrace AI, but fears they depend on it too much

Yan Zhuang
October 3

AS CHINA's government pushes its citizens to embrace artificial intelligence, it is confronting a problem partly of its own making: overreliance on the technology.

State media reports have featured stories that serve as cautionary tales: a farmer who lost 25 acres of seedlings after asking an AI for advice, children who have become so attached to chatbots that they want their parents to speak like them and AI-generated micro dramas with characters that look like carbon copies of one another.

These cases and others have

raised concerns in China that as it rushes to catch up with the United States in AI, it is running into adverse side effects created by the new technology, which is accused of undermining human relationships and depriving people of their better judgment.

The government, seeking to direct how people use technology, has responded by imposing regulations and judicial guidelines on its use — and misuse.

The response reflects how the ruling Communist Party is trying to balance its ambitions to promote the widespread use of AI with a desire to avoid anything that might undermine social order, say analysts.

The party is "recognizing

that the more they develop the technology, the more there's going to be social challenges that they have to deal with," said Scott Singer, a fellow and co-director of the China AI Initiative at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace. "Where the party is sensitive is any area where they feel like the technology is getting better in a way that fundamentally could disrupt social stability."

Singer said the party is particularly sensitive to disruptions caused not only to human relationships but also the job market as AI threatens to replace workers.

Concerns about overuse are shared among China's citizens,



People at World Artificial Intelligence Conference in Shanghai. FILE

who say they see the spread of the technology as inevitable even as they question its benefits and tire of its ubiquity.

Xie Tong, a graphic designer in Beijing, uses AI in her own work at a consulting agency and can no longer imagine her life

without it. But she despairs at encountering AI all around her — in the subway ads that she sees on her commute and in the work of contractors at her job who obviously relied on AI.

"It's like a marriage where you curse your partner but you can't leave them," she said.

For a time, China's AI push created a boom in virtual companion apps, including ones offering romantic partners, personal tutors and AI avatars of family members.

In a country already struggling with a shrinking population and a historically low birthrate, the proliferation has led to concerns from Beijing about AI replacing human relationships.

State media quoted experts saying people could soon find it hard to navigate real interactions. Reports cited a 2025 survey by the China Youth and Children Research Center of more than 8,500 minors that showed more than 20 percent "only wanted to chat with AI and did not want to talk with real people."

That mirrored the concerns of some parents like Vivian Lyu, a stay-at-home mother in Hangzhou who two years ago introduced her 5-year-old daughter, Polly, to Doubao, an AI assistant created by ByteDance, the parent company of TikTok.

Soon, the child was chatting with the A.I. and a personalized

companion on the app nearly every day. At first, Ms. Lyu thought the AI was good at keeping Polly entertained when the mother had to take care of household tasks. "When you feel like you don't have a choice, you use Doubao," she said.

In July, the government imposed limits on A.I. companions that require platforms to step in if users exhibited unhealthy dependencies. Under the new rules, platforms must intervene if users show signs of self-harm.

The rules also banned virtual relationships between chatbots and minors, which forced ByteDance to shut down the feature on Doubao that allowed users to create companions.

NYT

DISCUSSION TO BLEND IMPORTED COAL WITH DOMESTIC SUPPLIES GOING ON

Coal stocks down 66%, raising concerns ahead of next summer

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, October 3

REBUILDING COAL inventories ahead of next summer was the “main concern”, officials said amid a “neck-to-neck situation” as stocks at domestic coal-based power plants plunged 66% — from around 54.9 million tonnes at the beginning of April to 18.6 million tonnes by the end of September.

With rainfall in parts of northern and eastern India, there has already been some moderation in electricity demand and officials maintained they expect the demand to further ease as the summer heat recedes and the country moves into the post-summer demand pattern.

This will ease some pressure on coal-based power plants and allow them to rebuild inventory by March, officials told *The Indian Express*.

“The concern is not for this year but for next year. This year things will be neck-to-neck as there is a lot of pressure on thermal power plants in the absence of hydro-power due to rainfall deficit. The main concern is rebuilding the stock by March be-

fore the onset of next summer,” a senior official involved in power system operations told *The Indian Express*.

The depletion of coal inventories at domestic coal-based power plants this year is the highest in the past three years.

Fuel stocks at domestic coal-based power plants have declined by around 66% this year, compared with a decline of around 23% during the same period last year, when stocks fell from 55.2 million tonnes at the beginning of April to 42.6 million tonnes by the end of September. The same was 31.8% in 2024 and 36.8% in 2023 for the same period.

Push for increasing stock

Officials expect the situation to improve with better availability of railway rakes for transporting coal to power plants, along with an increase in coal production. Coal India Limited, the country's largest coal miner that accounts for about 83% of the coal supplied to the power sector in India, also reported a 918% increase in coal production during September compared to the same month last year.

COAL INVENTORY



YEAR	BEGINNING OF APR	END OF SEPT
2026	54.9	18.6
2025	55.2	42.6
2024	47.8	32.6
2023	34.5	21.8

FIGURES IN MILLION TONNES
SOURCE: NATIONAL POWER PORTAL

“Supplies to the power sector also registered strong growth of 10.63%, during the month rising to 48.90 million tonnes (MT) from 44.20 MT in previous fiscal,” the state owned miner informed exchanges on Thursday. Coal supplies to thermal power plants depend heavily on logistics, particularly the availability of railway rakes, as a large share of India's operational coal-based generation capacity is located away from the coal mines.

“October and November are typically crucial for rebuilding stocks as demand usually moderate during this period. While there has been some heating demand during the peak winter, usually this is the

period when coal stock rises,” another senior official told *The Indian Express*.

Blending of imported coal under discussion

This year, higher-than-projected demand has already raised concerns over power availability, with the government moving to take additional measures to maximise generation from available capacity. Among these measures, the power ministry has directed around 112 captive coal-based power plants to operate at maximum capacity from October 1 to December 31.

Apart from this, there has also been discussion on direc-

ting thermal power plants to blend imported coal with domestic supplies, officials aware of the matter told *The Indian Express*. However, no final decision has been taken on the issue so far. While the government has issued advisories on blending imported coal with domestic supplies from time to time in the past, such advisories have not been issued beyond October 15, 2024.

At the same time, there is a push to add more battery energy storage systems (BESS) over the next six months, particularly at the inter-state transmission system (ISTS) level.

The move is aimed at addressing the growing gap between the availability of solar power during the day and the higher demand for electricity after sunset, when generation from solar projects falls sharply.

One of the senior officials quoted above said at least five to six major renewable energy companies are planning to add around 10 gigawatts of battery energy storage capacity by March. Queries sent to the Ministry of Power did not elicit any response till the time of filing this report.

‘Letting weaknesses build has simply too high a cost’

Siddharth Upasani,
Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, October 3

CALLING FOR continued vigilance despite a prolonged period of financial stability, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Saturday said that he does not see any imminent signs of stress.

However, he warned that “today's resilience may not necessarily imply tomorrow's immunity” as India's experience over the past two decades has shown that banking and financial stresses “can build overnight, but take years to resolve and can be very painful”.

Noting that the world has weathered repeated shocks since the Covid pandemic, with the global economy being rather resilient, Malhotra said these periods of prolonged stability can encourage risk taking and fade memories of past crises.

“Even in India we have had a very prolonged period of financial stability... But I may like to point out that it is these very prolonged periods of stability that can encourage risk taking and leverage. Fading memories of past crises can weaken the appetite for prudence.... We need to remain alert to these risks,” Malhotra said.

“It took us more than a decade to clean up the legacy of excessive lending and NPAs from the early 2000s, so we cannot afford to become complacent. The economic and financial costs of allowing vulnerabilities to build are simply too high,” he said, speaking at the annual Kautilya Economic Conclave, organised by the Ministry of Fi-



Any corrections in AI related valuations in advanced nations ‘may have positive impact in terms of capital inflows’ for India. REUTERS

nance and the Institute of Economic Growth.

Malhotra's comments come amid heightened global tensions, with PK Mishra, Principal Secretary-1 to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, also pointing out at the same event that the world is confronted not just by risk but also uncertainty.

The RBI Governor said the financial system has absorbed the supply shock due to the West Asia conflict quite well. As a result, growth has been resilient. However, the global economic environment continues to remain “challenging”, with the conflict having “exacerbated not only inflationary pressures but also elevated financial system vulnerabilities,” he said.

Malhotra also said geopolitical and geoeconomic fragmentation, strategic realignment, trade restrictions, repeated supply shocks, technological disruption, and climate change are interacting in ways that are difficult to predict. Moreover, they are “even more difficult to

model using historical relationships”, he said, adding that price and financial stability cannot be looked at in isolation.

Listing the possible maturing of the AI investment cycle and any resultant slowdown in earnings of these companies as a risk, Malhotra said they could trigger “sharp repricing” of financial assets. “High risk appetite has spurred an increase in leverage, which, along with declining cash flow among major AI firms, would further amplify market corrections and financial market volatility,” he said. At the same time, he pointed out that any corrections in AI related valuations in advanced countries “may have positive impact in terms of capital inflows” for India.

The global AI investment boom has largely bypassed Indian stock markets due to the country's low exposure to the new technology.

As a result, domestic benchmark indices have fared poorly.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Brokers caution proposed IRDAI reforms could hurt jobs & customer service

George Mathew
Mumbai, October 3

INSURANCE BROKERS have opposed the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India's (IRDAI's) proposed reforms on insurance distribution, cautioning that the broad commission caps and a one-third cut in insurers' expense limits could weaken customer service, reduce jobs and slow insurance expansion.

The Insurance Brokers Association of India (IBAI) said the measures could undermine insurance brokers, who are legally required to act in the customer's interest, unlike tied agents. Brokers compare policies, negotiate coverage and help policyholders with claims. The association questioned why an independently appointed broker should receive less remuneration than an insurer's tied agent.

It cited regulator data showing 69% of complaints against general insurers relate to claims, while 63% of complaints are decided in customers' favour.

“Weakening the one participant whose duty runs to the customer cannot serve the customer,” an IBAI spokesperson said.

In its response to IRDAI's consultation paper, ‘Reforms for Recalibrating Economics of Insurance Distribution’, IBAI said it supported measures to protect policyholders, improve transparency and curb mis-selling. These include a ban on compulsory insurance bundling with loans, enforceable suitability requirements, commission clawbacks in

WHAT BROKERS SAY

MEASURES COULD undermine insurance brokers, who are legally required to act in the customer's interest, unlike tied agents

BROKERS COMPARE policies, negotiate coverage and help policyholders with claims. The association questioned why an independently appointed broker should receive less remuneration than an insurer's tied agent

proven mis-selling cases, disclosure of related-party payments and identity tagging of salespersons.

However, the main objection of brokers is to the proposed framework's more than 30 commission caps across products and distribution channels, along with the proposed reduction in insurers' overall expense limit.

Impact on costs, jobs and insurance access

IBAI also challenged the basis for the proposed caps. It said IRDAI's figures show that general insurers' total expenses of management fell from 28.2% of premium in 2022-23 to 26.5% in 2024-25, even as premiums grew by about 13% annually.

The association said the reported rise in commissions was mainly driven by the reclassification of payments from other expense heads — an issue it said was acknowledged in the consultation paper. Instead of blanket caps, IBAI recommended conduct and fair-value rules for segments where customers have limited choice.

The association warned that the proposals could also affect employment and insurance access in smaller towns. As of March 31, 2025, brokers sponsored 14.81 lakh of India's 27.18 lakh point-of-sale persons and 16,230 of 26,316 motor insurance service providers. Many are self-employed operating in tier-2 and tier-3 towns. IBAI said commissions below the cost of servicing customers could force distributors to leave smaller markets. It also warned that cutting insurers' expense limits by more than 30% over five years could lead to reductions in sales, servicing and claims staff.

Retention of 2023 expense framework

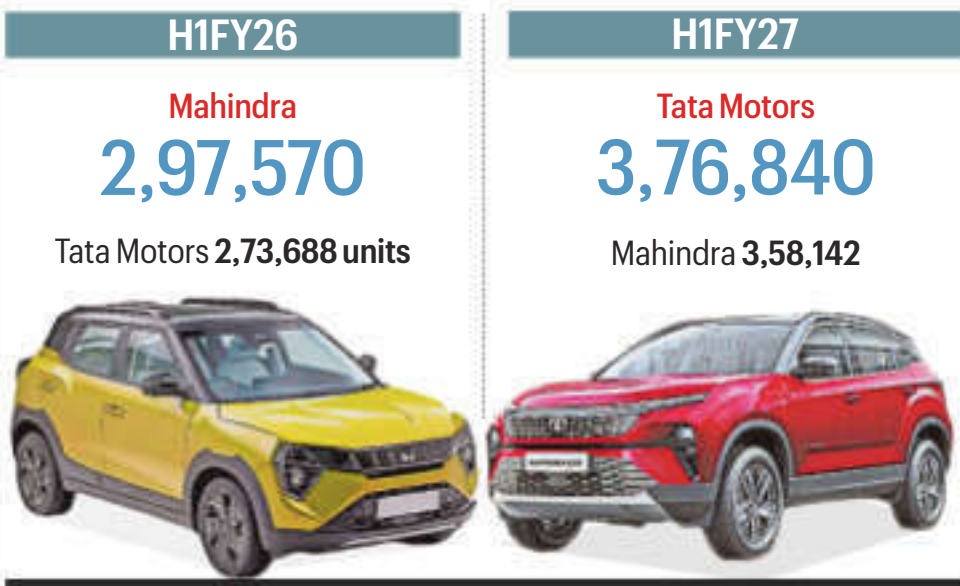
According to IBAI, reduced distribution reach could undermine the government's ‘Insurance for All by 2047’ target. It questioned replacing the 2023 framework before its scheduled 2028 review and without a regulatory impact assessment, particularly after the sector was opened to 100% foreign investment.

IBAI has urged IRDAI to retain the 2023 expense-management framework, limit commission caps to credit-linked and other coerced-choice sales, exempt commercial and large risks, and publish a regulatory impact assessment before drafting regulations.

The association said it would submit its detailed response by October 25, adding that its opposition was not to reform but to measures that, in its view, may not deliver tangible benefits to policyholders.

Tata trumps Mahindra as battle for India's No. 2 carmaker intensifies

TURNING THE TABLES



SOURCE: INDUSTRY DATA

Vikram Chaudhary
New Delhi, October 3

TATA MOTORS has overtaken Mahindra to become the second-largest carmaker in the first half of the ongoing financial year (H1FY27), as the tables turned in this competitive landscape where Maruti Suzuki leads by a big margin. In the same period of the previous year (H1FY26), Mahindra was trailing India's largest carmaker.

Sales data sourced from the industry shows that Tata sold 376,840 cars in H1FY27, almost 20,000 units more than Mahindra's 358,142 units. But just six months ago, Mahindra had a comfortable lead over Tata — in FY26, Mahindra sold 660,276 units, almost 10,000 more than Tata's 651,261 units. Even a year ago, Mahindra was the leader — in H1FY26, Mahindra (297,570 units) had a substantial lead over Tata (273,688 units).

Automotive analysts told *EE* that new launches in the mass-market segment gave Tata the much-needed push. “Tata launched the Punch ICE facelift in January, followed by

the Punch EV facelift in February, and then the new Tiago ICE and EV in May,” an analyst said. “These sub-4-metre cars priced under Rs 10 lakh gave Tata's sales a boost, at a time when GST 2.0 was already turning customers towards small SUVs. Month-on-month sales prove that.

“In April, Tata sold 59,000 cars, then in May 59,090 cars, June (62,076), July (62,611), August (65,253), and September (68,810). In contrast, Mahindra, which didn't have an all-new product barring the electric XEV 9S and the XUV 7XO — both at the upper end with on-road prices of most variant upwards of Rs 20 lakh — had a slower sales uptick. In April, it sold 56,331 units, May (58,021), June (60,393), July (60,048), August (59,257), and September (64,092 units).”

He added that while Mahindra has built an envious presence in midsize and large SUVs, Tata has silently developed a high-volume floor with small cars across multiple powertrains — petrol, diesel, CNG, and EV. *EE*

Nayara hikes petrol price by Rs 5, diesel by Rs 3

New Delhi: Nayara Energy, India's largest private fuel retailer, has raised petrol prices by Rs 5 per litre and diesel by Rs 3 with immediate effect, seeking to narrow the gap between retail prices and rising international oil and refined-product costs, people familiar with the matter said.

The latest increase comes amid renewed pressure on fuel retailers from higher global energy prices and follows a series of price adjustments by Nayara this year as refiners grapple with the impact of geopolitical disruptions on crude and product markets.

Nayara, which operates 7,108 petrol pumps across the country, raised petrol and diesel prices with effect from early hours of Saturday, sources said.

An email sent to Nayara spokesperson for comments remained unanswered.

Nayara was the first fuel retailer to pass on the surge in international oil prices to consumers when the Iran conflict disrupted energy supplies earlier this year. On March 26, it raised petrol prices by Rs 5 a litre and diesel by Rs 3, taking the rates at its outlets to Rs 100.71 and Rs 91.31 a litre, respectively, at the time.

State-owned fuel retailers subsequently began raising pump prices in May. They increased petrol and diesel prices in a series of staggered moves, with the cumulative increase reaching about Rs 7.50 a litre each by late May. *PTI*

G20 discussed curbing impact of govt-backed excess mfg capacities

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, October 3

G20 TRADE ministers have discussed preventing large production capacities — created with government support in some geographies — from hurting manufacturing in countries that follow fair trade practices, including India, the US and Europe, Commerce and Industry Minister Piush Goyal has said.

Replying to questions from the Indian diaspora in Chicago about the G20 trade ministers meeting, which concluded late evening on Friday in Milwaukee, Goyal said the members also discussed the future of several elements of the World Trade Organisation (WTO), which is currently under severe stress, including the fact that many countries are using predatory pricing as they have overcapacity, and are dumping goods, much to the detriment of honest and fair trade.

Replying to questions from the Indian diaspora in Chicago about the G20 trade ministers meeting, which concluded late evening on Friday in Milwaukee, Goyal said the members also discussed the future of several elements of the WTO, which is currently under severe stress, including the fact that many countries are using predatory pricing as they have overcapacity, and are dumping goods, much to the detriment of honest and fair trade.



Commerce and Industry Minister Piush Goyal. REUTERS

“So, issues like this were highlighted by the United States... This G20 was under their presidency. And good discussions were held that we should all collectively work towards ensuring that certain geographies with very large production capacities, created at different points in time with government support, should not be allowed to hurt manufacturing in countries where fair trade and honest business practices are carried out, such as the United States or Europe or India,” he noted.

He said that though it was a fruitful set of conversations at the meetings, differences of opinion prevented the release of an outcome document.

India is the most preferred destination to set up data centres, citing low-cost infrastructure and energy, a large pool of young talent and tax-free benefits until 2047, he added.

THE EIGHT-COACH, NON-AC TRAIN WILL OPERATE ON A DUAL-FUEL CONFIGURATION, USING BOTH DIESEL AND LIQUEFIED NATURAL GAS

Despite near 100% electrification, why Railways launched LNG train

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, October 3

THE RAILWAYS has launched its first train that can run on liquefied natural gas (LNG).

The eight-coach non-AC train, flagged off from Sabarmati station in Gujarat, is not a new train, though. It is a modified version of an existing diesel-electric multiple unit (DEMU) train — which means it can run both on diesel and LNG. DEMUs, to be clear, are self-propelled trains (but more on that later). Using LNG will result in lower emissions than diesel. The national transporter, therefore, is planning to add LNG systems to more

DEMU trains following the September 27 launch.

But the plan to unveil more such dual-use trains raises questions. Why does Railways need LNG trains when its broad-gauge network is almost completely electrified? And why can't the train be hauled by an electric locomotive?

The answer lies in the very configuration, and purpose, of DEMU trains.

What are DEMU trains?

In Indian Railways, most trains are hauled by heavy, standalone engines, called locomotives. However, DEMU trains — and EMU (electric

multiple unit) trains — are “train sets” that don't have a separate locomotive.

Instead, their movement and control systems are built into passenger coaches at both ends. These coaches are called driving power cars, or DPC. Half of the space of a DPC is taken up by the power packs while the remainder is meant for passengers.

In the case of EMUs, the tractive power, essentially the energy to move the trains, is provided by overhead electric wires. In the case of DEMUs, a diesel engine generates electricity which then powers the train's electric traction motors. Since these DEMU train sets



The Railways has planned to convert more DEMU trains into LNG-powered systems. REUTERS

do not have the provision to attach a separate locomotive, they cannot be hauled by an electric one. That is why the conversion to dual-fuel sys-

tems with LNG have been found as an alternative to reduce emissions. In fact, the Railways recently launched a hydrogen train by modifying a

DEMU rake (or train set). This, however, is not a dual-power train and may not be viable for a mass rollout because handling hydrogen is difficult.

A senior official of the Ahmedabad railway division said that the latest DEMU-LNG conversion was done at a cost of Rs. 1.86 crore. The train will use 40% LNG and 60% diesel during its operation. The DPC retains the capability to operate entirely on diesel whenever required.

How important is this development?

The DEMU was first introduced in Indian Railways in 1994 for non-electrified routes,

with a 700-horsepower configuration. In 2002, the Integral Coach Factory developed 1,400-horsepower DEMUs, which were inducted in Railways to replace existing slow-moving locomotive-hauled passenger trains on non-electrified mainline sections and for low-traffic-density branch line services.

The high acceleration potential of DEMUs made the fast passenger services between cities suitable.

However, with the push to lower emissions in the Railways and 99.6% of the network now electrified, the question is what should be done with these trains. They also cannot

be easily withdrawn from service as many of them still have some operational life remaining. “The existing diesel-powered assets continue to remain available for operational requirements. Some diesel powered assets are also required to meet exigencies.

“The dual-fuel conversion enables productive utilisation of these existing assets while reducing conventional diesel consumption. It also provides operational flexibility, as the DPC can operate in both, dual-fuel or diesel-only mode,” said the senior official of Ahmedabad division.

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PERSONAL

I, SAPNA ZARWAL KAUSER D/o BALDEV RAJ ZARWAL Ex. W/o TEJESHWAR KAUSER, R/o APT 1303 TOWER K SHANTI VIHAR, AWHO SECTOR 95, WAZIRPUR (115), DIST: GURUGRAM HARYANA - 122505 declare that I got divorce from my husband Vide Court Divorce Decree HMA No. 644/2025 dated 15.11.2025 and I have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as SAPNA ZARWAL. 0040881665-9

I, Sandeep Kumar Gupta S/o Om Prakash R/o 3120, Mahendra Park Smudai Bhawan, Shakur Basti, Delhi-110034, have changed my name to Sandeep Gupta. 0040881665-9

I, ABID KHAN, S/o-SAFI MOHD KHAN, R/O D-19/3A, Second Floor, Okhla Vihar, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, hereby declare that my father's name is SAFI MOHD KHAN. However, in all my school and College records, my father's name has been recorded as "S M KHAN". I hereby state and declare that "S M KHAN" and "SAFI MOHD KHAN" refer to one and the same person, i.e., my father. 0040881681-2

I, TANVI AGGARWAL D/O JAGMOHAN AGGARWAL R/O PLOT NO. 1 ANAND NAGAR INDER-LOK ONKAR-NAGAR DELHI-110035, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO TANVI. 0040881686-7

I, RUBINA is wife of Service No. 22051805F, Rank- L/Nk Name- Mahamadrakif Hulakund, Presently residing at Goutan Oni, Dastikoppa, Bellagavi, Karnataka-591153 have changed my name from RUBINA to RUBINA MAHAMADRAFIK HULAKUND for all future purposes. 0040881679-4

I, SIMAR JEET KAUR, W/o-SARBJIT SINGH, R/o K-223/5, Khasra No. 369, Gali No. 9, Near Ashirwad Dental Clinic, Swaroop Nagar, Delhi-110042, do hereby declare that, SIMAR JEET KAUR and, SWARNJIT KAUR, are one and the same person. 0040881665-2

I, Usha Hans, W/o-Ankil Solanki, R/O H.No.-395, Solanki Mohalla, Shahabad Mohammadpur, Dwarka, Delhi-110059 have changed my name to Usha for all future Purposes. 0040881675-6

I, RAM RATTAN, S/O-ROSHAN LAL KHANNA, R/O B-37, GUJRANWALA TOWN PART-1, DELHI-110009 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAM RATTAN KHANNA. 0040881688-1

I, Sangamesh Ningappa Masali S/o Ningappa C Masali R/o VTC- Nagathana, District-Bijapur, Karnataka - 586112, have changed my name to Sangappa Ningappa Masali. 0071063860-1

I, Lucia Isidoror Kerketta, w/o-Prem Lal Bara R/O H.No-B-978, Gali No-29, Sant Nagar, Burari, Delhi-110084 have changed my name to Lucia Bara. 0040881686-9

I, AMREEN RIZVI W/o Jeevan Rizvi, R/O Flat No-16, First Floor, Mall Road, Double Storey, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi-110018, Have Changed My Name to SHEHNAZ RIZVI. 0071063875-1

I, hitherto known as MAHESH AGGARWAL S/O MATHURA PRASAD resident of 530 site 1 vikas puri, New Delhi-18, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as MAHESH CHAND. 0040881676-2

I, Rudraksh S/o Naresh Vashista residing at DR-275, Shyam Nagar palwal-Dist-Palwal-21102, Haryana, have changed my name, henceforth I shall be known as Rudraksh Vashista for all purpose. 0050298962-1

I, Leela Kishan, S/o-Ganga ram, R/O-18/36F, Basant Nagar, Kishan Ganj, Delhi-110007, I declare that Leela Kishan and, Lalit Kumar is the same name and one person i.e. myself. 0040881681-4

I, Reena Chauhan, W/O Bijender Singh R/O-Village-Gochi Baghcedha, Ghodi Bachhedha, Gautam Buddha, Nagar Uttar-Pradesh-201310, have changed my name Reena Rawal, for all purposes 0040881582-1

I, Dilip Kumar Soni S/O Dinanath Seth R/O Paththan Toli, Sasaram, Rohtas, Bihar - 821115, have changed my minor daughter's name from Sangani Soni aged 16 years to Ayushi Raj Soni forever 0071063862-1

I, Rishi Pal Solanki, S/O Mahavir H.No. 25, Pooth Kalan, 110086 have changed my minor Son's name from Nitansh to Jeelethan Solanki. 0040881679-6

I, Kalpna D/o Tinku R/O-A-965, Street No. 15, Mandoli Extension, Mandoli, Delhi-110093, have changed my name Kalpna to Kalpna Gautam 0040881665-4

I, Sukhdarshan Singh, Sukhdarshan Sidhu, S/O-Surinderjeet Singh, R/O-1064, sixth Floor, Tower-1, Zara Aawas, Sector-104, Dhanawpur, Gurgaon (Haryana)-122006, Have Changed My Name To Sukhdarshan Singh Sidhu for all purposes. 0040881675-8

I, Babita W/o Arun Kumar R/O E-3/6B, Shatabdi Vihar, Sector-52, Noida, UP-201301, have changed my name to BABITAAGARWAL for all future purposes. 0071063821-1

I, RAME S/O-LATE ATTAR SINGH, R/O C-48, BAPU PARK Kotla Maharakpur Lodh Road South DELHI-110003, have changed my name to RAMEY. 0040881686-2

I, REKHA, W/O-ANUJ KUMAR TOMAR, R/O-Plot No.588, Flat No.2004, Sector-1, Vaishali, Ghaziabad(U.P.)-201010, have changed my minor son's name from, SAXAM KUMAR TOMAR to SAKSHAM KUMAR TOMAR, all future purposes. 0040881686-11

I, Madho Chauhan, S/o-Ektar Singh Chauhan, R/o-575/2, Chauhan Mohalla, Madanpur Khadar, Sarita Vihar, Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Madho Singh Chauhan for all purposes. 0040881675-1

I, MALIKZADA MOHD HUMAYUN, D.O.B. March 15th, 1970, S/O Late MOHD MUSLIM R/O H.NO.98-99 HAJI BHAVAN CROCKERY MARKET SADAR BAZAR DELHI 110006, hereby declare that I have changed my name to MOHAMMAD HUMAYUN permanently. 0071063773-1

I, MEENAKSHI DAHIYA W/O RAKESH R/O 29 NR. GOVT MIDDLE SCHOOL SONIPAT ROAD NAGAR GOHANA SONIPAT HARYANA-131301, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MEENAKSHI. 0040881681-6

I, Prabhuvan Kumar Pasvan S/o Babu Lal Pasvan, 235/1, VP Singh Camp, Railway Colony, Tuglakabad, Delhi-44, have changed my name to Prabhuvan Pasvan. 0071063853-1

I, hitherto known as Ramawati Devi W/o Baban Shah residing at Dharkandha khurd, Semri, Rohtas, Semri, Bihar-802211, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Bidawati Devi. 0071063866-1

I, Neelam D/O Babulal R/O House No. G-1846 JJ Colony Tigri South Delhi, Delhi 110062 have changed my name to Neelam Kumari for all future purposes. 0071063825-1

I, RITA DEVI, W/O-ANIL SHAW, R/O Rc-340, Subhash Park Khora Colony Khora Gaon Ghaziabad Uttar pradesh-201309, have changed my name from, RITA DEVI to REETA DEVI, For all the future purposes 0040881679-8

I, ASHOK KUMAR, S/o-Panju Mal, R/O-Flat No. U and V-Block-31A, GF, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi-110086 have changed my name to ASHOK KUMAR SACHDEVA. 0040881665-6

I, Diwan Singh Yadav, S/O-NIHAL SINGH YADAV, R/O D-1201, PURI DIPLOMATIC GREENS, BAJGHERRA ROAD, SAI KUNJ, NEAR DWARKA EXPRESS WAY ,BLOCK-A, SECTOR-110, Choma (62), Gurgaon, Haryana-122017, Have changed my name to Diwan Singh 0040881675-10

I, Shitiz S/o Arun Kumar R/o E-3/6B, Shatabdi Vihar, Sector-52, Noida, UP-201301, have changed my name to SHITIZ AGARWAL for all future purposes. 0071063815-1

I, JAYA ANEJA, W/O-AYUSH ANEJA, R/O-Flat No-2404, Tower-C, Ivy County, Sector-75, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar, UTTAR PRADESH-201301, I have changed my name to JAYAARORA. 0040881686-4

I, Parteeek Kumar S/o Gautam kumar R/o H.No-B 10/259, Gali No-3, Brijpuri Gokul Puri, Delhi-110094 have changed my name to Harsh Kumar. 0040881679-1

I, Km Yasmeen, W/o-Mohd Tazimm, R/O-1009/779, South Khalapur, Jamiya Nagar, Muzaffarnagar, Uttar Pradesh-251002, have changed my name to Yasmeen for all purposes. 0040881675-3

My name is recorded as 'Mansi Sharma' in my son Ojas Sharma's school records, whereas my correct name is 'Mansi Dutt Sharma'. Mansi Dutt Sharma, W/o Khush Dev, resident of 1449/112, 2nd Floor, Gali No. 3, Durgapuri, Delhi-110093. 0071063775-1

I, Romita Bansali D/o Jaisingh Bhansali W/o Himanshu Gandhi R/O-C-70, Vivek Vihar Phase-1, Delhi-110095, have changed my name to Romita Bhansa 0040881681-8

I, Sandeep Kumar Gupta R/O-L-4, 402, Gulmohar Garden Rajnagar Extension Ghaziabad have changed my daughter name from Bhumi Gupta to Aradhya Gupta. 0071063856-1

I, Mohd Kasim S/o Abdul Wahid R/O H.No. A-1, Morna Near OBC Bank, Sector-35, Noida, UP-201301, have changed my name Mohammad Kasim for all purposes. 0071063868-1

I, RAM RATTAN S/O ROSHAN LAL KHANNA, R/O B-37, GUJRANWALA TOWN PART-1, DELHI-110009 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAM RATTAN KHANNA. 0040881665-8

I, Shaista parveen, W/O Nizamuddin, R/OA-72/1, Gali No.9 wazirabad Village Delhi, 110084, have changed My Name to Shaista for all purposes 0040881681-1

I, PARDEEP S/O SATKANWAR R/O 3 NEAR POST OFFICE RAMESH NAGAR BAWANA DELHI-110039, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO PARDEEP KUMAR. 0040881686-6

I, Archana Kumari W/O Ashok Kumar R/O 392, 4th floor, B-Block, Green Field Colony, Faridabad Haryana - 121010 Have Changed my Name to Archana. 0040881679-3

I, ASHWANI HOODA S/O Om Prakash Hooda R/O-Flat No. 81, Second-Floor Pocket-1, Sector-23 Rohini Delhi-110085, have changed my minor son name RANVEER to RANVEER SINGH. 0040881665-1

I, Shahnaz Parveen Ahmad, W/o-Zeeshan Ali, R/O A-208, Ireo The Grand Arch Sector-58, Gurgaon (Haryana)-122011, have changed my name to Shehnaz Parveen for all Purposes. 0040881675-5

I, Hahnaz Begum W/o Sauktali Vll Malmal Po Malmal Madhubani Bihar-847229 have changed my name to Sahnaz Begam 0040881681-10

I, KISHOR KUMAR S/O DHARAM SINGH R/O ER-4 3RD FLOOR, INDERPURI, CENTRAL DELHI, DELHI, 110012 have changed the name of my minor daughter from MITYA to NITYTA for all purposes. 0071063778-1

I, Malini Dhamania D/o Indar Krishen Kapur R/O BW/45D, DDA SFS Flats, Shalimar Bagh, New Delhi 110088, have Changed My Name to Malini Kapur 0040881686-1

I, Rajeshwar Sahu S/o Raghunandan R/O Ward No-7, School Para Banjarjandad, Khadgawan, Post Banjarjandad, Koriya, Chhattisgarh-497335, have changed my minor son's name from Anshkumar Sahu Aged 12 Years to Mayank Sahu forever 0071063858-1

I, Poonam W/o Sh. Surendar Kumar R/O House. No.259, Gali.No.13, Vipin Garden, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059 have changed my name from Poonam to Poonam Devi for all future purposes. 00710638372-1

We, Gautam Naresh (DOB: 06-07-1948) and Usha Naresh (DOB: 05-08-1952), residing at Flat # 80, Binsar Apartments, Abhay Khand-4, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, have changed our names to Gautam Naresh Bhatnagar and Usha Naresh Bhatnagar respectively for social and personal communication purposes, as per Affidavit dated September 30, 2026, sworn before Notary Ms Vaishali Nagpal, Lic No-467, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad. It is explicitly declared that our original legal identities and records remain unchanged, and both names refer to one and the same respective persons. 0040881676-1

I, Ram Dixit S/O Mukta Prasad resident of 220, RPS, DDA Flats, Mansarovar Park Shahdara, Delhi 110032 have changed the name of my minor daughter aged 17 years from Hoshi to Hoshi Dixit. 0050298956-1

I, MAHIMA, D/o Late VINEET KUMAR, R/O C-18, Sector-20, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301, have changed my name from MAHIMA to MAHIMA VERMA, for all future purposes. 0040881681-3

I, hitherto known as Annu Shah, wife of Shri Naresh Shah, residing at H.No. 133, 2nd Floor, Triveni Apartment, Jilimili Colony, Delhi-110095, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Anita Devi. It is certified that I have complied with all other legal requirements in this connection. 0040881608-1

I, JUNEID MOHAMED ANWER CHHAPRA, F/O MUHAMMAD MEHRAN CHHAPRA, R/O 255, GALI IMAMBARA, BASTI HAZRAT NIZAMUDDIN, NEW DELHI-13, HAVE CHANGED MY MINOR SON'S, NAME TO MUHAMMAD MEHRAN, FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES. 0040881686-8

I, hitherto known as Sabita Devi W/o Sikandar sahir residing at PO- Sujayapur, Village- Sujayapur, Buxar, Dhanosi, Bihar- 802117 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Gudiya Devi. 0071063861-1

I, Anita W/O Lalit Vashisht R/O G-7/A, Krishan Vihar, Delhi-110086, have Changed my name to Anita Sharma. 0040881679-5

I, Kavita Bhardwaj, W/o-Ved Parkash Sharma, R/O-45-A, LIG flat, Gate No.1, Gulabi Bagh PO-Malka Ganj, Delhi-110007, have changed my name to Kavita Sharma, for all purpose 0040881665-3

I, Vikram Singh Yadav, S/O-Virender Singh Yadav, R/O-H.No-84, Gyan Villa, Village- Chandpur Ki Dhani, Rewari (Haryana)- 123401, have Changed My Name to Vikram Yadav For All Purposes. 0040881675-7

I, Punya Gupta D/o Anil Kumar Gupta R/O-1504, T-16, Lotus Panache, Sector-110, Delhi-201304, have changed my name from Punya to Punya Gupta. Punya and Punya Gupta both names belong to the same person. 0071063823-1

I, Subhash Chand Sood, S/o-Gauri Shankar, R/O.D-1/59-60, GF, Block D-1, Jeevan Park Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059, have changed my name from, Subhash Chander Sood, to Subhash Chand Sood, for all purposes. 0040881686-10

I, HEMA GHAVRI, W/O RAJNEESH GHAVRI R/O 123 FIRST FLOOR AMOLIK RESIDENCY SECTOR 86 FARIDABAD HARYANA-121002, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO HEMARANI. 0040881681-5

I, MOHD WASEEM S/O RAISUDDIN R/O RC-793 NEW AJANTA PARK KHORA GHAZIABAD U.P-201001 have changed my name from WASEEM to MOHD WASEEM Henceforth I would be known by the name of MOHD WASEEM for all future purposes. 0071063876-1

I, Rahul S/O Manoj Kumar residing at B-212/4 Ground Floor Birta Farm Chattarpur Extension Near Laxmi Narayan Mandir South Delhi-110074 have changed my name to Rahul Singh vide affidavit dated 01.10.2026 at New Delhi. 0050298968-1

I, MOHD ANAS KHAN, S/O ZAHID AKHTAR KHAN, R/O M-90, 2nd Floor, Abul Fazel Enclave, Jamia Nagar, Okhla, South-East Delhi 110025, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as MOHAMMAD ANAS KHAN, DOB 14.01.1997. 0130069926-1

I Shoba Chhetri D/o Dhan Bahadur Karki and W/o Prakash Chhetri R/O Kharkhola, PS- Kangolpuri PO- Kalapahar, Distt- Senapati, Manipur-795122 have changed my name to Anita Devi 0071063864-1

I, DINESH GUPTA, S/O-Anil Shaw, R/O Rc-340 Subhash Park Khora Colony Khora Gaon Ghaziabad Uttar pradesh-201001, have changed my name from DINESH GUPTA to DINESH SHAW For all the future purposes. 0040881679-7

I, MADHU W/o Ashok Kumar Sachdeva R/O Flat No. U and V-Block-31A, GF, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi-110088 have changed my name to MADHU SACHDEVA 0040881665-5

I, Virender Singh Yadav, S/O-Jhabar Singh, R/O-Near Ramsharnam Mandir, Chandpur Ki Dhani, Rewari, Haryana-123401, have changed my name to Virender Singh for all Purposes. 0040881675-9

I Shazain Malik S/O Md Mustafa R/O Ajhwa Ward No-13, Panchayat Saisauna Anchal P S Jokhat, Saisauna, Araria, Bihar - 854329, have changed my name to Md Shayeque 0071063867-1

I, Arun S/O Rajendra Nath R/O E-3/6B, Shatabdi Vihar, Sector-52, Noida, UP-201301, have changed my name to ARUN KUMAR for all future purposes. 0071063819-1

I, Sukshmasa, S/o-Bijender, R/oKhasra No.110/9-A-7, Fimi Road, Near Dayanand Dharam Kanta, Mundka, New Delhi-110041, hereby declare that my minor son, Darsh, has changed his name and shall hereafter be known as, Darsh Lakra. 0040881686-3

I, SANTOSH BAL/SANTOSH DEVI W/O HARISH KUMAR R/O 3285 MAHENDRAPARK RANI BAGH DELHI-110034, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SANTOSH. 0040881686-12

I, Sonu Shrivastav, S/o-Rama Shankar, R/O S-31/138-B Okhla Industrial Area Phase-1, New Delhi-110020, have changed my name to Sonu Shrivastav for all purposes. 0040881675-2

I, RIMPI PAUL W/O DIPANKAR GHOSE R/O A-402 VVIP HOMES GAUR CITY-2 GREATER NOIDA WEST GREATER NOIDA BISRAKH GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR UTTAR PRADESH 201306 have changed my name RIMPI GHOSH for all future purpose 0071063774-1

I, Renu Hooda Alias Renu, D/o-Jagdev Singh Hooda, W/o-Mukesh Kumar, R/O G-43, RE-I, Paprawat Road, Prem Nagar, Najafgarh, Delhi-110043, have changed my name to Renu. 0040881681-7

I, Chhavi W/o Mohit Kumar R/O -3/57, Sec-5, Rajendra Nagar, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Chhavi Singh for all purposes. 0071063854-1

I, V S N R VIJAYA KUMARA, S/O-SIVA SURYA NARAYANA ADDEPALLI residing at Flot No.401, Kubera Heights, Near Srirama Temple, Barampet, Sattenapalli Road, Narasaraopet, Palnadu, Andhra Pradesh-522601, have change my name and, shall hereafter be known as, V S N R VIJAYA KUMAR ADDEPALLI. 0040881693-1

I, KAILASH KUMARI VERMA ALIAS KAILASH VERMA W/O RAJESH BHARDWAJ RESIDENT HOUSE NO-28, SECTOR-7, SONIPAT, HARYANA HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO KAILASH KUMARI. 0040881665-7

I, hitherto known as ROHIT AGGARWAL S/O MAHESH CHAND resident of 530 site 1 vikas puri New Delhi-18, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as ROHIT AGGARWAL. 0040881676-3

I, Sudesh Yadav W/o-Diwan Singh, R/O D-1201, PURI DIPLOMATIC GREENS, BAJGHERRA ROAD, SAI KUNJ, NEAR DWARKA EXPRESS WAY, BLOCK-A, SECTOR-110, Choma(62), Gurgaon, Haryana-122017, have changed my name to Sudesh 0040881675-11

I, UMESH CHANDRA, S/O SHIV NARAYAN SHARMA, R/O A-51B GURU GOBIND SINGH KUNJ TAGORE GARDEN DELHI-110027, HAVE, CHANGED MY NAME TO UMESH CHANDER. 0040881686-5

I, Gurjeet Singh S/O Mahinder Singh Saathi R/O J-120, SF Rajouri Garden, Delhi-110027 have changed my name to Gurjit Singh Saathi permanently. 0040881679-2

I, Sapna Jangra D/o Satbir Singh R/O Jakhdh Khera (42), Hisar, Haryana-125052, have changed my name to Sapna for all purposes 0040881675-4

I, MD ANSARUL HAQUE S/O MD MUSTEQUIM, J-3/1, J-EXTN., SF, LAXMI NAGAR, DELHI-92 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MOHD ANSARUL HAQUE. 0071063777-1

I, MANOJ KUMAR S/O OM PARKASH R/O-CHAUTALA DABWALI SIRSA HARYANA-125101 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MANOJ KUMAR SHIAG 0040881681-9

I, Harish Kumar Arora R/O WZ-16, Plot No. 12, Upper Ground Floor, Shyama Prashad Mukherjee Park, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi - 110018 do hereby solemnly affirm and declare that I have changed my name from Harish Kumar to Harish Kumar Arora. In future I shall be known as Harish Kumar Arora for all future purposes. 0040881627-1

LOST & FOUND

I, Sarika Govil W/o Mudit Kumar Govil R/O P-202, 2nd Floor, Aditya MegaCity, Vaibhav Khand, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, UP-201014 have lost my complete filehaving all original property documents of my flat mentioned above which was purchased by me and my husband from Agarwal Associates (Promoters) Limited by Sale Deed having Book No. 1, Volume No. 13615, from Pages 143 to 182, Serial-18849dated 06/08/2009 and thereafter my husband has given me his 50% of the above mentioned property by Sale Deed having Book No. 1, Volume No. 15242, from Pages 103 to 126, Serial-10295 dated 12/04/2010. If anyone finds it call - 9795039067. 0040881581-1



Match for beautiful Jat Sikh divorcee (Short marriage) 36/5*-3, BDS, DDS., MS Dental Doctor (Seeking Doctor, Engineer, IT professional?), WhatsApp no 936-299-0458, 8544841816 0050298734-1



UJVN Limited
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone : 0135-2763808, Fax No : 0135-2763588
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866, Website: www.ujvn.com

RO No. 908

Office of the Executive Engineer, Project Civil Maintenance-Dakpathar, UJVN Ltd., Dakpathar (Dehradun) invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tenders is given below:
Tender No: 01/EE/PCM-DKP/TN/2026-27, 02/EE/PCM-DKP/TN/2026-27 & 03/EE/PCM-DKP/TN/2026-27
Name of work: 1)'Civil maintenance & repair works of A-Type, LA-Type & PIV Type residences at Dakpathar Colony, Dakpathar Dehradun' 2)'Civil Repair & Maintenance of B-Type Residences of Tons Colony at Dakpathar (Dehradun)' & 3)'Civil Maintenance & Repair works of Dakpathar Barrage, Dakpathar, Dehradun' respectively.
Estimated cost: Rs. 34,78,064.00 (GST Extra) Rs. 34,43,262.00 (GST Extra) and Rs. 27,52,800.00 (GST Extra), respectively.
Date of availability of bid document on website: From 17:00 hrs of 05.10.2026
Last date for submission of bids on website: Up to 17.00 Hrs of 27.10.2026
For fuller & further details, kindly visit e-procurement portal <https://uktenders.gov.in>

E-Tender Notice Dated : 03/10/2026

Executive Engineer
Project Civil Maintenance-Dakpathar

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

PROJECT IMPLEMENTATION UNIT (PIU)-Forest
Uttarakhand Disasters Preparedness & Resilience Project (U-PREPARE)
5TH FLOOR, USDMA Building, 36, IT Park, Sahasrabhara Road, DEHRADUN
Website: www.u-prepare.com; E-Mail: procurement.uprepare@gmail.com

Ref. No.: 111/03A/QR/RFB/PIU-Forest/U-PREPARE/2025-26 Date: 03/10/2026
Request for Bids

The Government of India has received financing from the World Bank towards the cost of the Uttarakhand Disaster Preparedness and Resilience Project (UPREPARE). PIU-Forest, an implementing agency of U-PREPARE intends to apply part of the proceeds for the procurement of goods under the following package.

The bid document in English may be downloaded by interested eligible bidders from the website <https://uktenders.gov.in> from 05/10/2026.

S. No	Package No.	Name of Package	Method of Procurement
1	03A/QR/RFB/PIU-Forest/UPREPARE/2025-26	Procurement for the Supply of 25 Quick Response Team Vehicles for Forest Fire Crew under PIU-Forest, U-PREPARE	Request for Bids (RFB)

BRIDGE

DEALER: South		VULNERABLE: None	
NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ 762		♠ K Q J	
♥ J 8 5		♥ A K Q	
♦ A 10 5 2		♦ K Q 8 3	
♣ K 7 6		♣ A Q 8	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
3N	pass	6NT	pass
pass	pass	—	—

West leads the ten of spades. East wins the spade ace and returns the spade five. Plan the play. To make the four diamond tricks he needs, declarer should gather information about the East-West hands while retaining an entry to dummy to allow for the possibility of double finessing in diamonds against East. No extra entry is needed if declarer decides to play West for four diamonds. Since dummy's only non-diamond entry is the club king, declarer should arrange for the last five cards in the North-South hands to be four diamonds and a club, with dummy's club the king.

THE WEST HAND

♠ 10 9 8 4 3 ♥ 10 9 7 4 3 ♦ 4 ♠ 10 2

THE EAST HAND

♠ A 5 ♥ 6 2 ♦ J 9 7 6 ♣ J 9 5 4 3

If nothing exciting happens when declarer cashes his off-suit tricks, there will be no reason to depart from the usual play in diamonds, cashing the king and queen first. However, as the cards lie East discards on the third round of each major, marking West with five-five in those suits. When West follows suit twice in clubs, that defender is marked with at most one diamond. Therefore, declarer should lead to the diamond ace and continue the suit, planning to finesse. If East splits his jack-nine, declarer can return to the club king to take another diamond finesse.

DEALER: West VULNERABLE: North/South

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ K 10 3		♠ A Q J 8 6 4	
♥ 8 3 2		♥ A 6 5	
♦ 8 7 5 4 2		♦ A Q	
♣ A 3		♣ Q 5	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
—	pass	pass	pass
1♣	pass	2♣	pass
4♣	pass	pass	pass

West leads the heart four. Plan the play.

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

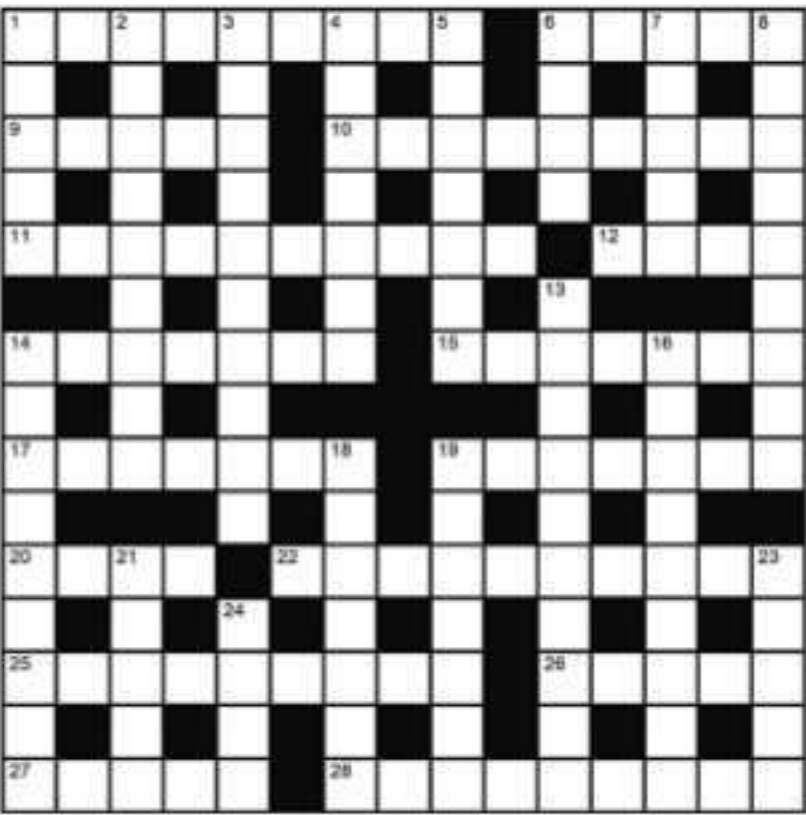
QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- 1. Oppressively (9)
- 6. Folds or pleats (5)
- 9. Air tubes for wheels (5)
- 10. Tetchy (9)
- 11. Firmly implanted (4-6)
- 12. English composer (4)
- 14. Rubber-base paints (7)
- 15. Mogadishu is its capital (7)
- 17. Requitall (7)
- 19. Remove or eliminate (4,3)
- 20. Author Ferber (4)
- 22. New Zealand port (10)
- 25. Tyranny (9)
- 26. Full range (5)
- 27. Respiratory symptoms (5)
- 28. Riddle (9)

DOWN

- 1. Chose (5)
- 2. Solemnly or intensely; wholeheartedly (9)
- 3. Hampered (10)
- 4. Woosers (7)
- 5. At times, wicket taking deliveries? (7)
- 6. Carryall (4)
- 7. Taxi driver (5)
- 8. Not changing (9)
- 13. Strong circumstantial evidence (7,3)
- 14. He sees what one is speaking (3-6)
- 16. Circus performer (4,5)
- 18. Treacle (7)
- 19. Man's figure used as a supporting pillar (7)
- 21. Twangy (5)



- 23. Segmental sclerotic plate on the back of an insect (5)
- 24. Leaps on one foot (4)

- broken tins (4)
- 14. Puts on the level (7)
- 15. Find consonants are given a spell, sir, in a Turkish environment (7)
- 17. One of Lincoln's men who supplied real information (7)
- 19. Splendid garnish (7)
- 20. Gardening tool for a dissolute fellow (4)
- 22. They take folk to court over quarrels, it's obvious (10)
- 25. An impression of turnover, not profit (9)
- 26. Mails mislead going to Muslim areas (5)
- 27. Jumped and broke a plate (5)
- 28. One Sydney

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- 1. When goods are sold out? (6,3)
- 6. After midnight fit to part of the roof structure (5)
- 9. Commanding officer little Nicholas sounds like a chap in good shape (5)
- 10. It might cover one for military retirement (6,3)
- 11. It's difficult on boats if they adopt such a tough attitude (4-6)
- 12. Is not curtailed in

SOLUTIONS TO 2601 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 1 Pesewa, 4 Scarcely, 10 Realistic, 11 Clear, 12 Out of, 13 Axiomatic, 14 Menaces, 16 Grew, 19 Amie, 21 Muddles, 24 Unrelated, 25 Haiku, 26 Dwelt, 27 Reexamine, 28 Meltdown, 29 Syzygy DOWN: 1 Performs, 2 Starting, 3 Whiff, 5 Cycling, 6 Recommend, 7 Ejects, 8 Yorick, 9 Steals, 15 Completed, 17 Fluidity, 18 Astutely, 20 Eatcrow, 21 Madden, 22 Dumdim, 23 Ordeal, 25 Headly CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS: 1 Cosine, 4 Skippers, 10 View-point, 11 Rarer, 12 Ruddy, 13 That's that, 14 Gherkin, 16 Said, 19 Gnaw, 21 Regains, 24 Aunt Sally, 25 Lodge, 26 Valve, 27 Indignant, 28 Archduke, 29 Anchor DOWN: 1 Coverage, 2 Steadied, 3 Nippy, 5 Kit-bags, 6 Perishing, 7 Earths, 8 Sprite, 9 Minton, 15 King's Head, 17 Birdbath, 18 Assenter, 20 Well ink, 21 Riyadh, 22 Latvia, 23 En bloc, 25 Logan

2602

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY OCTOBER 4: This is a year of service for you, perhaps service to family. Take care of yourself so you can be a resource for those who turn to you for comfort, guidance and courage. Is it time for a makeover?

MONDAY OCTOBER 5: This is a year of learning and teaching. Take time for reflection. Explore philosophies that get you closer to the true meaning of your life.

TUESDAY OCTOBER 6: You will reap the benefits and rewards for all your hard work. Expect awards, promotions and acknowledge-ment. Seize opportunities.

WEDNESDAY OCTOBER 7: This is the final year of a nine-year cycle for you. Take inventory of your life. Let go of people, places and things that have held you back. Commune with nature.

THURSDAY OCTOBER 8: This is a slower paced year. Do some internal and external housecleaning. Seize opportunities and reflect on your life.

FRIDAY OCTOBER 9: Take time to rejuvenate your energy. Focus on business and personal relationships, and make sure you hang out with people who have your back, people who are kind and helpful.

SATURDAY OCTOBER 10: Nurture the happiness and beauty you have within. Let your guard down and loosen up a bit. Have fun but remember your goals.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Don't expect much cooperation from others today. This is why you might feel cut off from others or a bit lonely. This is temporary. This Week: Be free to be your creative self.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): If you're working today or dealing with health issues or your pet, you might encounter obstacles. If this is the case, this is par for the course today. Don't make a big deal about things. This Week: Call the shots with home and family.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a tough day for social situations, especially romantic outings, sports events or dealing with your kids. Your best bet is to go along to get along and make as few waves as possible. This Week: Speak up.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Your confidence might be low today because you feel overwhelmed by authority figures in your family. Fortunately, the Moon is in your sign giving you a slight advantage. Furthermore, social outings please you. This Week: Take charge of your financial world.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): It might seem that whatever you try to do today seems to be met with obstacles or objections from someone. Keep your wits about you and pay attention when driving, walking or talking to others. This Week: Have the courage to be who you really are.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Financial issues might be stressful today. Whether earning or spending money, it seems like something will trip you up. It may bet time think about balancing your needs and your obligations. This Week: Look around you and choose a path.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): It's important to get along with others because you value partnerships and close relationships. This is why today is challenging. No matter what you do, you might feel cut off from someone. This Week: Choose friends who expand your world.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): It's a good thing Venus is in your sign smoothing your communication style and making it easier for you to be patient, because issues related to your job, your health and your pet are tough today. This Week: "Damn the torpedoes. Full speed ahead."

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Go gently today. Relations with friends, groups and even your kids are challenging. Take a step back and give the situation some breathing room. Don't force your ideas on anyone. This Week: Travel, learn, expand your world.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Today is not the day to question parents, bosses, teachers, VIPs or the police. Give authority figures a wide berth to avoid conflict or confrontations. This Week: Take your economic freedom.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): You will need all your diplomatic skills to avoid arguments with siblings, relatives and neighbours today. Not only might someone disagree with you, they might want to block what it is you want to do. This Week: Choose friends who respect your individuality.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): This is a poor day to reach a consensus about financial matters because people refuse to agree to anything. In fact, they'll be quick to tell you why you can't do something. Fortunately, your ability to work hard will save you. This Week: Create the job you want.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Wait without __, for you are not ready for __. - T. S. Eliot (7,.,7) (same word twice)

YADOT

EIGHTH

CNUTU

NCEOTG

ANSWER: Wait without thought/ready, uncut, height, cottage

UJVN Limited
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprises)
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, GMS Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax- 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866; Website-www.ujvn.lk.gov.in

पत्र सं०: 907

दिनांक: 03 / 10 / 2026

Short Term e-Tender Notice
Office of the Executive Engineer (CD-II), CDH & NP, UJVN Limited, Dehradun invites online bids from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:-
Tender No.: 01/EE/(CD-II)/LAKHWAR-2026-27
Name of work: Mathematical/Numerical Model Study of Water Conductor System of Lakhtar MPP (300MW).
Estimated Cost: Rs 18,45,000.00/- (excluding GST).
Date of availability of bid document on website: 05.10.2026, from 17:00 Hrs.
Last date for online submission of bid: 21.10.2026, up to 17:00 Hrs.
For Fuller & Further details kindly visit e-procurement portal "https://uktenders.gov.in"
Executive Engineer (CD-II)
"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 (2) (i) Cr. P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita
Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Md. Irfan S/o Md. Hasnain R/o Gali No. 6, near Shani Bazar Road, Bajrang Chowk, Bhalswa Dairy, Delhi** and mother **H.No. A-2/53, Gali No.7, Rajiv Nagar, Bhalswa Dairy, Delhi** also at: Vill. Bandi Naniyara Manjhawali, PS: Neem Chowk Bathauli, Distt. Gaya, Bihar, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **Case/FIR No. 734/2025 Dt.13.11.2025 U/s 74/351(2) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita and 10/21 POC SO Act.,** has been registered at **PS: Bhalswa Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Md. Irfan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Md. Irfan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Md. Irfan** of under **Case/FIR No. 734/2025 Dt.13.11.2025 U/s 74/351(2) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita and 10/21 POC SO Act.,** Registered at: **PS: Bhalswa Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.11.2026.**
By Order
Ms. Pooja Jain
DP/14029/ON/2026 **Ld. ASJ-05 (POCSO), Room No. 302**
(Court Notice) **Rohini Courts, Delhi**

वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक का कार्यालय, रॉकी सर्वसाधारण के लिए सूचना

नाम—जॉन मिंज,
उम्र—14 वर्ष,
उंचाई—4 फीट 2 ईंच,
रंग—साँवला,
पहनावा—काला रंग का टी शर्ट एवं जींस पैट पहने हुए है।

उपरोक्त लापता व्यक्ति जॉन मिंज, उम्र—14 वर्ष, पिता—आजाद मिंज, ग्राम—हिसरो, थाना—रातु, जिला—रॉकी जो दिनांक—11.07.2023 से लापता जो आजतक अपने घर वापस नहीं आए हैं। जिसके संबंध में रातु थाना काण्ड सं०—322 / 2023, दिनांक—01.08.2023, धारा—363 मा०द०वि० / 34 दर्ज कर इनकी खोजबीन की जा रही है। उपरोक्त सूचना को सार्वजनिक किया जाना आवश्यक है।
अतः सभी जनसाधारण से अनुरोध है कि यदि उपरोक्त लापता व्यक्ति कहीं मिलता / दिखता है तो इसके संबंध में वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक के कार्यालय में या निम्नांकित फोन नम्बर पर संपर्क कर इसकी सूचना दें।
(Email ID)(mrc-dcb@jhpolic.gov.in)
पुलिस उपाधीक्षक, मु०, द्वितीय, रॉकी। — 9431706142
थाना प्रमारी, रातु, रॉकी। — 9431706175
आवेदक आजाद मिंज। — 9263268725

वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक, रॉकी

PR 391063 Police(26-27)#D

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 CrPC
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Yogeshwari W/o Manoj Kumar R/o 76B, Gharonda Neem Ka Bangar, Patparganj Village Near Jain Mandir, Delhi-110091,** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC NI Act - 1006/2022, U/S 138 NI Act, PS Pandav Nagar, East Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Yogeshwari** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Yogeshwari** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant);
Proclamation is hereby made that **Yogeshwari** the said accused of **CC NI Act - 1006/2022, U/S 138 NI Act, PS Pandav Nagar, East Distt., Delhi,** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.11.2026**
By Order
Ms. Shraddha Tripathi
Judicial Magistrate First Class (NI Act)-02
(East), Court No. 407, NCB
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/14076/ED/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Dinesh S/o Rammehar R/o Village Sultan Pur, Tehsil Hansi, Distt. Hissar, Haryana** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 837/2025, U/s 74/75/76/79/115(2) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Jahangir Puri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Dinesh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Dinesh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Dinesh** of case **FIR No. 837/2025, U/s 74/75/76/79/115(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Jahangir Puri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **03.11.2026.**
By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
DP/13967/NW/2026 **JMFCC, Room No. 6, Ground Floor**
(Court Matter) **Rohini Courts, Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr.PC)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Jaspal, S/o Ranvir Singh R/o Patri Hamdard Chowk, Asaf Ali Road, Kamla Market, Central, Delhi, India** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.414/2021 u/s 379/411/356 IPC, P.S. Kamla Market, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Jaspal** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Jaspal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Jaspal of FIR No.414/2021 u/s 379/411/356 IPC, P.S. Kamla Market, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **04.11.2026.**
By Order
Sh. Aakash Mohan Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-12
(Central), Room No. 264, 2nd Floor
DP/14059/CD/2026 **Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Diwakar Kumar S/o Shiv Narayan Singh R/o C-565, DDA Colony, Khyala West Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 613/2021 U/s 33/38/58 Delhi Excise Act at PS: Khyala, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Diwakar Kumar** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Diwakar Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Diwakar Kumar** of **FIR No. 613/2021 U/s 33/38/58 Delhi Excise Act of PS: Khyala, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **21.11.2026.**
By order
Sheetal Rani
Judicial Magistrate First Class-12
West Room No - 152
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/13723/WD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Raju @ Akbar Ali @ Saddam S/o Saeed Mainudin R/o H. No. 1348, Put Kalan, Lakhi Ram Chowk, Kartar Wali Gali, Sultanpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case **FIR No. 505/2020, U/s 363/511/323/506/452/34 IPC, PS Bhajanpura, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Raju @ Akbar Ali @ Saddam** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Raju @ Akbar Ali @ Saddam** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Raju @ Akbar Ali @ Saddam** of Case **FIR No. 505/2020, U/s 363/511/323/506/452/34 IPC, PS Bhajanpura, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **03.11.2026.**
By Order
Sh. Kirandeep Kaur
DP/13704/NE/2026 **JMFCC-01 Room No. 05, 2nd Floor**
(Court Matter) **Karkardooma Courts, Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 82 Cr.P.C.)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **GANESH S/o Narad Mehto R/o WZ-36 & 16C D-1, Posingangpur, Janakpuri & Vagabond Janakpuri Flyover, Janakpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 1237/2922 & CR/CT Case No. 12113/2022, U/s 174A IPC, PS Hari Nagar, Distt. West, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **GANESH** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **GANESH** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **GANESH** of **FIR No. 1237/2922 & CR/CT Case No. 12113/2022, U/s 174A IPC, PS Hari Nagar, Distt. West, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **04.11.2026 at 10:00 AM.**
By Order
Moksha Bains
DP/14079/WD/2026 **Judicial Magistrate First Class-II (West)**
(Court Matter) **Room No. 206, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Amber Pandey S/o Arun Kumar Pandey R/o A-28, Gali No 5, Shankar Marg, Mandawali, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **case FIR NO. 704/2022, U/S 324/34 IPC ACT PS: Mandawli, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Amber Pandey** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Amber Pandey** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Amber Pandey** accused of **FIR No. 704/2022, U/S 324/34 IPC ACT PS: Mandawli, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.11.2026.**
By Order
Sh. Sachin
DP/13789/ED/2026 **JMFCC-03, Room No-16**
(Court Matter) **Karkardooma Court, Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 CrPC
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Nikhil S/o Ajay R/o H. No. F-7/256, W-49, T-Huts, Sultanpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 80133353/2024 U/S 305/331(4)/317(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Raj Park, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Nikhil** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Nikhil** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Nikhil of FIR No. 80133353/2024 U/S 305/331(4)/317(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Raj Park, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **16.11.2026.**
By Order,
Ms. Aakanksha
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
North-West, Court No. 107, 1st Floor
DP/13401/OD/2026(Court Matter) **Rohini Courts, Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sagar @ Totla S/o Late Satpal R/o H. No. 202/2, Near Railway Line, Jawala Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi** as committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence **FIR No. 374/23 u/s 380/411 IPC** at **P.S. Vivek Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Sagar @ Totla** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Sagar @ Totla** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C. has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Sagar @ Totla** accused of **FIR No. 374/23 u/s 380/411 IPC** at **P.S. Vivek Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.11.2026**
By Order: Sh. Mohit Sharma,
Chief Judicial Magistrate First Class, (Shahdara)
Room No. 59, 3rd Floor,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/14067/SHD/2026

{ ASIAN GAMES : SEPT 19 - OCT 4 }

As Asiad closes, India set to finish 4th with last-minute surge

• MEDAL TALLY

Po	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	169	89	83	341
2	Japan	83	95	91	269
3	S Korea	39	43	68	150
4	India	21	27	37	85
5	Uzb'stan	21	25	24	70
6	Iran	19	18	15	52

DAY 15 CAPSULE

Haul: 5 Gold, 2 Silver, 2 Bronze

5 GOLD

• Men's Cricket Team

Shreyas Iyer & co defeated Pakistan by 19 runs to clinch the gold medal.

• Men's Hockey Team

The Malaysia hockey team were defeated 5-1 by India in the final of the hockey event.

• Women's Individual Recurve

17-year-old Kumkum Mohod became the first from the country to win a recurve gold at the Asiad.

• Women's Individual Golf

Pranavi Urs became the first Indian woman to win a Golf individual Asiad medal on Saturday.

• Men's 57kg Freestyle Wrestling

Aman Sehrawat picked up an Asian gold medal to complete's India's most successful wrestling campaign since 1962.

2 SILVER

• Women's Golf Team

The team of Pranavi Urs, Aditi Ashok and Diksha Dagar came in second overall to finish with a silver medal.

• Women's 53kg Wrestling

Antim Panghal lost to 2024 Worlds gold medallist Moe Kiyooka in the final of the 53kg event.

2 BRONZE

• Men's Individual Recurve

Neeraj Chauhan rounded off India's recurve archery campaign with an individual bronze medal.

• Men's 97kg Freestyle Wrestling

Deepak Punia picked up a bronze medal to ensure that India completed their wrestling campaign with six medals.

• BRIEFLY

Indian kurash player Yash fails dope test

INDIAN KURASH player Yash Kumar Chauhan has tested positive for multiple banned substances in a dope sample taken during competition on September 27 in the Asian Games and has been provisionally suspended, the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA) announced. The 24-year-old Chauhan's sample was found to contain at least three banned substances. Chauhan's sample was tested by International Testing Agency, which takes samples and performs results management on behalf of the OCA. PTI

• URS TRULY

Pranavi leaves behind World No. 6 Chinese to script history

Tushar Bhaduri
New Delhi, October 3

THE SIGNIFICANCE of Pranavi Urs' gold medal in women's individual golf – the first-ever for India in the history of the Asian Games – can be gauged by the players she left behind.

China's Yin Ruoning, who clinched the silver after a playoff against Singapore's Shannon Xuan Yin Tan, is ranked world no. 6. Shannon herself was the European Order of Merit winner last year. Six of the top 10 in the world – including five of the top six – hail from Asia. And even though not all of them were in action at the Kasugai Country Club East Course, it shows where the epicentre of the game lies, and makes the achievement of the 294-ranked Indian even more remarkable

Four rounds and 72 holes of golf separates the contenders from the pretenders, and where Aditi Ashok had faltered at the 2023 Asian Games in the final round, the 23-year-old from Mysuru made sure to go the whole hog.

Mihir Vasavda

Nagoya, October 3

THE LAST gold India won was also the easiest.

So easy that, for the final penalty corner, the Indian hockey team had just two players standing on top of Malaysia's D. And even then, Harmanpreet Singh swept into the net. No elaborate variation, no crowding of the circle. Just two players, one set piece and a gold medal that was never really in doubt.

The 5-1 win was an unfussy ending to an extraordinarily complicated fortnight. For 12 days, India had managed only 10 gold medals. Then, with the Asian Games running out of hours, the medals began to pile up. Six golds on Friday. Five more on Saturday.

India finished with 21 golds, 27 silvers and 37 bronzes – 85 medals in all – and, perhaps most significantly, piped Uzbekistan to retain the fourth place it had earned in the last edition. The only rider is an unlikely gold for Uzbekistan in equestrian on Sunday. However, India finished 22 medals

short overall compared to the 2023 campaign. Both India and Uzbekistan finished with 21 golds, but India's two extra silvers made the difference.

The final ranking, though, barely captures the suddenness of the turnaround.

On Saturday, recurve archer Kumkum Mohod was shooting arrows in a contest that felt like a metaphor for India's Games. The 17-year-old had spent the week helping end South Korea's reign in the women's recurve team event. Now, in the individual final, she found herself twice behind Oh Yejin. Twice she dragged herself level. With the title coming down to the final arrows, Oh shot an eight. Kumkum shot a 10. Gold.

A few hours later, golfer Pranavi Urs nearly threw away a three-stroke advantage with a triple bogey on the third hole. The sort of mistake that can unravel a final round. Instead, she responded with birdies on the sixth, 10th and 13th, then held on to win India's first women's individual Asian Games golf gold.

"I purely did it for my parents," Urs said, as her mother



Antim Panghal claimed silver in the women's 53kg event. REUTERS

and father watched her stave off the pressure.

"They're here this week and it was always my mum's dream to have me represent the country and win, and then the national anthem and stuff. That was her Bollywood style, typical Bollywood mum. She wanted all that." Paris Olympics bronze medallist Aman Sehrawat's gold was harder still. He led North Korea's Han Chong-Song 6-1 in the 57 kg wrestling final, only for

the world champion to claw his way back and move 7-6 ahead. Aman, who kept the Asian Games gold as his phone wallpaper, had spent much of the bout defending his left leg. Now, he had a match to rescue. He scored four unanswered points in the second period and walked away an Asian Games champion. Different sports. Different circumstances. The same late refusal to let a Games that had been drifting away end quietly.

OLYMPIC SLUMP OVERCOME

Scars, blood, and finally gold: Aman's long, winding comeback

A year after missing tournaments through illness, Sehrawat beat reigning world champion Han Chong-Song



Mihir Vasavda

Nagoya, October 3

THERE ARE scars on his neck. Blood seeps through his teeth. His lips are cut. Scratch marks run under his left eye, with another just above it. Yet Aman Sehrawat lifts his phone with one hand, shows the wallpaper, an Asian Games gold medal with "I am champion" written on it, while holding the real thing in the other.

Then he talks about motivation. Or the lack of it.

The post-Olympic slump was real for the 57kg wrestler. It wasn't existential, but after the high of Paris 2024, 2025 felt "strange." "I was winning the selection trials one-sided, but felt empty within," he says.

A persistent stomach ache made everything harder. He could not digest what he ate. He missed weight for the World Championship and could not compete in the continental event. At times, even enduring the daily grind of wrestling felt like a chore. And then there was

the mind. "My motivation went down a lot," he says. "I began over-thinking, wondering how I missed tournaments."

The 23-year-old had left Paris with a simple plan for the next four years: to win everything on the way to Los Angeles. Instead, tournaments were going ahead without him. And the more he thought about the ones he had missed, the more the fire dimmed.

On Saturday, in his first competition in the 57kg category since Paris, it flickered back to life. Aman defeated reigning world champion Han Chong-Song 11-7 to win gold, giving India its second wrestling title after Sujet Kalkal opened the account a day earlier.

Han, though, had no intention of letting him ease back into the big stage. He stayed low, darting underneath Aman's hands and snapping at his legs whenever the Indian gave him an opening. Aman had begun beautifully, getting to the legs himself and building a 6-1 lead, but Han slowly changed the nature of the bout. At one point, he appeared to hurt his ankle, only to spring back up and snap at Aman's legs, dragging him into another exchange.

Then the comeback gathered pace. Han kept getting underneath Aman, turning a



Aman Sehrawat updated his phone wallpaper to reflect his Asian Games gold medal. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

final that had seemed under control into a scramble. 6-1 became 6-3, then 6-5, and finally 6-7. Aman had spent much of the bout dictating where the wrestling would happen; suddenly, he was reacting to Han.

Aman resisted the urge to chase the score. Instead, he went back to his opponent's legs. He drove through Han to reclaim the lead, found another takedown soon after and then used a gut wrench to roll the North Korean over, stretching the advantage to 10-7. Han scrambled desperately, but Aman stayed attached. With the clock running down, he drove him towards the boundary and forced the final step-out, which made it 11-7.

There was no desperate

throw, no spectacular rescue. Aman returned to the wrestling he trusted, and once he did, Han could not keep him off. "This medal feels good. But winning a medal is not a big deal," he says. "It's a big deal to retain it."

The 57kg category does not wait for anyone, more so in India, where the depth is intense. "So it's not a small thing to maintain this level," he says.

Perhaps that is why this gold means more to him than other medals. It is proof the road to Los Angeles has not gone off course. "2025 was strange for me," he says. "It's not like my performances were bad. I was winning all the trials at home. I won the 2026 Asian Championships convincingly. But I couldn't compete at the World Championship or the

Asian Championship. I felt empty at one level."

There is little self-pity in the way he recounts it. More frustration, perhaps, at how his stomach derailed a plan he had already made for himself.

Missing the World Championships hurt particularly badly. Aman had an Olympic bronze, an Asian Championships silver and the belief that a world title was within reach. The infection prevented him from making weight, and the opportunity passed.

"I will regret it for a long time," he says. "It was a good time to win the World Championship. Sushil Pehlwan has won the World Championship for India. I felt I had a chance to match his achievement."

Now, after beating the world champion, he looks at that missed opportunity differently. "Koinahi," he tells himself. "Ab jo World Championship hai, woh tere naam hai (Never mind. The next World Championship is yours)."

The Asian Games gold will not recover the year he lost. "But this medal will reignite fire," he says. "Even for the preparation for the Olympics, in fact, this will keep me motivated."

Until recently, the LA Olympics medal was the image on his phone. After the selection trials, he changed it to an Asian Games gold. It was something to chase, something to manifest. Now, with the real Asian Games gold medal in his hand, he will change it back. The LA medal gets the wallpaper again.

• SATURDAY'S NEW HORIZONS

India's five golds on Saturday all carried with them history-defying feats that solidified the progress they've shown.

Archery

Kumkum Mohod became the first Indian recurve archer ever to win an individual gold medal.



Wrestling

Six medals pushed India to its best-ever wrestling haul since 1962.



Hockey

Never had the men's and women's teams won gold together at an Asiad.



Golf

No Indian woman had won an individual golf gold until Pranavi Urs' historic show.



carried the weight of Indian expectations. But the 20 before it tell a more interesting story.

This was not a Games rescued by one sport, one athlete or one golden generation. It was a late avalanche, after athletics, badminton and shooting underachieved compared to the previous edition. Archer who toppled a dynasty, a golfer who survived her own collapse, a wrestler who recovered from one, cricketers who handled Pakistan, hockey players who finished the job.

"That's a big relief for us because how the World Cup went, it was really hard mentally and physically," hockey team vice-captain Hardik Singh said. "(We) stood up at the Asian Games, and we fought in every match. It shows our character, and that's how we are. We want to start strong and finish stronger."

For nearly two weeks, India had looked like a contingent waiting for its Games to begin. Then, suddenly, it did. Ten golds became 21 in 48 hours. And fourth place, which had seemed to be slipping away, was India's again.

India's historic title defence tells tale of triumph and relief



India beat Malaysia 5-1 in the final to seal an LA Olympics berth. AP

Prithish Raj

New Delhi, October 3

AS THE final hooter blew in Gifu Prefectural Green Stadium, India men's hockey team started celebrating after winning the Asian Games gold defeating Malaysia 5-1. The celebration had mixed hues of triumph and relief.

Triumph because the gold medal from last edition was defended and an Olympic berth for 2028 was secured; relief because the win salvaged some pride in an otherwise disappointing year. The gold was historic in the sense this is the first time the Indian men's hockey team have defended their gold medal in the Asian Games.

In the final against Malaysia, it was a near flawless performance with the Indian forward-line scoring five goals past Malaysia. The 14th-minute field goal from Shello Silverius being the only blip.

Skipper Harmanpreet Singh opened the scoring in the 11th minute with his impeccable flick that breached the Malaysian defence but Shello restored the parity in the 14th minute as Indian defence switched off for a moment. Jugraj Singh made it 2-1 in the 23rd minute with another thunderous drag-flick and India went into the halftime with a 2-1 lead.

India penetrated deep inside the Malaysian defence multiple times in the third quarter but the only goal came when Hardik Singh wrong-footed goalkeeper Mat Zalmi to score the penalty stroke.

The Indian team was relentless in the last quarter with seven penalty corners but India converted only one after Harmanpreet scored in the 57th minute, the last nail in the coffin for the Malaysian hopes.

Youngster Shilanand Lakra had already given India a big cushion with a well taken field goal in the 54th minute.

There is nothing much to write about the overall campaign apart from the fact that it was the only way for India to mask the disappointment at the World Cup earlier this year and the poor show in the FIH Pro League.

At the Asian Games, India was troubled in just one game, which was against Pakistan. The arch-rivals produced a thrilling match after ages.

The match just exposed the long-sitting problems in the Indian defence. The Indian defence goes into shell the moment the opposition starts attacking with intensity. Against Pakistan, India were leading 3-0 but went down to 3-3 and constantly lost shape in the fourth quarter before a late strike from Abhishek saved the day.

A team that was deemed fit-test at one point of time now struggles to catch breath at times in the fourth quarter. It was not the case against Malaysia today, but it is there every time the opposition starts attacking in the last quarter.

Coach Craig Fulton's mantra is to defend to win. But the team is winning right now but are not able to defend conceding to the likes of Indonesia and Sri Lanka.

Field goals paucity

India scored 58 goals from seven games in the tournament. The breakup of the goals read 34 field goals, 20 penalty corners, and four penalty strokes.

On paper, the stay looks really good but in reality, India scored those 30 field goals against oppositions like Indonesia, Sri Lanka, and Bangladesh. Only four field goals came against Pakistan, Malaysia and Japan. India had to rely on penalty corners once a quality defence came up against them.

Out of 47 goals against Indonesia, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, and Korea, India scored overwhelmingly 30 field goals and only 17 penalty corners and strokes. But against Pakistan, Malaysia, and Japan, India scored seven penalty corners and strokes and just four field goals.

India needs to find more field goals or more ways to break opposition's defence when things start getting tough instead of relying just on Harmanpreet or Jugraj to score a penalty corner.

All is not lost on the team though. With 2028 Olympics qualification done, the Indian team and coach Fulton have a lot of time on their hands to go back to the drawing board and fix things if they want to continue the Olympic medal winning streak at Los Angeles.

Nevertheless, the gold had many meanings today, for the Indian team it meant salvaging a poor year overall.

Japan Olympic prez criticises Organising Committee



The cruise ship on which some athletes were put up. Not having a Games village led to transportation issues. REUTERS

Reuters
Nagoya, October 3

ASIAN GAMES organisers need to reflect on whether they could have been better prepared for challenges brought by the number of athletes at the multi-sport event, Japanese Olympic Committee President Seiko Hashimoto said on Saturday. Organisers budgeted for 15,000 athletes and officials at the Aichi-Nagoya Games but total registrations rose to around 17,000, forcing a scramble to accommodate the extras. Hashimoto said dealing with the additional competitors had proved extremely difficult, causing inconvenience for athletes. "We must reflect on whether we could have prepared better in advance and take this as a valuable lesson for the future," she told a press conference in Nagoya.

Centralised village

"Rather than a centralised athletes village, there were a large number of different accommodations spread out across various locations, and I understand that this created significant challenges when it came to transportation."

Organisers housed athletes in a mix of hotels, temporary wooden container units and a cruise ship in a bid to save costs. Several national team delegations complained about chaotic logistics, with rooms double-booked or assigned to the wrong athletes, along with transport problems that affected athletes' preparations for competition. Asian Games organising committee Secretary General Satoshi Murate apologised last week for mistakes in accommodation and transport, saying a late surge of athletes and officials had made it difficult to ensure smooth service. "Even for situations that seem beyond our control, anticipating potential issues and preparing for them beforehand is vital to the successful operation of the Games," said Hashimoto, who was the Tokyo Olympics' organising committee head. "Addressing this will be one of our primary tasks moving forward."

“Even for situations that seem beyond our control, anticipating potential issues and preparing for them beforehand is vital to the successful operation of the Games”

SEIKO HASHIMOTO, PRESIDENT, JOC

ASIAN GAMES FINAL

Cricket adds to golden finish

Men's team, boosted by knocks from Tilak Varma and Abhishek Sharma, beat Pakistan by 19 runs to defend title

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, October 3

FOR A long time, India's best-laid plans unravelled when a final came calling. That has changed over the last three years, and the latest evidence came in the Asian Games final, where India beat Pakistan by 19 runs at Japan's Korogi Sports Park to win gold.

The victory was not built around a collective batting performance. It was carried by two very different innings, from Abhishek Sharma and Tilak Varma, with Shivam Dube adding a timely cameo. The rest struggled on a slower turner.

Abhishek set the tone in the powerplay, taking on Pakistan's spinners and quicks, using the depth of his crease and attacking anything short. When Saim Ayub dropped short, Abhishek pulled him over wide long-on. When Ahmed Daniyal bowled back of a length, he swung over midwicket. The left-hander raced to his fifty in 20 balls and was eventually dismissed for 61 off 28, with three fours and seven sixes. Pakistan gave him chances too, dropping him at deep midwicket and surviving another chance behind the stumps, before he was stumped off Arafat Minhas.

His dismissal at 93/3 halted India's momentum as others struggled to get going. Sooryavanshi, who had briefly threatened to take the game away with two sixes off Saad Masood, fell for 15 attempting a reverse sweep against Ayub. Sanju Samson made only two. Ishan Kishan scored 20 from 18 balls, Shreyas Iyer 21 from 24.

India's defence was built around Axar Patel and Washington Sundar, who kept Pakistan under pressure through the first six overs.

Tilak then played the innings that gave India the upper hand once more. His innings was almost the opposite of Abhishek's: he did not try to take the game away from the start, taking his time before attacking once the death overs came. He hit Sufyan Moqim for consecutive sixes in the 18th over, then attacked Ayub with a four and six in the next. His unbeaten 51 off 22 gave India the finish they needed. Dube played his part in that late surge, charging Ayub and striking two sixes and a four in three deliveries in the 19th over. His 27 off 15 gave India another lift before he fell. Tilak and Dube added 62 from 30 balls, changing the complexion of the innings after it had slowed in the middle phase, and helped India end on 211/6.

India's defence was built around Axar Patel and Washington Sundar, who kept Pakistan under pressure through the first six overs. Axar struck twice, while Washington removed Pakistan captain Sahibzada Farhan as Pakistan slipped to 39/2.

Axar made the first breakthrough. Sadaqat miscued a sweep in the sixth over, and Washington completed the catch near the boundary. Axar



Indian men's cricket team takes a victory lap after winning the gold medal. PTI

then removed Usman Khan, spearing a full delivery into middle and leg and forcing a mistimed flick to Dube.

Washington was equally effective; his two overs cost only 13 and produced a wicket. But the grip loosened when Ravi Bishnoi and Abhishek came on. Bishnoi conceded 10 in his first over and 14 in his second, including two sixes to Hasan Nawaz. Abhishek's over cost 10, with Nawaz hitting a six and surviving a dropped catch.

Pakistan reached 76/3 after 10 overs, with Nawaz 26 off 18. The required rate was still above 13, but Pakistan had begun to gather momentum.

Nawaz was the main threat. He attacked the spinners, punished anything short and repeatedly found the boundary as the required rate climbed. His 87-run stand with Saim Ayub gave Pakistan hope before Dube broke the partnership in the 15th over.

Nawaz reached his fifty in 29 balls and was given another chance when Washington dropped a catch off Dube. He kept Pakistan in the contest until the final over, reaching 96 off 51 balls with five fours and seven sixes. Dube's second over cost 16, but he had already removed Ayub in his first. Washington dismissed Abdul Samad

in the 18th, while Bumrah bowled a tight 19th, leaving Pakistan needing 33 from the final six balls. Nawaz hit Dube for a four and a six in the final over, but the medium-pacer held his nerve. After a yorker and two dot balls, Nawaz was caught behind off the final ball, ending Pakistan's chase at 192/6 and handing India another gold at these Asian Games.

BRIEF SCORES: India 211/6 in 20 overs (Abhishek Sharma 61, Tilak Varma 51; Arafat Minhas 2/25) beat Pakistan 192/6 in 20 overs (Hasan Nawaz 96; Axar Patel 2/29, Washington Sundar 2/29) by 19 runs.

IRANI CUP: DAY 3

Smaran stands tall but ROI's batting fails to deliver

Shuvaditya Bose
Srinagar, October 3

"RISHABH BHAI, aaj bas survive karna hai (Rishabh, just survive today)," a fan called out to the wicketkeeper as the Rest of India captain trudged towards the dugout at tea on day three. In the last couple of hours, his team had lost four wickets for 55 runs. Jammu & Kashmir, who won the Ranji Trophy for the first time in February, could see a double within reach. The Irani Cup was there for the taking.

Pant, who was unwell, had walked out to bat with his team in disarray. He gave the fan a small nod that seemed to say he would try.

He did not last. A wild swing and he was lbw in only the second over of the third session. Nine deliveries later, Akash Deep was out.

"Ab toh jaldi all out ho jayenge (they will be all out soon)," the fan said. The statistics were on his side: the two men still to come, Mukesh Choudhary and Mukesh Kumar, have first-class averages of 11 and 8.14.

Two hours later, he stood corrected. Ravichandran Smaran was still there. His unbeaten 126 took the visitors from 197/8 to 306/8 at stumps.

He had done it in the first innings too, scoring 68 when Rest of India were 155/7.

He was matter-of-fact about it. "I've been in these situations a lot throughout my career. Back in Karnataka, in home league matches as well as for the state, I've been in a lot of situations like this. I have the game awareness of how to bat with the tail."

It was his seventh first-class century, in only his 19th appearance, with five sixes and 15 fours. "In these situations, I always want to play aggressive cricket. The fourth innings is always going to be hard for any team batting, irrespective of how the wicket is playing. The plan was to play with positive intent. I knew that as I keep scoring runs, they are also going to spread the field and try different things."

Highest partnership

At the other end Mukesh Choudhary was unbeaten on 9 off 47 balls. The pair's 109 for the ninth wicket is the highest in the Irani Cup.

Smaran credited his partner, and said what might have been. "It was unfortunate that we lost a couple of wickets in the middle. Probably, if I had another batsman out there, it could have been a different



R Smaran remained unbeaten on 126. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

situation and we would probably have a lead of more than 300 runs."

He topped the charts last Ranji Trophy season with 950 runs, yet that was not enough to earn a place in the India A side for the two unofficial Tests against Australia A.

Smaran, 23, is not thinking about call-ups.

"I'm not expecting any call-ups from India A. Honestly, I'm just looking to score as many runs as possible, help my team and win every trophy that we have. I can't think about what

can happen in the future. It's not in my hands. The goal doesn't change. In the Ranji Trophy, my goal is to score 1,000 runs and be back-to-back on the top (of the run-scorers' list)."

Red-ball cricket is not the only format he thinks about. His century in the final won Karnataka a fifth Vijay Hazare Trophy title in 2025, and his T20 strike rate is 155.82.

"It is a very good challenge for guys who want to excel in three formats. In this day and age, T20 has gone to a whole other level, where the demands

are entirely different. You have to get your strike rate to more than 200. As batters who want to play three formats, we also have to evolve and ensure that we are right up there. We have to be in pace with the demands of the game."

Smaran is yet to make his mark in the IPL, but he finds a link between his Sunrisers Hyderabad stint and his red-ball batting.

"Definitely, IPL has improved my game. Even in red-ball games, there are situations where you have to take on bowlers, like today. The white-ball game of mine came into play when I was batting with the tail."

His one let-off came on 104, when Umar Nazir had him lbw off a no-ball. His father, Ravichandran S, and his coach, Syed Zabtiullah, were watching from the stands.

"I'm really grateful that I could get a hundred in front of them," he said. Rest of India lead by 265 runs. The Ranji Trophy champions have won the last two editions of the Irani Cup. Smaran may have just rewritten the script.

BRIEF SCORES: Rest of India 237 & 306/8 (Ravichandran Smaran 126 not out; Sahil Lotra 3/71) lead Jammu & Kashmir 278 by 265 runs.

Rahul's century not enough as Hope rises for Windies



Shai Hope's unbeaten 162 negated KL Rahul's 129 not out. PTI

Lalith Kalidas
New Chandigarh, October 3

THE NEW PCA Stadium was decked up for its first men's ODI, expecting local boy Shubman Gill to extend his dream streak. The law of averages was cruelly overdue after West Indies had dismissed him only once in 241 deliveries in two games. Gill deprived his home crowd of a spectacle. Instead, the day belonged to his counterpart Shai Hope, who watched Gill butcher a 406-run chase from behind the stumps three nights ago in Guwahati. Switching positions three times in six days, Hope went back to his sweetest spot at the top. He made his fifth century against India, his highest score at 162 not out, to power a consolation five-wicket win in an emphatic 352-run chase on Saturday.

The Indian team management ticked off a few boxes on its batting wish-list, through a sparkling KL Rahul century and Rohit Sharma's 92. The bowling unit left more questions unanswered in a botched defence.

Despite a batting order trimmed by injuries, the Windies top order kept Gill's bowlers on their toes, matching the asking rate from the start. India's new-ball struggles eased briefly when Siraj's inswinger castled John Campbell in the fifth over.

The search for able back-ups hit a wall again when Hope and Amir Jangoo took apart debutant Anshul Kamboj in his opening spell. Kamboj had been pulled out midway through India A's first-class fixture in Pondicherry on Thursday as Prasidh Krishna's replacement. He leaked 41 in five overs.

Only a run-out, from Virat Kohli's quick reflexes, looked likely to end Jangoo's 111-run association with Hope. Kuldeep Yadav skimmed without reward, and Naman Dhir emerged as an unlikely wicket-taker with a contentious caught-behind.

Moving up from No. 3 in the previous game, Hope moved smoothly towards his fifth century against India and a second in succession. With few proven hitters in the lower half, an injury to Jewel Andrew and cramps in his legs, Hope slowed down drastically, taking 44 balls without a boundary from 87 to 126. That phase partly dented the chase before the captain waded into the last four overs. Gurnoor Brar and Kamboj traded control for a batch of looseners, and Hope and Gudakesh Motie carted them for eight boundaries in 14 deliveries, which took the chase away.

Earlier, a full reveal of the middle order brought India a fourth century of the series in

KL Rahul, who walked out with the bat for the first time this series. He picked up from where Rohit stopped, after Rohit had braved a sharpened new-ball barrage on length from the West Indies pacers.

Jayden Seales and Matthew Forde combined to tempt Gill into an unusual adventure early on. It took only four consistent length deliveries before Gill impatiently missed a charged slap through cover. Seales pounded the deck harder next time, the angle cramping Gill as he nicked behind his hips to the keeper. Virat Kohli was gone the next ball, his fourth golden duck in over 300 outings, when Seales' vicious in-ducker found the middle stump.

With the pacers' lengths rarely overspilling, Rohit measured his release after a watchful spell and pulled impulsively for six over square-leg in the 12th over, though the vision behind his favourite shot has fluctuated this series.

He had nearly fallen to the stadium DJ's plea for a maximum in the 10th over, miscuing a pull just over mid-wicket. Fifty balls in, Rohit slouched and pumped Alzarri Joseph over the square-leg fence, the same over that produced a reckless heave across the line before a leading edge parried over backward point. The venom of the pacers had dissipated by then, and Rohit switched gears against the left-arm spinners. Vitel Lewis and Gudakesh Motie bled boundaries as Rohit unfurled the sweep, the conventional and the slog, with brutal accuracy. Another abrupt swipe proved fatal, against seamer Keemo Paul's innocuous length ball, and he holed out at deep mid-wicket eight short of a third ton in four innings.

Surviving a string of four dropped catches between his 13th and 69th delivery, Ruturaj Gaikwad's weary half-century held the fort until Rahul shifted gears at five. With dismissive drives off the seamers at regular intervals, he reached fifty in 41 deliveries.

Shepherding the lower order with a calm head, Rahul bought himself vital game time at number five after a patchy England series two months ago. He timed a chilling overdrive towards the close, five sixes in his last 12 deliveries, which reiterated his worth. It still fell short against another keeper-batter's riposte.

BRIEF SCORES: India 351/7 in 50 overs (KL Rahul 129 not out, Rohit Sharma 92; Jayden Seales 3/62) lost to West Indies 352/5 in 48.2 overs (Shai Hope 162 not out, Amir Jangoo 67) by five wickets.

• SELECAO IN CITY OF JOY

India show spark against Brazil in friendly, but result was written in the stars

Sayak Dutta
Kolkata, October 3

THE LAST TIME a world-famous South American star set foot at Salt Lake Stadium, the occasion was marked by unimaginable chaos at the Lionel Messi event late last year, when disgruntled fans took out their ire on the fixtures and fittings of the hallowed venue.

On Saturday, some of the stain was washed away as soon as the Hino Nacional Brasileiro was played. History was made when the five-time football world champions played their first-ever match against India. Though India conceded four unanswered goals, there were encouraging signs from Khalid Jamil's men, especially in the early stages. But the game also

showed how far India still has to go to be considered on an equal footing with the elites.

Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti had said in the build-up to the match that there are no friendlies for the Selecao. Even then, there was scepticism over whether he would risk his big names in a match against the 138th-ranked team, especially with big clubs anxious about the fitness of their star players as the international window comes to a close.

But the Italian fielded a relatively strong side, handing starts to Vinicius Jr, who garnered the biggest cheer from the crowd, Marquinhos and Estevao.

Bright start

The Blue Tigers started

brightly, even going toe to toe with Brazil on occasions with Apuia Ralte coming closest for India when his long-ranger just went dangerously past the Brazilian post.

They were even finding spaces in the visitors' half but in decision in the final third cost them. India also earned four corners in the first half, just one less than Brazil.

The Indian backline, meanwhile, employed the offside trap expertly, limiting the ever-sprightly Vinicius to just one big chance in the early stages, which drew a save out of goalkeeper Gurpreet Singh Sandhu at his near post.

But as the match progressed, Brazil wrested control. The gulf in quality became apparent when Estevao, who had missed



Pedro (L) scored the second goal of the game. PARTHA PAUL

a chance in just the second minute, opened the scoring in the 28th, skipping past Ashique Kuruniyan and smashing his shot past Gurpreet, who got a hand to it but couldn't keep it out.

Pedro doubled Brazil's lead when he latched on to a pass from Estevao and let fly at Gurpreet. The ball went under the keeper's palms and trickled into the net.

Predictable

After halftime, Brazil made as many as four changes, withdrawing Vinicius and bringing on Flamengo's Samuel Dias Lino. Premier League stars and regular Selecao starters Arsenal's Gabriel and Bruno Guimaraes were introduced in defence and midfield respectively. Jamil made three changes as well with

the biggest being subbing off Gurpreet for Prabhsukhan Singh Gill.

The second half followed the same script as the first with India getting two early chances through Manvir Singh and Ryan Williams, squandering both, before Brazil made them pay with a curler from Samuel, making it 3-0 in the 58th minute.

India had a great chance of reducing the margin and scripting a big moment in the 63rd minute, but a goalmouth melee resulted in a Brazilian clearance off the line.

Williams got another opportunity four minutes later when Manvir floated in another delicious ball from the left but the volley couldn't get the desired impact.

Manvir got another chance

of his own in the 74th minute but his shot aimed at the near post went over the bar. Thereafter, the match settled into a pattern in which Brazil poured forward, kept the ball and made the Indians chase shadows.

The Selecao came close to a fourth goal twice in added time as Gill pulled off a spectacular save off a rocket from Vanderson before another effort hit the side-netting.

India, however, could not hold on as Samuel made it four with a low drive, incidentally the last shot of the game, past Gill and into the Indian net.

India were valiant, even making fans believe in moments, but the result, if not the scoreline, was written in the stars as soon as the fixture was announced in July.



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‘Glad I’m still relevant’

Actor Shefali Shah on her debut book *The Audacity of Being*, three decades of acting, relationships and failures

Watching over the City



Suanshu Khurana

ON A day of pelting rain in Mumbai, when the high-rises fade into grey silhouettes, a small slope on Nargis Dutt Road in the ritzy Pali Hill leads one to the storied home of one of India’s most definitive modern poets.

Boskyana, 92-year-old poet and filmmaker Gulzar’s home, sits as a quiet haven amid glass and concrete reaching the sky. The raised road, reminder of a city that has been built several times over, has led the quaint white bungalow to live in a somewhat sunken space, tucked in the past and uninterested in the vertical growth of the frantic world above.

As is well known, Boskyana is named after the poet’s daughter, Bosky (filmmaker Meghna Gulzar). What is little known is that she is named after boski, a prized Chinese silk variety known for being soft and delicate. The idea, however, is from another time and place. Gulzar’s father was a textile trader in Pakistan’s Dina, an unassuming village located along the Grand Trunk Road in the heart of Pakistan’s Jhelum district. The poet once joked that if he’d had a son, he would have named him Lattha (crisp white budget-friendly cotton).

It is the warp and weft of this metaphorical silk that runs through Gulzar’s life, with decades spent spinning language into an artform: making the ordinary feel just as fine, weaving those pashmina-like phrases of love and loss: *Geeli hansi, waqt ke paanv, khwabo ki pudiya, seeli hawa* and *chand ki bindi wali ratiya*, which continue to linger.

A large bust of Mirza Ghalib carved in white marble stands guard at one end of the book-lined, exposed-stone wall in the poet’s living room. A screen divides the study from it. The poet’s voice drifts in from his book-drowned study — a discussion on the matter of his current iPad. He arrives on the other side in his trademark white, starched kurta pyjama, the frame frailer now, hair a shade greyer. But just as he speaks in that familiar, deep voice, the years seem to melt away. “I’ve just changed my iPad. And this old cover didn’t fit. So a new one needs to be bought,” he says, settling on an ottoman.

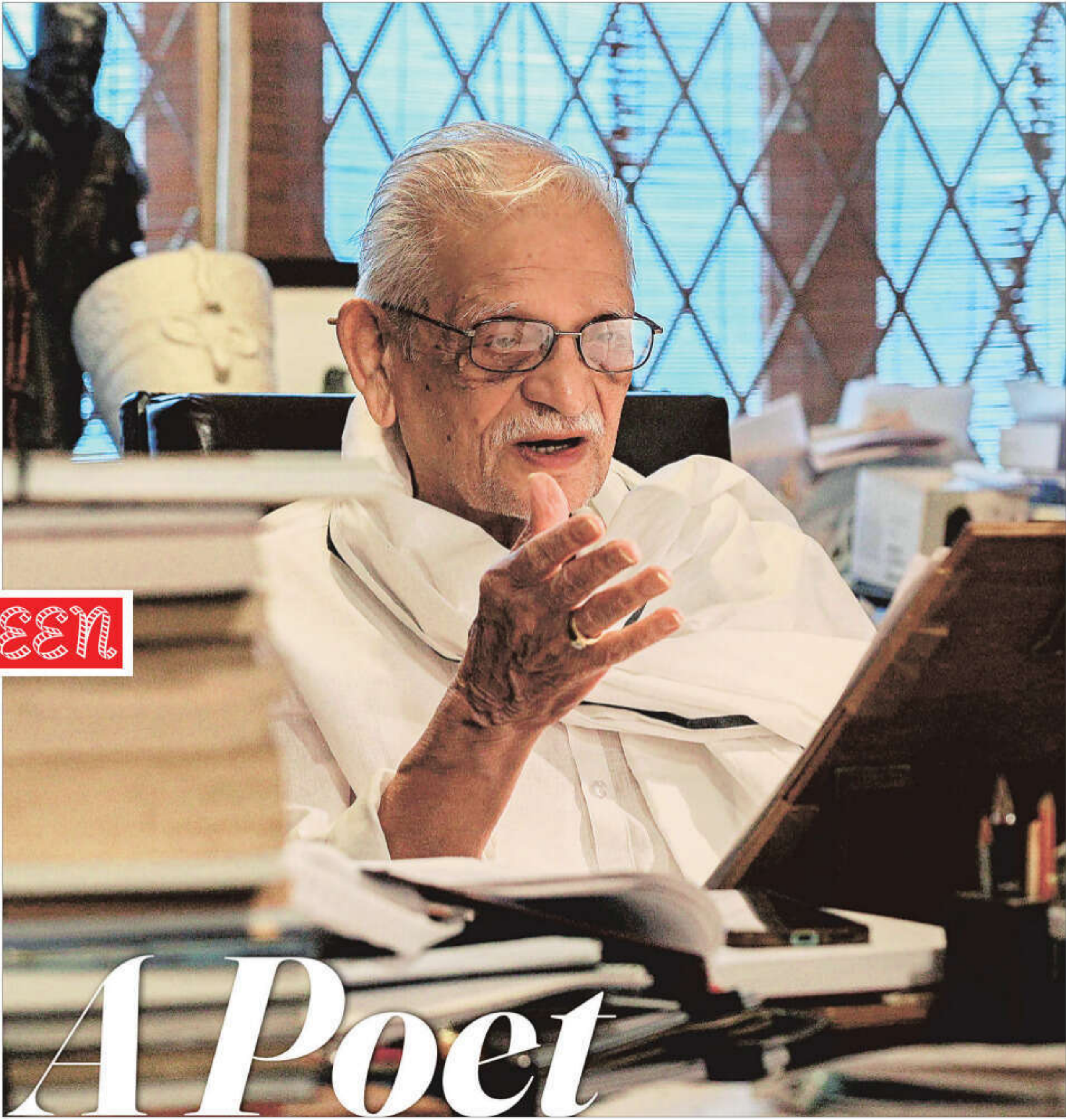
For a writer who has spent decades measuring the weight of ink on paper, it is striking how technology seems to fit seamlessly into this otherwise handcrafted world. Like *Online*, one of his newer stories, where 11-year-old Suhani is telling her grandfather, Mr Syal, to play ‘Patience’ on the iPad and not step out during COVID. There is a hint of Gulzar in it. He may be steeped in the rhythms of the past but has embraced the new phases with curiosity.

SITTING IN Gulzar’s home that is about half-a-century old, four days before his 92nd birthday and clutching his latest book *Aamchi Mumbai: My City in Stories and Poems* (Harper Collins, Rs 3999), with English translation by Rakhshanda Jalil, ‘home’ becomes an obvious subject to open with: one that is built and another that is left somewhere and preserved in memory. Gulzar’s story also has these two homes, ones that have shaped him and his oeuvre, while getting infused into the syntax and cadence of his work. There is one that he left behind in Dina during a bloody Partition, the home that has been a constant refrain in his writing, including *Raavi Paar* and *Footprints on Zero Line: Writings on the Partition* among others. It is also a home he didn’t revisit for a long time. He couldn’t get himself to.

His friend Paul Mahindra, who also assisted “Bimal da” (Bimal Roy), told him not to go back. “He said something which remained with me. *‘Woh badla huya hoga* and those images which you are retaining in your head... when you won’t find them, *toh bohut taqleef hogi*. So I did not go. I was about 70 when I went back for the first time,” says Gulzar, whose visit was prompted by the hospitalisation of Pakistani poet and journalist Ahmad Nadeem Qasmi. Gulzar often refers to Qasmi as his guru.

“When I went to Lahore, my friends and I drove to Jhelum... I found my *gali* (bylane) soon. It was the same as it was. I visited the primary school where we sat on durries and studied. And suddenly I saw a block named after me. The inscription read: ‘Sampooran Singh Kalra urf Gulzar Block’. It was next to another named after Fatima Jinnah. The farmland was gone but someone said of a tree – *‘Ye ped murjha gaya hai, par ye ped abhi tak aapka hai’* (the tree was wilted but it is still yours),” says Gulzar, recipient of the Jnanpith Award and Sahitya Akademi fellowship, among numerous other accolades.

After Gulzar’s family moved to Delhi and he was admitted to United Christian School, their house became almost like a refugee camp. “People would keep coming from our village. Then my father would keep searching the camps to find anyone of his own. He was affected a lot,” says the poet who was packed off on the Frontier Mail to Mumbai that would become “the longest home I know,” he writes in *Aamchi Mumbai*. “What a strange city this is, and how strangely it rears those who come here. It fights and quarrels. It beats and bruises you. But it also gives you the fondness and affection of a friend...” he writes in the book, comprising



SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

SCREEN

A Poet for the Ages

Veteran poet Gulzar on the home he lost, the city he found and all the words in between

his impressions about Mumbai — from its Irani hotels, monsoon rain and ocean to its footpaths and people who live on them.

When Saleem Sinai, the protagonist of Salman Rushdie’s *Midnight’s Children*, returns to Bombay, he says, “Yes, it was my Bombay, but also not mine”, capturing a city transformed by time. Does Gulzar, who has spent seven decades in what Rushdie calls “the most Indian of Indian cities”, feel the same from the time he alighted from the train, a frightened young boy?

He sees the change through an unlikely lens: the disappearance of Irani hotels from everyday Bombay. “Once my toothpaste got over and my elder brother said, go get it from the Irani restaurant. I told him, I need toothpaste, not a pastry. So he told me, for any general store items, go to the Irani hotel,” says Gulzar. The leitmotif reappears through his writing on Mumbai. “Irani hotel was a complete culture in itself. You could go anywhere in the city and find an Irani restaurant. The North has always had places to drink water: a *pyau* (water kiosk) or communal tap. In Bombay, the Irani hotels put out free drinking water. Then, in *chaar aana*, I could have my lunch: keema pav and tea was a full meal. That is what the Iranis were doing here,” says Gulzar, who noticed how leftover food, paid for but untouched, was kept for *fakirs*, for the poor who would queue up at night for what was called the Irani biryani. “*Bhookha koi nahi rehta tha*. As times changed, all of it got lost somewhere. These hotels and that culture are gone. That is what I miss,” says the poet.

He recalls the time when Morarji Desai was chief minister and amidst prohibition, the clandestine, underground bars emerged. “Illicit liquor was available at Pascal ka Adda and Aunty Bars, where alcohol

was served with salt to be licked along,” says the poet. Characters drinking this illicit liquor often appear in his stories, including in *Mez ke Upar*, *Mez ke Neeche*. “The way people lived in *Jhopadpattis*, it was full of life. Poverty was there but you never felt ashamed of it. There was a pride and dignity of life to it,” says Gulzar.

THE CONVERSATION pauses when old friends Sukhwinder and Jyoti arrive unannounced to wish him ahead of his birthday. The room changes colour, with almost a childlike happiness that takes over Gulzar. Not all of it is to do with the bottle of scotch they’ve brought as a present. “*Ay meri dheehai, meri maangi huyi beti* (she is my daughter, my asked-for daughter)” he introduces Jyoti, also his tennis partner. Giddy, with the rare chance to speak in Punjabi with everyone in the room, he introduces us. “This girl is also from Punjab... *te Punjabi bol lendi hai* (she can speak in Punjabi),” he tells Jyoti.

Like the shade of an old tree, Punjabi occupies a prized place in Gulzar’s literary life. It is not just his *ma boli* (mother tongue), but one he was encouraged to return to even as he moved through Urdu’s literary world as a young poet in the Bombay of ‘50s and ‘60s. Filmmaker and writer Balraj Sahni, who had also spent time in Santiniketan, would urge him to attend the meetings of the Punjabi Sahit Sabha. “Balraj saab told me, ‘*Gurudev ne kaya si, madri zubaan ch likh* (Gurudev had told me to write in the mother tongue),’ he says.

Once in Mumbai, Gulzar lived with his elder brother before moving out and making ends meet by working in a motor garage. The two had their differences. “The best part of that motor garage job was that in the time that the paint dried, I could sit



PHOTOS: EXPRESS ARCHIVE



THE STORY OF TWO HOMES (From top) Gulzar; with Lata Mangeshkar; with Asha Bhosle and long-time collaborator RD Burman; on the sets of *Parichay* with Jeetendra and Jaya Bhaduri; Gulzar with Rakhee and Meghna

and read,” says Gulzar, who still regrets having to leave his education at Delhi’s St Stephen’s College, where he studied for a few months before joining Khalsa College in Mumbai. “But they didn’t have Urdu and I didn’t want to study Hindi,” says Gulzar, who soon moved to National College.

Gulzar ended up living in Coover Lodge in Andheri’s Chaar Bangla, where distinguished writer Krishan Chander lived in the main house. Sahir Ludhianvi rented the first floor and he rented the outhouse for Rs 18 a month. Sunday was when the Progressive Writers meetings were held while the Punjabi Sahit Sabha took place on Saturday. It was at these meetings that literature on social inequality, religious hypocrisy and marginalisation was discussed. “Both these associations were very well-knit. Most of the Leftists were there. Poet and lyricist Shailendra was a unionist since he worked in the Railways. As for films, they were never the aim of any of these writers,” says Gulzar, who was pushed into films by Shailendra. “He would say, *achhe khaase writer ho, jaate kyun nahi?*” “All these big writers — Ali Sardar Jafri, Krishan Chander, Rajinder Singh Bedi, Sahir Ludhianvi — *inki kitaabein padhi huyi hain* and seeing them in person as a young boy was huge,” says Gulzar.

Another space he frequented was the Bombay Youth Choir. This is how he met composer Salil Chowdhury, founder of the orchestra, who later collaborated with Gulzar on Hrishikesh Mukherjee’s *Anand* (1971). The choir was interwoven with a certain cultural awakening in post-Independent India.

In National College, his batchmate was writer Sagar Sarhadi and soon literature became a passion. “At that time, if you carried a book on the Russian Revolution, you were considered an intellectual,” he says, with a chuckle. The two were surrounded by Punjabi writers like Sukhbir, “a committed communist”, Harnam Singh Naaz, among others. “This is when Sagar and I took an oath of sorts: we will not take up a job; we will only write. *Aur nahi hai isme kamai toh dekhenge*,” says Gulzar.

That is how the journey began. “People ask me if I was fond of writing since childhood. It’s all a myth. Life takes its own time... to adapt your talents and aptitude,” he says.

He fondly remembers his literary life in Bombay’s trams. How all of his young writer friends would settle on the upper deck of a tram and continue discussions and recitations as the city rolled past. A one-anna ticket allowed them to ride through the day, so if the discussion continued, so did the journey. “From Charni Road to Dadar, *hum afsaane sunaate the...* People turned to listen in; conductors began to recognise us, knew we would turn up on Sunday. It became so interesting. That is the city I have spent more than 60 years in,” says Gulzar.

When American writer Howard Fast’s *The Naked God* came out, explaining why he had left the Communist Party, there was a commotion in our world: “Howard Fast was the only conversation then. When Faiz would write a *nazm* from jail, *ek leher si daud jaati thi*. We’d say, ‘Faiz saab is a very optimistic man, how can he write this’... everything was discussed in great detail,” he says.

Eventually Gulzar found his way into Bimal Roy’s world. His first screenwriting and lyrics credit came with *Bandini* (1963). He would go on to make his directorial debut with *Mere Apne* (1971), about the growing disillusionment among unemployed youth. Decades later, in 2026, its central theme remains relatable. The films that followed — *Parichay*, *Aandhi*, *Maachis*, among others — brought the same literary sensibility to stories of a changing India. As for the songs, his were away from familiar tropes. Gulzar was expanding the vocabulary.

NOT FAR from Ghalib is a harmonium that RD Burman once brought to Boskyana so that he and Gulzar could experiment with music late at night. The kind of partnership where Gulzar would bring abstract, free-verse poetry, and Burman would somehow compose those into brilliant tunes. The non-rhyming, prose-like lyrics of *Mera kuch samaan* (*Ijaazat*, 1987) are a fine example of that partnership. “Tomorrow you will bring a copy of the newspaper and ask me to make a tune out of it,” Burman had told Gulzar before creating one of his most minimalist and haunting melodies. In the poet’s six-decade career as a lyricist, that song remains a masterpiece that broke every known rule in songwriting. Then there was the equation of the material and non-material — *Sawan ke kuch bheege bheege din, khat mein lipti raat...* are the belongings a beloved is asking back from her companion.

A couple of months ago, he wrote a song for India: *Ek akela Hindustani, do mile toh Hindustan*, a “*quami tarana*” (a patriotic song) for today’s generation. The song invokes Hindustan, a term that belongs to an older, more layered vocabulary of the nation. “*Main ‘sa’ ki umr mein tha, aur main ‘ni’ se bhi aage nikal gaya hoon. Ab main upar ka ‘sa’ ho gaya hoon*,” he told a few young music students in Kolkata. At 92, Gulzar now has his own musical analogy for age, using ascending notes of the *alankaar* to describe life. But this ‘*upar ka sa*’ may just be the beginning of another octave. After all, he continues to find words for a changing world. The world where AI may generate Gulzar-like poetry in seconds. But can it live inside those words, or the spaces in between? For that, we’ll always need Gulzar.



DOWN IN JUNGLELAND

BY RANJIT LAL

AUTHOR, ENVIRONMENTALIST
AND BIRD WATCHER



It's a dragonfly's tarsal reflex that makes its wings beat

Dream to Fly, Like Bugs

What makes insect wings marvels of natural engineering

FOR FAR too long, insect flight baffled scientists. According to the laws of conventional aerodynamics, by which birds and aircraft flew, insects ought not to be able to generate the lift or thrust required for sustained flight. They were just too heavy. Then, with the help of extreme slow motion photography and the use of scaled-up models immersed in dense oil, they figured out how they managed to pull it off. Insect wings comprise two layers of chitin in the cuticle: a tough composite material strengthened with structural proteins. They sandwich a network of delicate but tough veins carrying blood and oxygen, besides being flexible and providing structural support and sensory information. The pattern of venation is often used to identify a species. Further, the glistening, often transparent wing, is extraordinarily flexible, twisting about its axis by as much as 45 degrees. Not all wings are transparent. The wings of butterflies and moths are covered with coloured scales, like overlapping roof tiles. They may be broad or long and slim or swept back, like the wings of fighter jets.

Usually most insects have two pairs of wings growing out of their bodies, which may work independently, or which more often are 'zipped' together with hooks to form one large wing. In some insects, like houseflies, the rear pair of wings are reduced to stubs called halteres, which work like gyroscopes. In others, like ladybirds the forewings form hardened elytra, providing a sort of umbrella under which the hind wings fold when not in use.

The wings are powered by tough muscles that may be 'direct' or 'indirect'. Primitive insects like dragonflies and damselflies have direct muscles, one powering each wing, enabling them to beat independently but only as quickly as the nerve impulses command them to. Bees and flies, on the other hand, have indirect muscles that vibrate the entire thorax, enabling the wings to beat at a much faster (over 1,000 beats per second for mosquitoes) rate. Flight muscles consume an enormous amount of fuel and energy and may comprise between 10 and 30 per cent of the insect's weight.

While the wings of birds provide lift and thrust only on the down stroke (the upstroke is usually just a reloading exercise) the flexibility of insect wings, twisting about their axis, enables them to create lift and thrust on both the upstroke and down stroke. The wings create vortexes, along the leading edge — little tornadoes of air — which pull it (and the insect) upwards. If these vortexes grow too large, they would cause the insect to stall, so a pressure gradient along the leading edge causes them to slide towards the end of the wing and drop off, where they create another sudden burst of lift. By deft manoeuvring of the wing tip, the insect can change direction, gain or lose height in a millisecond or even to hover rock steady.

Small insects use another method of creating vortices called the fling and clap (or Weis Fogh) method. Their wings 'slap' together on the upstroke and separate snappily on the down stroke, creating a vacuum to develop into which air rushes and creates a vortex to develop on each wing, which slides across the leading edge, and gets shed during the next 'clap', causing lift and thrust. It does cause more wear and tear but enables vertical take-offs.

Most insect wings are stiffer and thicker along the leading edge and become more flexible towards the trailing edge.

Insect wings are really marvels of natural engineering and we are now trying to emulate them, using flexible materials instead of stiff metal. Planes require engines to provide thrust and aerofoil shaped wings to provide lift. Both insects and birds need just their wings.



The Spoken in THE VISUAL

In her first New York solo at the Museum of Modern Art, artist Nilima Sheikh expands her exploration of displacement and conflict to address climate crisis

Trisha Mukherjee

AMONG THE most rewarding moments in Nilima Sheikh's over five-decade-long career was when the guards at her exhibition in Chicago in 2014 requested to meet her. "They had been moved by my work, comparing it with political events elsewhere," she says.

The exhibition, *Each night put Kashmir in your dreams*, featured works on the cultural legacy of Kashmir and the volatility of its present, a subject local enough to be relegated simply as 'South Asian art', perhaps risking the loss of a nuanced political reading, by a Western audience. But Sheikh has learnt to "never underestimate the intelligence of the viewer".

"A work of art is like music... people who really understand classical music can get something more but it doesn't mean that the ones who don't know so much cannot appreciate it," she says, sitting in her Delhi home, hours before boarding a flight to New York, where her first solo show in the city, *Fractured Skies*, is underway at the Museum of Modern Art (MoMA).

On display are three series: 'Each night put Kashmir in your dreams' (2003-14); 'Home, Land' (2023-25) that looks at the lives of the nomadic Bakarwal communities of Kashmir; and the brand new 'Shahid/Witness' (2025-26), in which she broadens her field to climate change, besides continuing her long standing engagement with displacement and conflict.

It all started when she first saw photographs of floods in Uttarakhand a few years ago. It led her to reading Amitav Ghosh and other literature on the environmental crisis. "Glacial warming is a huge problem in the Himalayas. You see it in the papers now (most recently with Nepal) but it has been so for some time," she says.

As a response, she paints the Simurgh. Baroda-based Sheikh adapts the traditional folk tale from the Persian manuscript, *Anwar-e-Suhaili*, in which the mythical bird saves a sandpiper-couple's nest that has been taken by the sea, into her unique visual lexicon.

In her painting, *Climate Change/Flood 2*, it is the wrath of the river, originating from a melting glacier that sweeps away the sandpipers' nest, and with it trees, boats and human homes. Even as the nest has the assembly of birds flanked by the Simurgh hovering over it, the destruction of human civilisation looms large. In this contrasting image, Sheikh paints the cycle of life, depicting both the precarity of the present and the hope of a renewal.

Here, the sky is the witness. "If there is any sanity remaining, perhaps it is up there," she says, adding that the idea was borrowed from Chinese paintings, particularly the Mogao Grottoes within the Dunhuang caves, which don't treat air as empty space; instead, they use the void to create a whole world.



Sheikh was born into a family that had a legacy in medicine. Her maternal grandfather had founded the Gulab Devi Memor-



ABHINAV SAHA

FINDING HOME (Clockwise from top) *Home, Land 4*; *Climate Change/Flood 2* (*Shahid/Witness*); Nilima Sheikh at her Delhi residence

ial Tuberculosis Hospital for Women in Lahore in 1934 on the request of Lala Lajpat Rai. Both her parents were doctors — father, a physician; mother, a pathologist.

Sheikh attributes her seemingly unexpected affinity for the arts to her parents, particularly her mother, who was also a naturalist. "She was always open to the visual arts and we were taken to museums all over the place," says the 80-year-old artist.

The other determining factor was Delhi's Modern School, where she says the art room was not a space exclusively reserved for art class.

"We had artists Kanwal and Devyani Krishna teaching us. It was unusual for the time to have known artists as school teachers. We also had Narendra Sharma, a disciple of Uday Shankar, who introduced us to the notions of modern dance. At a time when art was not seen as a viable profession, it was a combination of these two enviable opportunities that made going into art as a profession the most desirable thing for me," she says.

She enrolled in bachelor's in history at the University of Delhi, which was followed by a masters in painting from MSU Baroda. Sheikh's art today is a balanced reflection of her learnings from the three stages of her education. *Dying Dreaming* (2007-10), for instance, carries the free-wheeling thought from her formative years in its innovative double-sided hanging scroll-like structure; the juxtaposition of Kashmir's geo-political trauma with its everyday life comes from her understanding of the region's history; and the exquisitely detailed handiwork, similar to the ones in Persian miniatures is a skill honed at MSU Baroda.

Collaboration is inherent to her practice — between the artist and the artisan, between the text and the visual. Quotations from what she reads or her interpretations of them often find their way onto her canvas. In one of the works at MoMA, she integrated the poetry of Miyah poet Shalim Hussain. She also works closely with Sanjhi stencil artists of Mathura to build a visual narrative by layering in her large-scale paintings.

To her, this osmosis of skills and knowledge seems natural. "Why not?" she asks.

"One form of expression need not impinge on the other... they can extend the meaning of the other. I enjoy that very



ARTWORKS: KIRAN NADAR MUSEUM OF ART

much, and I think we are past the modernist phase when the notions about originality were so crucial in one's own style," she says.

In the same vein, traditional forms have heavily informed her work as a post-modern painter — from the structural and narrative language of miniature painting and the technique of using casein tempera (fast-drying paint) on handmade, layered wasli paper to the Chinese and Japanese vertical scroll painting traditions. "During my training with KG Subramanyam, he emphasised on learning visual language rather than acquiring style. With that firmly in my head, I have looked at historical paintings, not only from the point of view of their beauty but also from what I can learn about their linguistics."



There is a palpable sense of both authority and ease when Sheikh talks about Kash-

mir. It's like reminiscing about old times with a confidant. The valley first appeared in her work in 2003 with the solo exhibition: *The Country Without a Post Office: Reading Agha Shahid Ali*.

"I visited Kashmir every alternate year growing up but these were not the run-of-the-mill trips. We did a lot of trekking to areas people don't usually go to... only the nomadic tribes would go there. I feel indebted to my understanding of visuality to these areas," says Sheikh who, along with artist BV Suresh, worked with Kashmiri craftspeople for the mural at the new Mumbai airport in 2014, using papier-mâché and pinjrakari. In that way, for her, Kashmir too is home. And the anxiety of losing it runs through her work. "When you feel threatened, you begin to understand the meaning of home in a slightly different way," she says.

'Glad I'm still relevant'

Actor Shefali Shah on her debut book *The Audacity of Being*, three decades of acting, relationships and failures

Alaka Sahani

IN HER debut book, *The Audacity of Being: A Sort of Memoir* (Bloomsbury), actor Shefali Shah, 53, revisits her life and career with an unusual willingness to laugh at her mistakes, acknowledge failures and examine how certain projects have shaped her. The *Delhi Crime* actor says that instead of a carefully curated version of herself. This is an honest, self-deprecating account of an actor, who over three decades, has continued to evolve.

Even though you have not given a chronological account of your life in *The Audacity of Being*, we still get to know about the evolution of a person and an actor.

What I was five years earlier, I'm not the same anymore. Everyone evolves, right? My working career is 30 years and I am older than that. There is a movement, there is a flow of things. So, if I have evolved, whether for the good or the bad, that is what it comes across (in the book). However, it was not a

You talk about your mistakes, failures or fears. Did you want your readers to take away something from there?

I am figuring out my own life on a day-to-day basis. What works for me may not work for someone else. If they can think there is something in the book that makes them think, or which they can relate to, it means that at least somebody has a chance to read it. What I wanted it to be was honest, self-deprecating almost. I wanted the book to be funny, witty and an easy read. I'm really not here to give *gyaan*.

You have played several interesting characters. What makes Vartika in *Delhi Crime* (2019) special?

Delhi Crime is precious to me. There was



MAKING IT REAL
Shefali Shah

RIDHIKA MEHRA

Do you think we are writing better roles now for women, and women of certain ages today?

I'm glad I'm still relevant. One can do one thing which is phenomenal, and then spend the rest of your life just harping about that. Whether it's a failure or success, I can't hold on to that. I get bored very easily. I have to move on. So, it feels amazing that if a grandmother, a mother and a teenage daughter can relate to and feel that my work is relevant. It's easy to become redundant in today's time.

When you played mother to Akshay Kumar in *Waq: The Race Against Time* (2005), it became a talking point.

Waq played a big part in how my career panned out. It also affected my career. It would be stupid not to accept that.

***The Audacity of Being* is a sort of memoir, not a definitive autobiography. You could have easily skipped the chapter about your first marriage, but you have chosen to talk about it. Why?**

Well, my first marriage is no secret. I think I've written about it respectfully. I'm talking about a marriage falling apart. So it's about the failure of a relationship. Such a thing can probably happen even between best friends. It's just that when you get married, your idea is of a happily-ever-after. That may not necessarily pan out the way you imagined. Then, you have no option but to deal with it.



EVERYMAN: THE STORY OF ECONOMICS IN THREE ACTS
ANTARA HALDAR
Allen Lane
397 pages
₹1,499

Pratap Bhanu Mehta

IMAGINE HOMO Economicus as a full-blooded character. Call him Neo. This character is a utility-maximising, or usually profit-maximising, character — rational, priding himself on a tough realism about the world, assuming everyone acts mostly on self-interest. He sees the world as a series of price points, measures every opportunity cost, and is sentimental about only his unsentimentality. He further believes that everyone acting like this rational actor will, through a miraculous feat of coordination, produce public benefits and untold prosperity. His avatars have a different machismo about them. One is called Finn, a finance bro who uses the power of money to make and unmake worlds; a Davos Man, who dislocates economies in opening them up; or Tek, the guy who believes that boundless technology combined with boundless capital can create a new humanity. All believe that markets will somehow coordinate these machismos.

The outcome will be untold public benefit. But in reality, the world they create is Darwinian: some win, some lose. The losers might want the helping hand of the State, might resent the power of the winner, might even agitate for equality. But in reality, they are whiners, holding back humanity. Imagine further an Everyman, who just might think human beings are more complex: less rational, subject to behavioural influences, not single-minded in their motivations but above all, slightly more decent and capable of cooperation. Not everything has a price; cooperation can produce more public goods and a better society than gladiatorial competition, and demanding a little equality is hardly whining, but the demand of justice. Imagine if these characters collided in a psychodrama in the real world; these social theories became character types who show up in historical crises, from deindustrialisation

Homo Economicus and Other Avatars

Written in part as intellectual history, part fable, Everyman is meant to be an indictment of economics, of a world caught up in its own limitations

to depressions. It would make for a fascinating fable of sorts.

This, broadly, is the premise of Cambridge economist, Antara Haldar’s engaging, *Everyman: The Story of Economics in Three Acts*. Written in part as intellectual history, part fable, *Everyman* is meant to be an indictment of economics, the world of Neo, caught in its own limitations. John Stuart Mill had two critiques of Bentham. Using Carlyle’s memorable turn of phrase, he said Bentham “had the completeness of limited men.” But his second objection was that if everyone thought everyone was only self-interested, we would indeed all become only self-interested. Our construction is self-f fulfilling. Something like this thought underlines Haldar’s fable. Neo does not describe human nature. Neo is a construct we have created and let shape us. Neo is not all bad; there is a kind of tragic cast to him. As one character tells Neo, “You are like Spock from *Star Trek* and we are like Homer Simpson from *The Simpsons*. But I bet it can be hard on you as well — even being the personification of reason — to live up to the ideal.”

But this is the only sympathy Neo will get. Neo is an imperialising figure who has

no answers to deep problems of precarity, inequality, ecological devastation and economic volatility. He is deluded: It is social cooperation and the visible hand of the state that is needed for the public good. But, mostly, he is psychologically stunted: ignorant of the mass of literature in evolutionary biology, psychology, anthropology and behavioural economics that describes human beings in all their complexity. If humanity is to be saved, Neo must be discarded; his conception of a bull run will be a rampage on what it means to be human.

Everyman is inventive in constructing ideas as characters. It is breathtaking in the range of its references. There is a literary bravura in the writing, as metaphors, puns and allusions pile on each other in hurried succession, as Neo and his interlocutors are described in tropes drawn from Shakespeare to Borges. The best sections are the last third, where you get less of an indictment of economics but a representation of the kind of unintelligible pastiche of forces our world has become. As Haldar puts it, this era of superabundant information, “the archive felt like a graveyard of meaning instead of a treasure.”

But Haldar’s Fable works unevenly. Some of the allusions and jokes land; many don’t. The book’s rhetorical power overwhelms its analytical acuity. The blitz of ideas is all dealt in their Twitter versions as it were. The opening intellectual history, where Neo appears as a progeny of Smith, Keynes and Hayek, borders on a caricature of these figures. It is also a punch that does not land. There is almost nothing in *Everyman* that these figures did not know. Even the benighted Hayek was as much a theorist of common law as he was of markets. That “Neo” is at root of all evil is too simplistic; our penchant for cooperation and sacrifice in the form of nationalism can be more murderous and stand in the way of cooperation as much as Neo’s rationality. The conflict between Neo and Everyman is not a conflict between two types: It is a civil war of the soul within all of us. If Neo is all that limited, why did he triumph? The rhetorical excess in the book makes you wonder, to use Shakespeare, as Haldar does: Doth thou protest too much?

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

QUICK VERDICT

HIT Inheritance of Loss

RANBIR SIDHU’s *No One Gets Out Of Here Alive* is a Partition memoir that discusses the death and grief that followed it. The book opens with the death of Sidhu’s father, and then goes back in time to nine months earlier, when his mother died. In their deaths, he looks back at their lives and tries to understand who they were beyond being his parents. Who they might have been had the Partition not happened.

Blending elements of essay, travelogue and history, Sidhu traces the geographical space Punjab, where his parents were born and died, against its history of violence and its demand for a masculinity that deformed the lives of both women and men, equally.

In capturing beautifully the subtle nuances of the parent-child relationship, Sidhu makes the memoir an engrossing and poignant read for anyone interested in decoding the complexities of intergenerational relationships and everything that affects them.

ANUSREE K C

HIT What Lies Beneath

AREFA’S TEHSIN’S *The Fourth Girl* is a feminist mystery thriller telling the story of three women with varied backgrounds: Bhairavi, a Dalit who converted to Christianity; Qailah, a Muslim; and Rajvi, a Rajput. The fourth girl joins their yearly trip to the fictional Sumer forest unexpectedly, and then disappears. The incident changes the course of their lives. Twenty years later, the three meet at the funeral of a famous journalist in Sri Lanka, with another journalist digging up the death.

Tehsin, who has published over 20 novels, grew up in Udaipur, the novel’s base setting. She now shuttles between India and Sri Lanka, introducing the other setting of the novel: Colombo. The author doesn’t shy away from depicting the ingrained patriarchy, the systemic colourism, casteism and classism of Indian society but it is her writing that makes the third-person narrative feel like a first-person one. Every time you think you know something, a new question pops up in your head, and you can’t help but turn the page. *The Fourth Girl* is definitely a relevant read in this day and age.

REVA THAKKAR

Peasant Pasts and Future

Maryam Aslany’s sweeping history of peasants aims to bring them back into the global conversation

Harish Damodaran

DEVELOPMENT THINKERS largely view agriculture, more so peasant farming, as a sector producing too little output and incomes relative to the too many people it employs. The marginal productivity of labour in agriculture — the extra crop harvested from adding one worker on the same piece of land, keeping all other inputs unchanged — is “negligible, zero, or even negative,” as the 1979 Economics Nobel Prize laureate, William Arthur Lewis, put it.

The process of development, according to this world view, entails moving the “disguised unemployed” surplus workforce in farms into manufacturing and other modern “capitalist” sectors, where the marginal productivity of labour and incomes or wages are higher. Such withdrawal would actually be beneficial for agriculture; it allows for economies of scale through consolidation of existing holdings, making them amenable to use of farm machinery, equipment and capital-intensive productivity-enhancing inputs.

Maryam Aslany believes that the above *weltanschauung* — of peasants and small-holder farmers being a drag on progress and incompatible with a modern economy — has been subscribed to as much by advocates of free-market capitalism as by Marxists.

For Karl Marx, peasants were akin to individual “potatoes in a sack”, lacking the collective class consciousness of the industrial proletariat and incapable of revolution: “They cannot represent themselves, they must be represented”. The Bolsheviks went a step further. They, like the American technocrats, embraced a vision of large-scale farming. Worse, agriculture was a source of surplus that had to be forcibly extracted from the countryside to fund the Soviet Union’s ultra-rapid industrialisation. Under Joseph Stalin, peasants were stripped of their landholdings and brought to work on *kolkhoz* collectives or State-owned *sovkhoz* industrial farms deploying armies of tractors and combine harvesters.

Aslany is right that the peasant has all



EXPRESS ARCHIVE

but been “eradicated” in the West. The United States today has only 1.9 million farms that directly engage 1.2 per cent of its total workforce. The average farm size was 466 acres in 2024, with 50.2 per cent of the aggregate value of production coming from those with \$1 million or more in annual gross cash income. The European Union has more farmers (8.8 million) but agriculture’s share in employment is a mere 3.9 per cent.

But this is not so in Asia, Africa and Latin America. Aslany estimates that as many as two billion people live in peasant households worldwide. After 300 years of “modernisation”, peasants still constitute a quarter of our humanity, vastly outnumbering assembly-line workers, miners, taxi drivers or office drones. And more than a third of the world’s food comes from farms under two hectares.

The Iran born-and-raised economic sociologist’s contention is, perhaps, supported by evidence from India. The country has around 100 million landholding farmer families, with agriculture accounting for 43 per cent of its employed labour force in 2025. That’s down from 64.6 per cent in 1993-94, which isn’t significant enough from a Lewis model standpoint. The minuscule rise in manufacturing’s share, from 10.4 per cent to 12.1 per cent, makes it an even less impressive structural transformation story.

Aslany’s book makes two central arguments. First, peasants were key to what she

FROM THE GROUND UP
A sugarcane farmer in Maharashtra



PEASANTS: MAKERS OF THE MODERN WORLD
MARYAM ASLANI
Bloomsbury
352 pages
₹799

calls the “biological order”, when human activity was powered almost exclusively by plants and animals — and the people imbued with knowledge for collaborative relationships with their natural cycles. There could be no states or empires without peasants. They not only supplied food but generated the agricultural surpluses that made it possible for cities to exist and for kings to maintain standing armies and build architectural wonders — from the Egyptian pyramids and the Great Wall of China to the Kallanai Dam and the Angkor Wat temple complex.

Not for nothing that successful rulers valued the peasant and nurtured the agrarian economy by investing in irrigation systems, keeping taxes and levies to a bearable level, and restraining rapacious moneylenders and malicious aristocrats. India’s most fertile and revenue-yielding lands — be it the Indo-Gangetic plains, the Cauvery, Krishna, Godavari and Mahanadi deltas or even the Deccan and Malwa plateaus — were also the ultimate trophies in epic wars, mythological and real.

Second, the transition to an “industrial order” is not seamless. The death of peasant agriculture is a phenomenon highly specific to the US and western Europe. Average farm sizes are small in Japan, South Korea and China. China has brought down the share of its workforce in agriculture from 59.6 per cent to 21.7 per cent between 1991 and 2025. But as Aslany notes, “China is exceptional; it cannot become the general condition”. Not every country can be the world’s factory and today’s factories, moreover, create far fewer jobs than in the past.

Aslany’s sweeping history of peasants not just aims at bringing “the most enduring class of humanity” back into the global conversation. By telling their stories from ground up — through growers of sugarcane, rice, coca and cocoa in Maharashtra, Cambodia, Peru and Ghana — it does so in an engaging manner. Far from being backward and insular, peasants are shown as practical and adaptive to change. Contending with the forces of nature breeds in them innovativeness as much as hardiness and endurance.

Where the book falls short, however, is in offering a blueprint for the future of peasant agriculture. Even in countries where it is far from dead, retaining the best lands and human resources is a challenge for which there are no easy solutions.

‘My curiosity begins in India’

Maryam Aslany on her Pune connection, climate change and why the answer to the rural crisis lies in making the countryside visible again

Sunanda Mehta

You studied in Pune and this is where you became interested in farming communities and their contributions. Tell us more about it.

I came to Pune from Tehran in 2002 for my undergraduate studies in Physics at Wadia College and stayed on until 2008 to finish my postgraduation. Pune was a natural choice as many Iranians come here for higher studies. I went on to do my Master’s at Oxford and a PhD in economic sociology at King’s College, London. But ever since, I have found myself coming back — to India and Pune, which I consider my second home. I often say Pune is the only city where I don’t need a Google map to navigate.

Around 2005, though, I noticed the city changing from the quiet, retirement city it was. Suddenly, it was booming with construction and crowds; migration and malls. Everyone was talking about this change only from the urban perspective but I found myself thinking that surely the change must be there in the countryside too. This, then, became the topic for my thesis: The rural middle class in post-1991 India. So India is where all my curiosity begins.

Was it the familiarity with the terrain that led you to focus on Indian farmers through sugarcane cultivators of Maharashtra rather than, say, the farmers of Punjab or Uttar Pradesh?

Yes, there was a comfort level with Maharashtra and the villages around Pune. I had even picked up a bit of Marathi during my stay, which was a huge help. Initially, I ventured into the Vidarbha region, known for farmer suicides, but then gravitated to western Maharashtra and the sugar belt.

What is your impression of the 2020 farmers protests in Delhi? Are we likely to see more of these?

The 2020-21 farmers’ protests were remarkable, both in scale and in their ability to sustain mobilisation for a long period. The fact that the government eventually had to



SEEING GREEN
Maryam Aslany

FARMERS ARE FIGHTING FROM A POSITION OF ENORMOUS STRUCTURAL WEAKNESS. THAT’S ONE OF THE REASONS GLOBAL CAPITALISM HAS REMAINED SO ATTACHED TO PEASANTS

listen, demonstrated that organised farmers can still exercise considerable political power. Are we likely to see more such protests? I think farmer protests will remain a significant feature of political life.

Farmers are fighting from a position of enormous structural weakness. That’s one of the reasons global capitalism has remained so attached to peasants — it knows it can out-manoeuvre them. They are geographically dispersed, have limited resources and cannot abandon their fields for long. Meanwhile, political institutions, capital, markets and media are overwhelmingly concentrated in cities. It isn’t just a struggle over prices or legislation, it’s a war of ideas, over how urban societies see farmers and the land that feeds them.

Other than sugarcane, what made you choose the other three crops you write about in your book — rice in China, coca in Latin America and cocoa in Ghana?

All three crops are grown by small farmers and are vital supply-chain commodities. Coca — let me compare legal and illegal peasant economies — the leaf itself is legal in Peru but whom you sell it to isn’t. The selection also spans Asia, Latin America and Africa. These crops shape society deeply — be it their family, marriages or land management. Also, despite different ecologies, all these farmers share nearly identical economic and political struggles.

During your travels through these continents, was there any experience that moved you?

I spent quite a lot of time trying to write about the remoteness of these places. Beyond this remoteness, there is a familiar world. I have never seen the degree of hospitality anywhere in the world. One person I was struck by during my field work was Anil, a sugarcane cutter in Maharashtra, who didn’t know how old he was. When I asked about his dreams, he said, “My dreams died when I was born.” He described himself as a knife or *koyta* or a machete, that’s how they are counted as labourers in the sugarcane fields, each hand is a knife, the children are counted as half a knife. I was really, really shaken.

Do you think climate change is the biggest threat for farmers now?

The big threat is actually debt: moneylenders are growing everywhere like mushrooms and are charging astronomical interest rates. The situation of small farmers, anywhere in the world, is a cycle of eternal debt. Climate change enters a system already in crisis and intensifies it.

WATCHING OVER THE CITY

Clock towers may have little relevance now but they are markers of a city, its people and history

Shiny Varghese

FLANKED BY automobile spare parts shops and art framers, a narrow lane leads up to Sabzi Mandi Ghanta Ghar, near Kamala Nagar, in Delhi. Time moves at a different pace as we inch up to the centre of what was once the wholesale vegetable market. Workers who spent languorous hours beneath the tower don't hear the hands of time ticking away. But this clock is keeping time. At 50 ft, with its repetitive *jaali* pattern on its four sides, there is a plaque that calls it the Ram Roop Tower, named after the industrialist of the 1940s, who has also built a temple and schools in the area. "It used to be a landmark when my father sold fruits in the market and later opened RK Dry Fruits, this shop, in 1980," says Rakesh Kumar of the recently refurbished tower. It stands testimony to time, industry and education in the area. As have many such towers over centuries. Recently, the Allahabad High Court questioned the building of one such tower in Firuzabad market in Uttar Pradesh, when it asked: What is the point of building one when people can check the time on their phones and wristwatches? While philosophers have contended about the illusion of time, there have been many attempts to map its transience.

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Gurugram-based horologist Debasish Das, author of *Clock Towers of India: Sentinels of Time* (Niyogi, 2026), has been chronicling the journey of clock towers for over six years. What began as an essay on documenting sun dials in mosques in Delhi grew to become a book that has taken him to different parts of the country, including Kochi, Mumbai, Lucknow and of course, Delhi. "What fascinates me is the constant effort to measure, regulate and publicly communi-

cate something as intangible as time. A clock tower is not merely a machine; it gives time a visible and audible presence in the life of a community," says Das, who is an engineer with Nokia. He recalls his visit to the clock tower in Delhi's old and well-known institutes, Shri Vishwanath Sanskrit Mahavidyalaya. "Everyone spoke only in Sanskrit on the campus. They allowed me go all the way to the top of the clock tower. It's got balconies and a marble canopy, and has to be manually wound every seven days," he says. In his book, he writes, the Indian clock tower was never a single architectural type. Some of them evolved from older gateways, temple structures or civic buildings, others were purpose-built monumental towers, while in princely states they often became expressions of royal patronage and modernity. Their locations were equally varied as well, from markets and railway stations to palace precincts, municipal squares, ports and major intersections. "So, although we use the common expression *ghanta ghar*, the structures themselves represent very different histories and purposes," says Das. While he has documented nearly 150 clock towers across the country, many with the help of friends, he sees how royal and industrial patronage, family ties and the aspirational intent of a city shaped the existence of these towers. For instance, Jodhpur's *ghanta ghar* was built during the reign of Maharaja Sardar Singh, while Sangramsinhji High School Gothic clock tower in Gondal was modelled on the English public schools such as Eton and Harrow. Nestled in many of these towers are stories of their origin. Mumbai's famous Rajabai Clock Tower brings together Western technology and a personal story. Das writes, "Its Victorian Gothic architecture and European clock mechanism were commissioned with the wealth of Indian merchant Premchand Roychand, who



SOMAYA SAMPAT



DEBASISH DAS



SOMAYA SAMPAT

named it after his mother, Rajabai. She followed Jain traditions and would eat only before sunset." Its chimes helped her keep time. Though this is an oft-repeated story, it also points to the city's philanthropic and cosmopolitan character. Das takes us further back in time to the origin of the word itself. He says, "The expression 'ghanta ghar' has its roots in the sophisticated water clocks or ghatika yantras. This was a device, a hemispherical bowl made of a thin sheet of copper, with a fine hole at the centre of its base. When the bowl was placed within a large basin of water, the bowl would slowly sink as water entered through the hole. It was then lifted, emptied and placed back on the water. The bowl sank once every 24 minutes. Since the Sanskrit word for a vessel or pot is *ghata*, the interval of 24 minutes measured by it came to be

THE LONGEST DISTANCE (Clockwise from left) Mumbai's Rajabai Clock Tower; Sangramsinhji High School Gothic clock tower in Gondal, Gujarat; the inner working behind Rajabai Clock Tower

called a *ghati*. Over time, *ghati* evolved into the familiar *ghari*, which is now associated with a clock or a watch. What has been fascinating is that these towers have not worked on the same mechanism. From the water clocks to weight-driven mechanical clocks and later pendulum-regulated mechanisms, depending on the period and technology, they have moved with time itself. "Replacing an original mechanical movement with a cheap quartz mechanism may make the clock functional but it can also turn a living timepiece into a mere façade. When the gears stop turning and the bells fall silent, the tower may still stand but its heartbeat is gone," says Das.

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Many of these towers have clip-clocked

through centuries, sometimes without ever stopping. Like Mumbai-based architect Brinda Somaya found out when her firm, Somaya Sampat, with a team of conservation experts, worked on the Rajabai Clock Tower. "The project demanded research, patience and respect for craftsmanship. Even during the restoration process at a height of 280 feet, the clock continued to function. It reinforced a fundamental principle of conservation: understand the building first, intervene sensitively, and allow it to continue its life without losing its authenticity," says Brinda. Das affirms, "Strictly speaking, we no longer need clock towers to tell the time. Our smartwatches have made the clock tower redundant. But we still need them to remind us where we have come from and to give our cities a sense of place and memory."



Neil Patil
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There is a version of Japan that opens up once you have already done the first trip. Tokyo, Kyoto, Osaka, the essential introduction, is exactly where every visit to this country should start, and it earns every bit of its reputation. But Japan is deep enough that a first trip was always just the opening chapter. Once you have walked Shibuya, seen the temples, and eaten your way through Osaka, there is a second Japan waiting, quieter and slower, built for people who are coming back. I want to walk through three ways into that second Japan, the one worth planning for once the first trip is behind you. How you travel. Where you sleep. Where you actually go. **You Do Not Need to Wait for Someone** There is a word in Japanese for what happens when you sit alone at a narrow wooden counter in Tokyo, order a bowl of ramen, and simply eat it. *Ohitorisama*. Loosely translated, it means honourable person of one. Nobody at that counter is looking at you with pity. Dining alone is not treated as a symptom in Japan. It is a recognised, respected way of being in the world. If you have spent the last decade or two waiting for the right travel companion to materialise, a friend with the same schedule, a partner with the same appetite for long days and unfamiliar food, you already know how that waiting feels. It quietly becomes a reason to postpone things you actually want. Japan is the country that finally gives you permission to stop waiting, not because it is trying to be inspirational, but because it has built an entire culture around the idea that doing things alone is a perfectly reasonable, even a good, way to live. *Ohitorisama* is mainstream enough to have spawned an entire service economy. Solo karaoke booths are designed for one. Restaurants advertise counter seats as a feature rather than an afterthought. Onsen towns offer solo

ryokan packages. Walk into almost any ramen bar or sushi restaurant in Tokyo and the counter seating is arranged with deliberate attention, the chef two feet away, the meal given a rhythm that a table for two would actually interrupt. You are not eating alone in spite of the design. You are eating alone because of it. There is also a fear worth naming honestly, the fear that travelling alone will make you look sad or diminished in the eyes of people back home. That fear is real. But this is the wrong country to carry it into. Japan consistently ranks among the safest countries in the world on the Global Peace Index, and solo female travellers in particular describe it as transformative, a place where walking alone at midnight in a city of nine million people produces no anxiety whatsoever. Being alone in public here is read as a preference, not a problem. Japan also makes the practical side easy. The Shinkansen and urban rail networks are signed in English throughout, and the IC cards, Suica and Pasmo, are loaded with cash at any airport kiosk and tapped at every turnstile in the country, removing the language barrier from transit almost entirely. Google Maps works on Japanese transit with a precision that will surprise you, down to the exact platform and carriage. And the konbini, the 7-Elevens, FamilyMarts, and Lawsons on what feels like every third corner, are where you go to reset when you are tired or disoriented, stocked with hot food, foreign-card ATMs, and more varieties of rice ball than you will manage to try in a fortnight. **Sleep Somewhere That Is Not a Hotel** Today, let me tell you about a version of Japan most of those visitors never get close to, and it costs about the price of a mid-range hotel room. It is called a *minshuku*, and if you have spent time in Japan without staying in one, you have missed something significant. A *minshuku* is a family-run guesthouse, a Japanese equivalent of a bed and breakfast, except the family running it also lives there and probably grew up in the same building. It should not be confused with a *ryokan*, the full luxury version with formal service and elaborate *kaiseki* dinners. A *minshuku* is simply someone's house. The room is small, the floor is tatami, the futon comes out of a closet each evening, and the bathing is shared, a small family-style *ofuro* (a traditional



Japanese soaking bath) you queue for alongside two or three other guests. There is no menu and no room service, and it typically runs five to ten thousand yen a night with dinner and breakfast included, roughly 4000 to 7000 Indian Rupees, all in. The food is genuinely the main event. Stay in a mountain *minshuku* in Nagano and dinner is foraged mountain vegetables, river fish, and handmade soba noodles. Stay on the coast of the Noto Peninsula and it is whatever came off the fishing boats that morning. Meals are often eaten in a shared dining area, sometimes alongside the family themselves, fumbling through a translation app to ask how the soup was made while someone's husband makes a joke you do not fully understand and everyone laughs anyway. No hotel can engineer that. Japan's rural population is shrinking fast, and the people running these guesthouses are often in their sixties or seventies with no children interested in

taking over. When they retire, the guesthouse closes. This is not meant as a guilt trip, just context. The Japan that exists in these small family operations is genuinely not going to be around forever, and staying in one is a way of experiencing it while it still is. **Add Three Cities to Your Next Trip** Tokyo, Kyoto, and Osaka remain the right place to fall in love with Japan, and there is nothing to apologise for in wanting to see Fushimi Inari's torii gates or wander Gion at least once. But precisely because these cities have become so popular, with Japan crossing 36 million international visitors in 2024, they have had to introduce measures like barriers at Fushimi Inari and no-photography zones in Gion just to manage the crowds respectfully. That popularity is a sign the first trip worked exactly as intended. For a second trip, three other Japanese cities offer something wonderfully different, the feeling of being somewhere without any of it being performed for tourists.

Kanazawa, on the Sea of Japan coast, may be Japan's most underrated city, and it is not close. Kenroku-en, one of Japan's three officially designated great gardens, still feels like a garden rather than a photographic backdrop. Nagamachi, the former samurai quarter, is a maze of narrow lanes you can often have almost entirely to yourself on a weekday morning. The city produces around 98 per cent of Japan's gold leaf, and between November and March its Omicho Market serves some of the best snow crab in the country without Tokyo or Osaka prices attached. Matsumoto, in Nagano Prefecture, is built around one of Japan's few original, unreconstructed castles, jet black and set against the Japanese Alps. What makes it work as a destination is that it is a real working city, with coffee shops, jazz bars, and craft sake producers that cater to local residents rather than tourists. It is also the best base for the Alps, with Kamikochi, a protected alpine valley closed to private cars, less than an hour away. Takayama, tucked into the mountains of Gifu Prefecture, is the most architecturally dramatic of the three. Its Sanmachi Suji district is a stretch of genuinely original Edo-era merchant townhouses, not reconstructions, and its daily morning markets sell produce and handmade crafts to locals who happen to be visible to tourists rather than performing for them. Shirakawa-go, the UNESCO-listed thatched-roof village, is fifty minutes away by bus and worth the half day. These three cities connect into a logical seven day circuit, two nights each with a night in Tokyo on either end, linked by pleasant limited express trains through mountain scenery. Accommodation across all three is noticeably cheaper than Tokyo or Kyoto, and shoulder season, late October through November or March before spring holidays, gives the best combination of weather, lower domestic crowds, and reasonable prices. **The Second Trip Rule, Applied to Japan** Travelling alone, sleeping in a stranger's home, and adding a city nobody has mentioned to you before are really the same instinct wearing different clothes. Each one rewards someone who has already done the essential version of Japan and is ready for a slower, less curated one. None of this is a replacement for Tokyo and Kyoto. It is what you graduate to once you love

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them enough to come back. Japan has always had enough depth to reward a second visit more than the first. The essential route gets you in the door and makes you fall in love with the country. Everything in this piece is simply what is waiting for you the next time you go back. **Know the Unknown** Ever since we launched flight bookings on Veena World, I have been falling down rabbit holes about airports. And Narita Airport in Tokyo, of all places, holds one of the strangest stories in aviation. When the Japanese government chose the site for Tokyo's main international airport in 1966, it picked farmland, largely without consulting the families who had farmed it for generations. The farmers refused to leave. What followed was one of the longest, most bitter land disputes in modern Japanese history, decades of protests, standoffs, and legal battles, so intense that the airport opened in 1978 with riot police stationed at the perimeter and every passenger required to show identification just to enter the terminal, a rule that stayed in place until 2015. A handful of farmers never left. One of them, Takao Shito, still farms a small plot of land that sits inside the airport boundary today, his fields reachable only through a tunnel that runs underneath the runway. His refusal to sell forced Narita to permanently alter its design. The airport's second runway had to be shortened, and the taxiway curves visibly around his land to this day, a small green patch of carrots and radishes surrounded on every side by one of the busiest airports on earth. Every year, tens of crores of passengers land at Narita a few hundred metres from a working vegetable farm that the airport was never able to buy. It is, as far as I know, the only major international airport in the world with an active farm inside its own perimeter, still there because one family refused to give up their land. See you next week...

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